

FOR PARENTS OF CHILDREN AGED 2-16

MOBILE ADDICTION IN CHILDREN

A 21-Day Plan for Parents

Child-psychology based · Comics for the whole family · Scripts, worksheets & daily trackers



21 daily steps

21 comic stories

Age-wise tips 2-16

WHO & IAP guidance



Sushma Ma'am

Child Specialist Educator & Child Psychology Expert

Mobile Addiction in Children: A 21-Day Plan for Parents

by Sushma Ma'am

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Important: This book offers educational guidance for parents based on child psychology and published public-health recommendations (WHO, Indian Academy of Pediatrics, American Academy of Pediatrics). It is not a medical diagnosis or a substitute for professional care. If your child shows signs of severe distress, self-harm, aggression, or a sudden change in behaviour, please consult a paediatrician, child psychologist or psychiatrist. In India you can call Tele-MANAS 14416 (free, 24x7).

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Sushma Ma'am

Child Specialist Educator & Child Psychology Expert

- Child Specialist Educator with years of classroom and parent-counselling experience
- Child Psychology Expert – focuses on emotions, behaviour and healthy habits
- Author of the kids' comic "LEVEL UP AI: Defeat the Glitch King"
- Believes in "connection before correction" – firm limits with warm hearts

A letter to you, dear parent

If you picked up this book, you have probably seen it: the blank stare at a screen, the tears when the phone is taken away, the 'five more minutes' that never ends. First, please know this – **you are not a bad parent, and your child is not a bad child**. Phones and apps are designed by very clever people to hold attention. Children's brains are still growing the 'brakes' that adults use to stop.

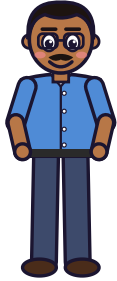
This book will not ask you to throw the phone away. It will help you, step by step over 21 days, to **understand** your child, **replace** screen time with real joy, and **build** habits your family can keep. Each day has a short comic you can read with your child, a clear action, the psychology behind it, and exactly what to say.

Go slowly, be kind to yourself, and celebrate small wins. Your connection with your child is stronger than any app.

— Sushma Ma'am

Meet the Sharma family

You will meet this family in the comic at the start of every day. Maybe you will see a little of your own home in them!



Rohit (Papa)

Works long hours; scrolls news and reels to "relax".



Neha (Mummy)

Loving, tired, sometimes hands over the phone to finish work.



Riya, 14

Social media, chats and late-night scrolling.



Aarav, 10

Loves mobile games; melts down when asked to stop.



Anaya, 6

Cartoons during every meal; cries without the phone.



Dadi

Full of stories and games – the family's secret weapon!



Sushma Ma'am

Your guide – explains the psychology and the plan.

How to use this book

1. Read **Part 1** first (about an hour). Understanding the "why" makes every step easier.
2. Do **one day at a time**. Read the comic with your child, then do the day's action together.
3. Use the "**Say this, not that**" scripts – words matter more than rules.
4. Pick the **age-wise** tips that fit your child. Skip what does not fit.
5. Tick the **21-day tracker** every night. Missed a day? Just continue – no guilt.
6. If you see a **red-flag box** sign in your child, talk to a professional (Part 3).

What the coloured boxes mean



Child Psychology Insight



What Research Says



Sushma Ma'am Says



Say This, Not That



Activity



Age-wise Guide



Red Flag – Seek Help



Today's Win



One promise before you start

Change your own screen habits alongside your child's. Children copy what we do far more than what we say. This is a family plan, not a punishment for the child.

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My 21-Day Family Tracker

Every night, colour one star for each: ★ we did the action · ★ we stayed calm · ★ we had fun together. Put this page on the fridge!

Day 1 Screen detective ★ ★ ★	Day 2 Family meeting ★ ★ ★	Day 3 Screen-free zones ★ ★ ★	Day 4 Digital sunset ★ ★ ★	Day 5 Boredom jar ★ ★ ★	Day 6 Parents go first ★ ★ ★	Day 7 Review & celebrate ★ ★ ★
Day 8 Outdoor play ★ ★ ★	Day 9 Stories & books ★ ★ ★	Day 10 Calm the storm ★ ★ ★	Day 11 Little helpers ★ ★ ★	Day 12 Creative hobbies ★ ★ ★	Day 13 Good screen time ★ ★ ★	Day 14 Week 2 review ★ ★ ★
Day 15 Family media plan ★ ★ ★	Day 16 Tweens & teens ★ ★ ★	Day 17 Safe online ★ ★ ★	Day 18 Self-control ★ ★ ★	Day 19 Study time ★ ★ ★	Day 20 Slip-ups ★ ★ ★	Day 21 Celebrate! ★ ★ ★
🏆 Our reward at the end of Week 1 _____			🏆 Our reward at the end of Day 21 _____			

PART 1

Understand

Why screens hook young brains, how much is too much, and how to tell if your child needs help.



CHAPTER

1

PART 1 · UNDERSTAND

Is My Child Addicted?

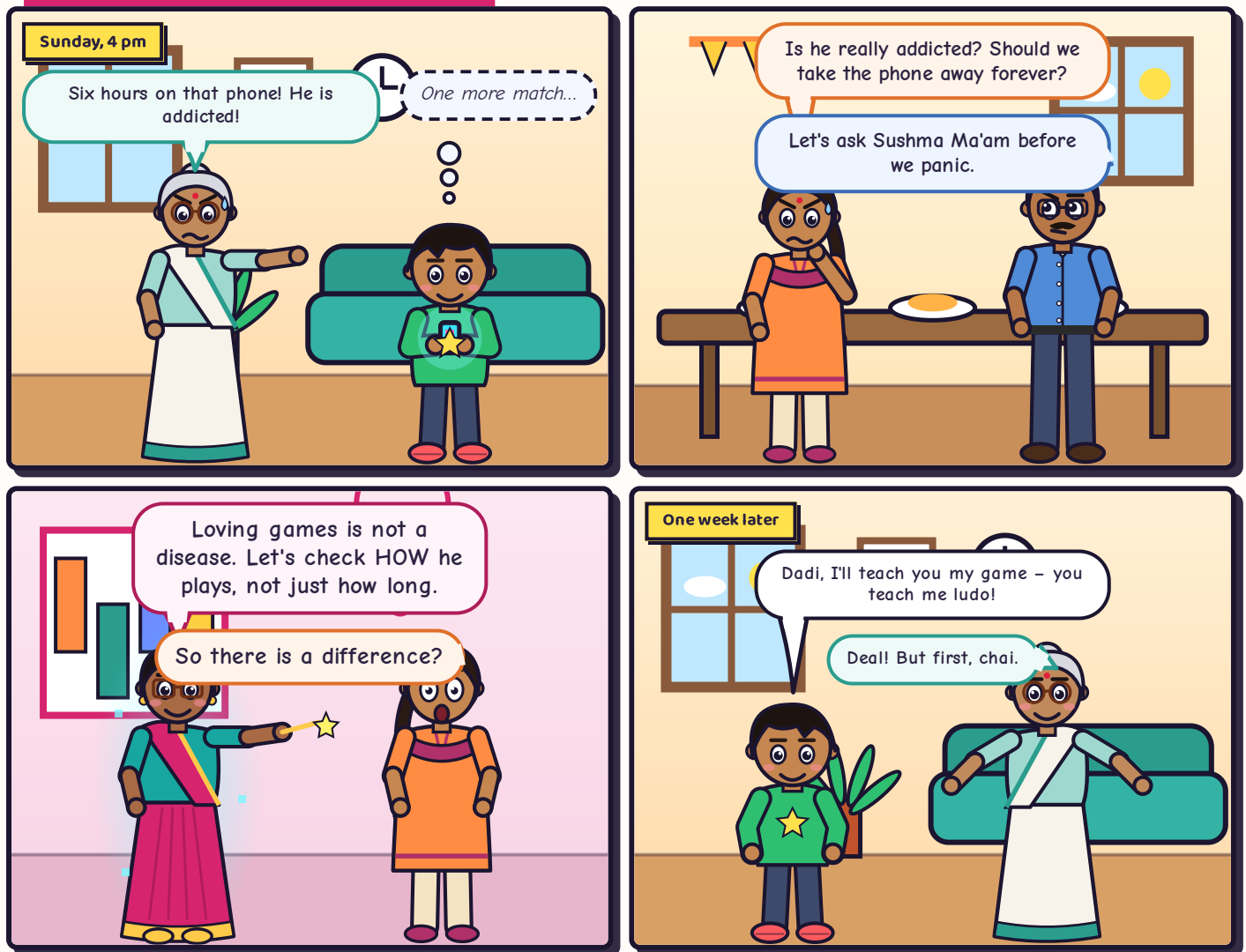
🎯 Tell healthy use, over-use and a real problem apart.

🕒 15 min read

✅ 4 C check



💬 Comic: "This Boy Is Addicted!"



💬 Sushma Ma'am says



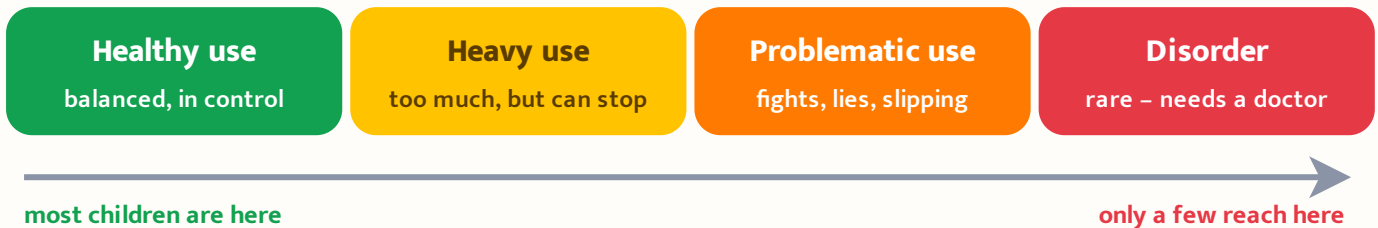
When parents come to me, the first word is often "addiction". I understand the fear. But a label can make us panic and fight. In this chapter we will look calmly at **what is normal**, **what is a warning sign**, and **what really needs a doctor** – so you can respond with a plan, not with fear.

What do people mean by "mobile addiction"?

In everyday talk, "addiction" simply means *"my child uses the phone too much and I can't stop it"*. Doctors use the word more carefully. For them, the question is not only **how many hours**, but **whether the child has lost control** and whether screen use is **damaging daily life** – sleep, studies, family, friendships, mood.

A child who watches cartoons for two hours on a holiday and then happily goes out to play is **not** addicted. A child who secretly plays till 2 a.m., skips meals, lies about it and explodes when stopped – every day, for months – needs more help. Most children are somewhere in between, and that middle zone is exactly where parents can make the biggest difference.

The screen-use spectrum



Your aim: move your child one step to the LEFT – not to zero screens.

Healthy use	Heavy / over-use	Problematic use
Stops when asked, maybe with a little grumbling	Needs many reminders; sulks	Rage, crying, hitting or begging almost every time
Sleep, homework, play are fine	Sleep and homework start slipping	Marks, sleep, friendships clearly suffering
Enjoys other things too	Other hobbies feel "boring"	Gave up sports, friends, hobbies
Open about what they watch	Some sneaking	Lies, hides devices, uses at night

Gaming disorder: what it is – and what it is not

The World Health Organization (WHO) added "**gaming disorder**" to its disease classification, **ICD-11**. This was important, because it told the world that for a small number of people, gaming can become a real health problem. But read the description carefully – it is much more than "plays a lot".

ICD-11 gaming disorder IS...

- **Impaired control** – cannot limit when, how long or how often he plays.
- **Gaming takes priority** over other interests and daily activities.
- **Continuing despite harm** – keeps going even when school, health or family clearly suffer.
- Serious impact on life, usually seen for **at least 12 months**.

It is NOT...

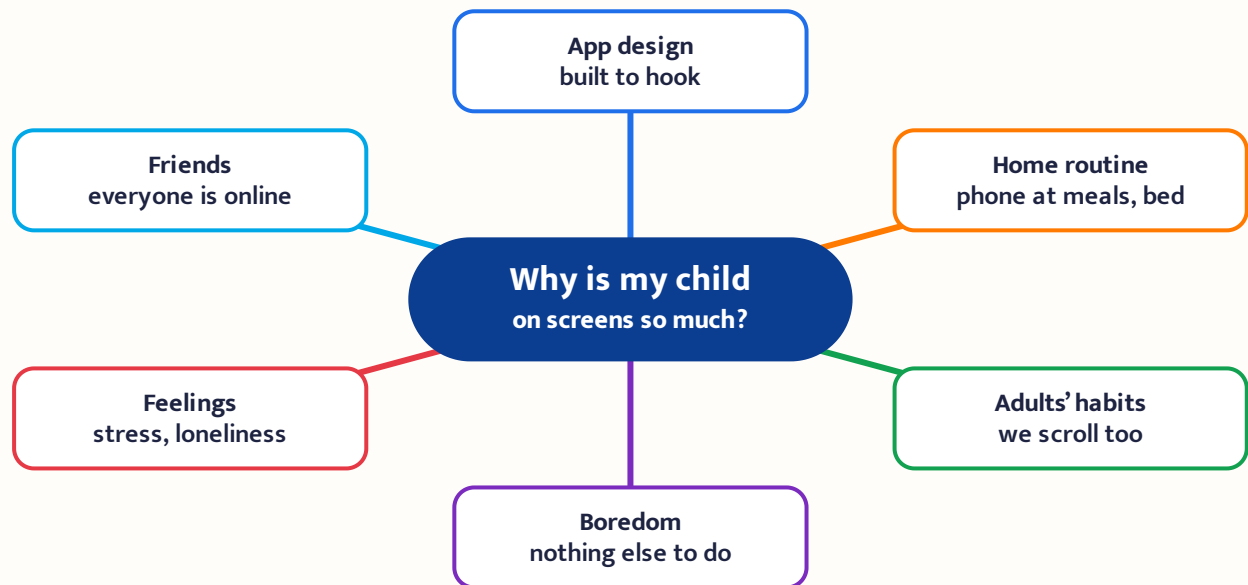
- A child who loves games and talks about them all day.
- A few weeks of heavy use during holidays.
- A diagnosis parents can make at home, or from a quiz.
- A label to shout during an argument.

Child Psychology Insight

Research on gaming disorder suggests that **only a small minority** of people who play games meet these criteria. Often, very heavy screen use is a **sign of something else** – boredom, loneliness, bullying, stress about studies, anxiety, ADHD or low mood. The screen becomes an escape. That is why we always ask *"What is the screen doing for my child?"* and not only *"How do I stop it?"*

A family issue, not a "bad child" issue

Phones were designed by very clever adults to hold attention – and they hold ours too. When a child over-uses screens, it is usually a mix of **the device design, the home routine, what the adults do, and what the child is feeling**. That is good news: it means there are many places where the family can make small changes together.



Sushma Ma'am's 4 C's of healthy screen use

Counting hours is useful, but it is not enough. Over the years with families, I have used a simple check with four C's. **This is my own practical framework, not a medical test** – but it helps parents see the whole picture quickly.

Sushma Ma'am's 4 C's of healthy screen use

C1 CONTENT

What is my child watching or playing? Is it age-right?

C2 CONTEXT

When, where, how long?
Meals, bedtime, homework?

C3 CONNECTIONS

Does it connect him with people or pull him away from them?

C4 CONTROL

Can she stop calmly when time is up – without a war?

Quick 4 C check – tick what is TRUE today

- ☐ **Content:** I know the main apps, games and channels my child uses, and they suit his/her age.
- ☐ **Context:** No screens during meals, in the hour before bed, or in the bedroom at night.
- ☐ **Connections:** My child still enjoys friends, family time and outdoor play.
- ☐ **Control:** When time is up, my child can stop – maybe grumbling, but without a big fight.

4 ticks: healthy base – keep it up. **2–3 ticks:** pick the weakest C and start there. **0–1 tick:** read Chapter 5 and do the full self-assessment.

**Words that hurt – and backfire**

- "You are a phone addict." → The child starts to *believe* it and stops trying.
- "Sharma ji's son never touches a phone." → Comparison creates shame and secrecy, not change.
- Try instead: "The phone is very strong. Let's make a plan together so you are the boss of it."

Three homes, three different pictures

Hours alone don't tell the story. Here are three children, based on situations parents often describe to me (names and details are made up). Who needs what?

**Ishaan, 8 – healthy use**

Watches cartoons for about an hour after homework and plays a cricket game on weekends. Grumbles when the timer rings, but switches off and runs down to play. Sleeps on time. **What he needs:** keep the routine, keep co-viewing.

**Meher, 11 – heavy use**

Since the summer holidays she watches videos 4–5 hours a day. Homework is rushed, she argues about every limit, but she still enjoys her dance class. **What she needs:** clear family rules, a screen budget and more fun offline – the 21-day plan.

**Kabir, 15 – problematic use, needs extra help**

For almost a year Kabir has gamed late into the night, skipped tuition, dropped cricket and stopped meeting friends. He has lied about his marks and once broke a door when the Wi-Fi was switched off. **What he needs:** the family plan **plus** a professional – his paediatrician can refer him to a child psychologist, who will also look at mood, stress and sleep. With the right help, children like Kabir do get better.

Myths and facts

✗ Myth

"Every child who plays a lot is addicted."

"Just take the phone away for good – problem solved."

"Educational apps don't count."

"He'll grow out of it."

"It's the child's problem."

✓ Fact

Most heavy users are **not** addicted. Control and daily life matter more than hours.

Sudden total bans often lead to secret use and fights. Gradual, agreed limits work better.

They are better content, but eyes, sleep and sitting time still count. Breaks matter.

Habits grow stronger with repetition. Early, gentle limits are easier than late, harsh ones.

It is a **family** pattern – routines and adult habits shape it.



Pause and think

Which of the three children above is my child most like today?

Which "myth" have I believed? What will I do differently?



Sushma Ma'am's summary

- Most children who love screens are **not** "addicts" – they are children in a world built to hook them.
- Look at **control and daily life**, not only hours.
- Gaming disorder (ICD-11) is real but uncommon, and only a professional can diagnose it.
- Change the **family system**, not just the child.



Sources & further reading

1. World Health Organization. ICD-11: 6C51 Gaming disorder – description and diagnostic requirements. icd.who.int
2. WHO. "Addictive behaviours: Gaming disorder" – questions and answers. who.int
3. NIMHANS SHUT Clinic (Service for Healthy Use of Technology), Bengaluru – information for families.

CHAPTER

2

PART 1 · UNDERSTAND

Why Screens Hook Young Brains

 Understand dopamine, design tricks and the habit loop.

 15 min read

 Brain basics

 Comic: Where Did the Time Go?

 Sushma Ma'am says


Children don't lack willpower – they are up against some of the smartest designers in the world. When we understand **why** screens pull so hard, we stop blaming and start planning. And our children can learn it too: "It's not you, it's the design."

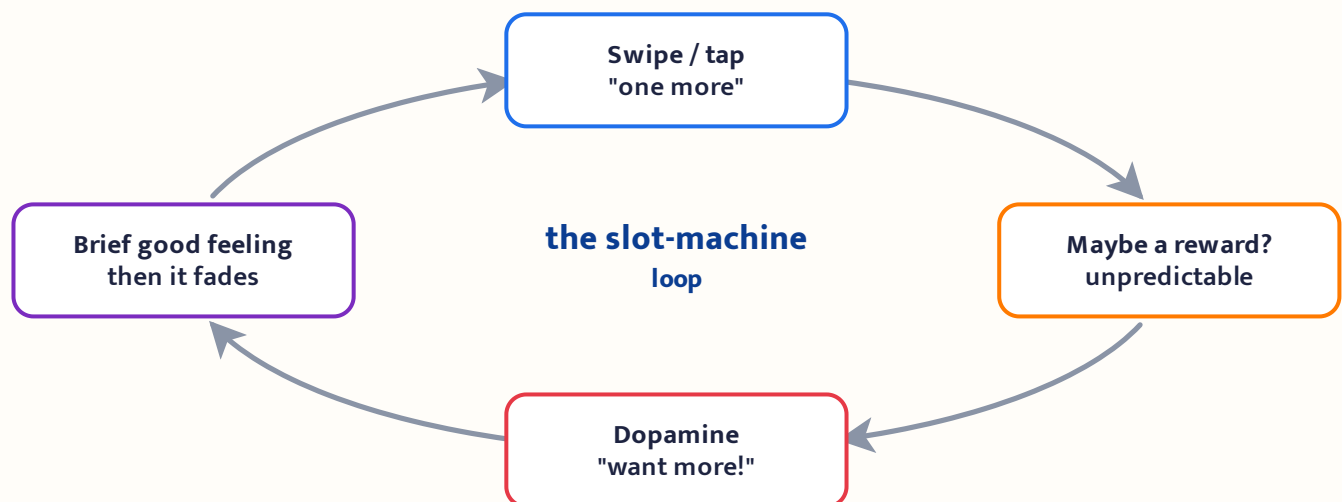
The reward system and dopamine – in simple words

Deep inside the brain is a **reward system**. It uses a chemical messenger called **dopamine**. Dopamine is not exactly a "happy chemical" – it is more of a **"want more" signal**. It rises when the brain *expects* something good: a sweet, a six in cricket, a new message, the next level. It pushes us to go after it.

This system is healthy and necessary – it helps children learn to walk, ride a cycle and practise music. The problem is that phones can trigger it **again and again, in seconds, with no effort**. Real-life rewards (finishing a drawing, winning a match) take time and effort. After a lot of fast phone rewards, slow real-life rewards can start to feel "boring".

Variable rewards: the slot-machine trick

The brain reacts **most strongly to rewards it cannot predict**. If every swipe gave a great video, the brain would relax. But when *some* swipes give something amazing and others don't, the brain keeps checking – "maybe the next one!" This is the same principle as a slot machine in a casino.



Child Psychology Insight

Psychologists call this **intermittent (variable) reinforcement**. Behaviour rewarded unpredictably is the **hardest to stop** – for children and adults alike. That is why "just one more" is so hard to say no to.

An Indian example

Think of a child opening a packet of chips hoping for the free toy, or checking the cricket score every two minutes in a close match. Not knowing **when** the good thing will come is exactly what keeps us checking.



How the hook changes with age

Age 2–5

Bright colours, fast cuts, songs that repeat and autoplay. Little ones cannot "decide" to stop – the adult must decide.

Age 6–9

Surprise videos, unboxing, "levels" and stars. Use shows with an end, and a visual timer they can see.

Age 10–13

Online games with rankings, loot boxes, daily rewards and friends waiting in the lobby. Agree game time before play starts.

Age 14–16

Likes, streaks, group chats and fear of missing out. Talk about how apps make money from their attention.

Design tricks that keep children hooked

Feature	How it hooks	What you can do
Autoplay	The next video starts before the child decides. No natural stopping point.	Switch autoplay OFF in YouTube/OTT settings. Choose videos in advance.
Infinite scroll	Reels and feeds never end, so the brain never gets a "finished" signal.	Use a timer that is outside the phone (kitchen timer, clock).
Notifications	Pings, red dots and vibrations pull attention back again and again.	Turn off non-essential notifications; use Do Not Disturb at study and bed time.
Streaks & daily rewards	"Don't break your 50-day streak!" creates fear of losing (FOMO).	Talk about it openly: "Who gains when you can't stop?"
Loot boxes & surprise rewards	Paying or playing for a random prize – very close to gambling.	Block in-app purchases; keep payment details off children's devices.
Likes & views	Social approval, counted in public – powerful for teens.	Praise real effort at home; talk about "likes ≠ worth".

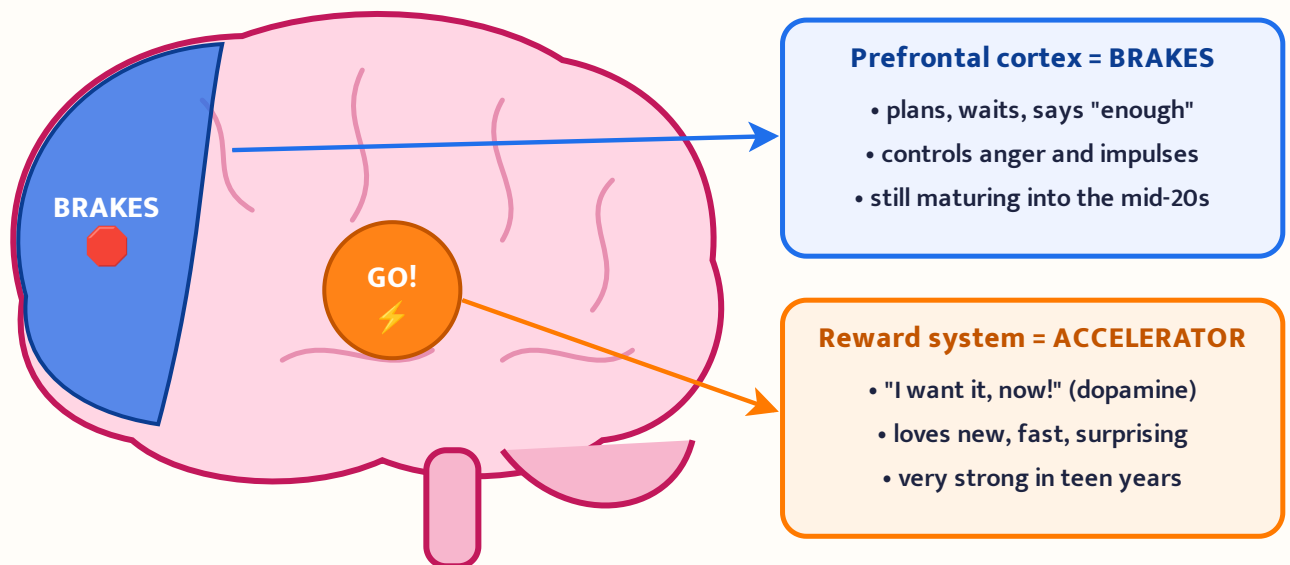


Activity: Be a "design detective" with your child (age 8+)

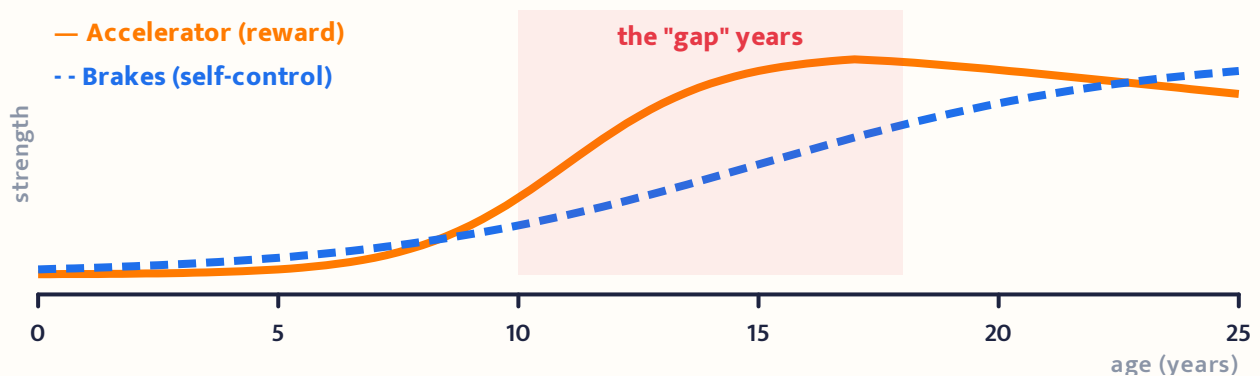
- Open your child's favourite app **together**. Hunt for the hooks from the table above: autoplay, streaks, red dots, rewards.
- Give one point for every hook found. Parents play too – check your own apps!
- Ask: "Who made this, and why do they want you to stay longer?" Let your child answer.
- Choose one hook to switch off together (autoplay, notifications). Children accept limits more easily when **they** spot the trick.

Brakes and accelerator: the growing brain

Think of the brain like a scooter. The **reward system** is the accelerator – it says "Go! More! Now!" The **prefrontal cortex**, just behind the forehead, is the brake – it plans, waits and says "Enough, homework first." In children and teenagers the accelerator is already powerful, but the brakes are **still being built – right into the mid-20s**.



A child's brain: a powerful accelerator with brakes still being built



A simplified picture: the "want it" system gets strong early; self-control keeps developing into the mid-20s.

💡 What this means for you

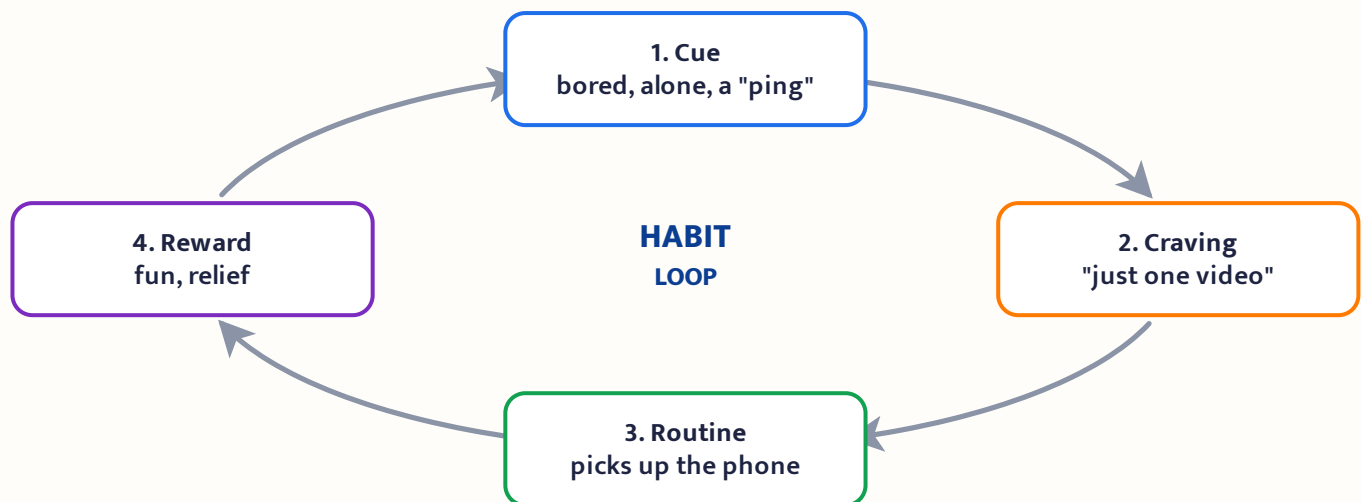
Until your child's own brakes are strong, **you are the external brakes** – through routines, limits, phone-free places and your calm presence. Slowly, as the child grows, you hand over the brakes. Expecting a 10-year-old to "just control yourself" with a device built to beat adult self-control is not fair.

The habit loop

Every screen habit follows the same loop. A **cue** (boredom after school, the car ride, a notification, feeling left out) creates a **craving**. The child does the **routine** (opens the app) and gets a **reward** (fun, relief from boredom or worry). Repeat this a hundred times and it becomes automatic – the hand reaches for the phone before the mind decides.

🌟 How to use the loop

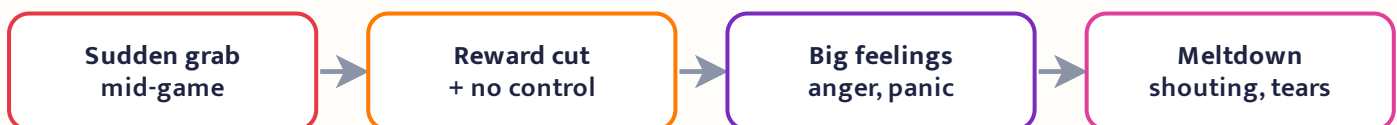
You rarely win by fighting the craving. Instead **change the cue** (phone out of sight) or **swap the routine** (a boredom jar, a ball, a book) while keeping a **reward** (fun, your attention). The 21-day plan uses exactly this.



Loop step	Aarav's example	What the family can change
Cue	Comes home from school at 3:30, nobody around, phone on the sofa	Phone kept in a drawer; snack and a note from Mummy on the table
Craving	"I'm tired – just one match"	Name it: "Your brain wants a break – what kind?"
Routine	Plays for two hours without noticing	Swap: 20 minutes of cricket downstairs or a comic first
Reward	Fun, feels relaxed	Keep the fun: agreed game time later, with a timer

Why taking the phone causes a meltdown

When you suddenly take the phone in the middle of a level or video, the child's brain is at the **peak of "want more"**. The reward is cut off, the brakes are weak, and the child feels **no control**. The result: tears, shouting, even hitting. It is not simply "bad behaviour" – it is an overloaded brain. That doesn't mean you give in; it means you **plan the stop**.



✓ Five ways to make stopping easier

- 1 Warn before, not during:** "10 minutes left... 5 minutes... finish this level."
- 2 Stop at a natural end** – end of an episode or match, not in the middle.
- 3 Give some control:** "Do you want to stop now or after this video?"
- 4 Have a bridge activity ready** – snack, walk, helping in the kitchen.
- 5 Stay calm and kind, and still follow through.** Name the feeling: "It's hard to stop when it's fun."



Sushma Ma'am's summary

- Dopamine is the "**want more**" signal; unpredictable rewards make it strongest.
- Autoplay, infinite scroll, streaks and loot boxes are **designed** to keep children hooked.
- Children's brakes are still growing – **you are their brakes** for now.
- Change cues and routines; plan the stop to avoid meltdowns.



Sources & further reading

1. Harvard University, Center on the Developing Child – executive function and self-regulation. developingchild.harvard.edu
2. National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH) – "The Teen Brain: 7 Things to Know". nimh.nih.gov
3. American Academy of Pediatrics – healthychildren.org, articles on media and children.

CHAPTER

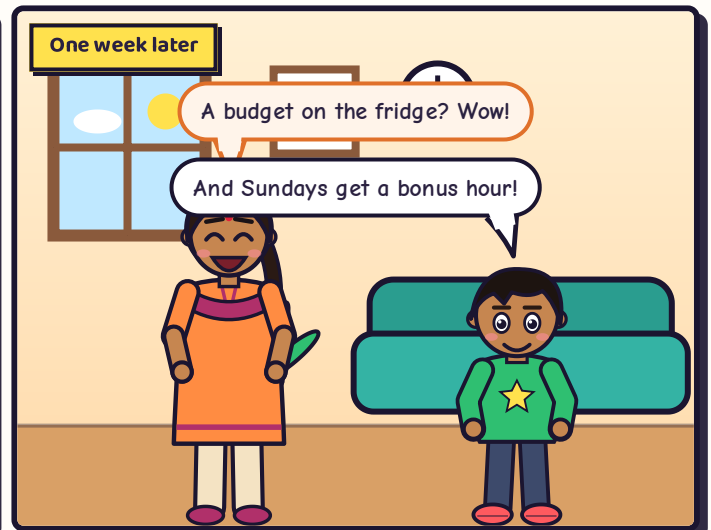
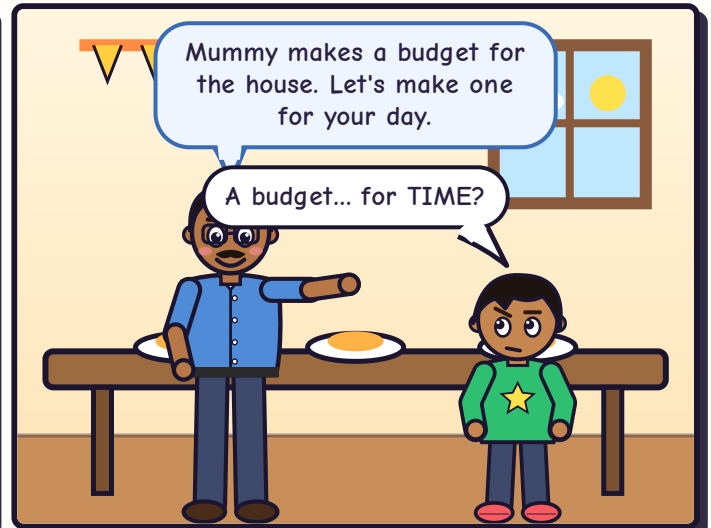
3

PART 1 · UNDERSTAND

How Much Is Too Much?
Guidelines by Age
 Know the expert limits and plan a daily screen budget.

 12 min read

 WHO · IAP · AAP

 Comic: The Time Budget

 Sushma Ma'am says

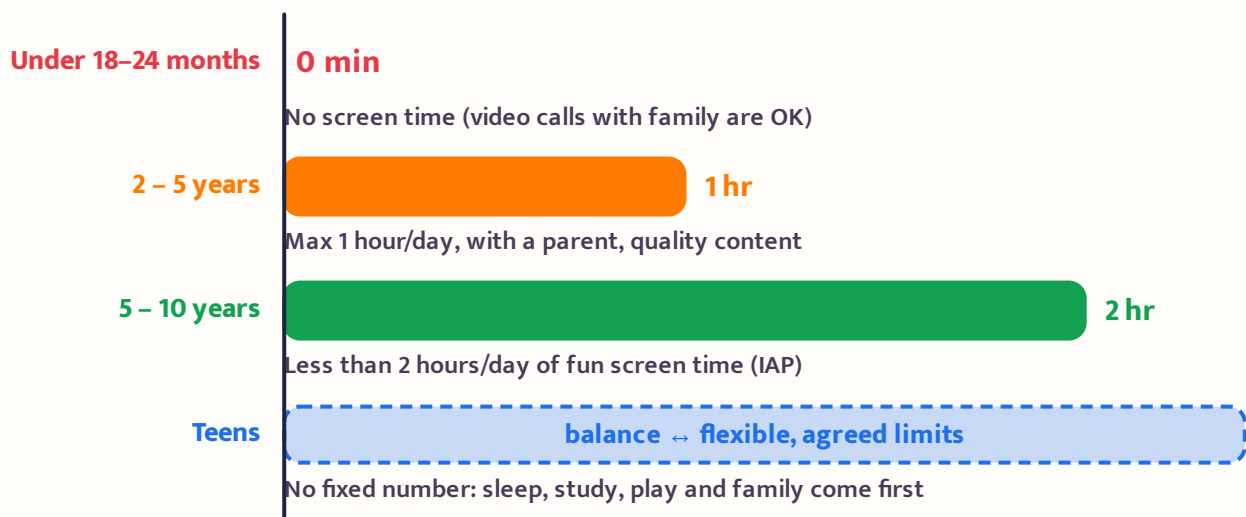

"How many hours is okay, Ma'am?" is the question I hear most. Here are the answers from the WHO, the Indian Academy of Pediatrics and the American Academy of Pediatrics. But remember – **what** your child watches and **with whom** matters as much as the number.

What the experts recommend

Age	WHO (2019)	Indian Academy of Pediatrics (IAP)	American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP)
Under 1	No screen time	No screens under 2 (video calls with family OK)	Avoid screens under 18 months, except video-chatting
1–2 years	Sedentary screen time not recommended (age 1); for age 2, max 1 hr	No screens (except video calls)	If introduced after 18 months: good-quality content, watched together
2–5 years	No more than 1 hour a day; less is better	Max 1 hour a day, supervised, quality content	Limit to about 1 hour of quality programmes, co-view
5–10 years	(guideline covers under-5s)	Less than 2 hours a day of recreational screen time	Consistent limits; Family Media Plan
Teens	–	Balance: protect sleep, activity and family time	Consistent limits; screen-free bedrooms and meals
All ages	Reading, storytelling, active play, good sleep	No screens during meals and 1 hour before bedtime	Screen-free bedrooms and meals; parents model healthy use

Note: Guidelines are summarised in simple words. "Screen time" here means **recreational** use (entertainment), not online classes or homework – but school screen time also adds to eye strain and sitting time, so breaks matter.

Recreational screen time – daily upper limits



What Research Says

- For under-5s, the **WHO** guideline puts screen time inside a bigger picture: **physical activity, sleep and less sitting**. Its advice is to replace screen time with reading, storytelling and active play with a caregiver.
- The **IAP** guidance for Indian families adds clear home rules: **no screens during meals** and **none in the hour before bed**.
- The **AAP** suggests every family make a **Family Media Plan** ([healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan](https://www.healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan)) – we will build one in Week 3.

Quality matters as much as quantity

One hour of a video call with Nani, or building a science model with a tutorial, is very different from one hour of random reels. Researchers often separate **active / educational** use from **passive** use. Ask three questions: *Is my child thinking, creating or connecting? Is the content made for this age? Is someone talking with the child about it?*



Better screen time

- Video calls with grandparents, cousins
- Creating: drawing apps, coding, music, making a story
- Age-right learning shows, watched together
- Family movie night with talk afterwards
- Looking up answers to real questions



Watch-out screen time

- Endless reels, shorts and autoplay
- Screens while eating or falling asleep
- Violent or adult content, random chats with strangers
- Phone as the only way to calm down
- Games with loot boxes or pay-to-win

What counts as "screen time"?

Activity	In the fun budget?	Keep in mind
Cartoons, YouTube, reels, gaming	✓ Yes	This is the main budget. Use a timer outside the phone.
Online class, school homework on a device	— No	Still needs breaks: 20-20-20 rule, stretch, water.
Video call with Nani, Dadi, cousins	— No	Allowed even for babies (IAP, AAP) – it is real connection.
TV running in the background	✓ Yes	Especially for toddlers – switch it off when nobody is watching.
Family movie night	✓ Yes	A "good" use: together, planned, with talk afterwards.
Educational app used alone	✓ Yes	Better content, but eyes and sitting time still count.



Tricky situations – and what to do

- **"Everyone in my class has more screen time!"** – "Every family has its own rules. Ours are about sleep and fun together. Let's look at your budget."
- **Dadi or Nani gives the phone at meals.** Don't argue in front of the child. Later, explain the doctors' advice kindly and ask for their help – "You tell the best stories, Mummy-ji."
- **Homework comes on WhatsApp.** Let a parent read the message and write the task on paper; the phone goes back.
- **Long journeys, weddings, festivals.** Plan a slightly bigger budget in advance, pack books, cards and doodle pads – and return to normal the next day.

Co-viewing: the simplest upgrade

For young children especially, the AAP recommends that parents **watch together** and talk about what they see. A toddler learns far more words from *you* naming things on screen and connecting them to real life than from the screen alone. For older children, co-playing a game or watching one of their favourite YouTubers with them is a door into their world.

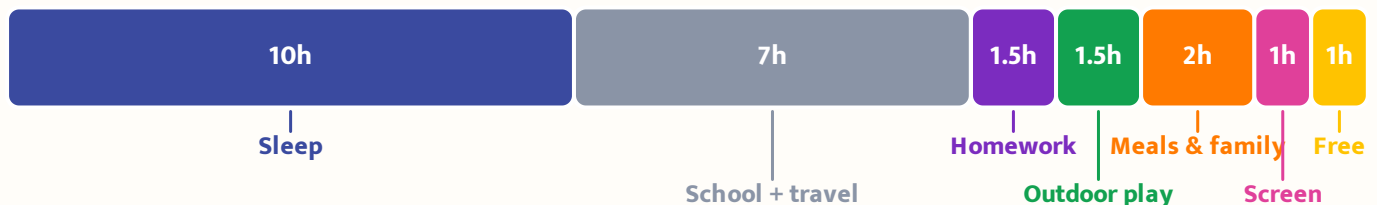
Co-viewing phrases

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ (Silently scrolling next to the child)	✓ "Oh, that elephant is drinking water! Where did we see an elephant?"
✗ "Stop watching that rubbish."	✓ "Show me why you like this channel. What's the funniest part?"
✗ "You're wasting your life on games."	✓ "Teach me one round. I bet I lose!"

The screen-time budget

Think of the day like the monthly household budget. First we pay for the **essentials** – sleep, school, homework, meals, outdoor play, family time. Screen time is like "shopping money": it comes from what is **left**, and it has a limit. This framing helps children understand limits as **fair planning**, not punishment.

Example: a school day for an 8-year-old (24 hours)



Screens get what is **LEFT** after the non-negotiables – not the other way round.

Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Screens are not needed. Reading, songs, blocks and outdoor play build the brain best. If used, keep it short, slow-paced and watched together.

Age 10–13

Let the child help plan the weekly budget. Separate homework screen time from fun screen time.

Age 6–9

Use a visual timer and fixed "screen slots" (e.g. 5–6 pm). Prefer shows with a clear ending over endless video feeds.

Age 14–16

Negotiate, don't dictate. Fix non-negotiables (sleep, phone out of bedroom at night) and give freedom within them.

**Activity: Make your child's budget**

- Draw a long strip of 24 boxes (one per hour) with your child.
- Colour in sleep first, then school, homework, meals, play and family time.
- Look at what is left. Agree together how much of it can be screen time – within the limits for his/her age.
- Stick it on the fridge. Weekends can have a slightly bigger budget – decide in advance.

**Sushma Ma'am's summary**

- Under 2: no screens (video calls are fine). 2–5: up to 1 hour, together. 5–10: under 2 hours of fun screen time.
- No screens at meals, in the hour before bed, or in the bedroom at night – for every age.
- Quality and company matter: create > consume, together > alone.
- Screens get the budget that is **left** after the essentials.

**Sources & further reading**

1. World Health Organization (2019). Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5 years of age.
2. Indian Academy of Pediatrics – guidelines on screen time and digital wellness in infants, children and adolescents (2021).
3. American Academy of Pediatrics – Media and Young Minds; Family Media Plan: [healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan](https://www.healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan)

CHAPTER

4

PART 1 · UNDERSTAND

What Too Much Screen Time Can Do

 Know the risks calmly – and how to protect against them.

 15 min read

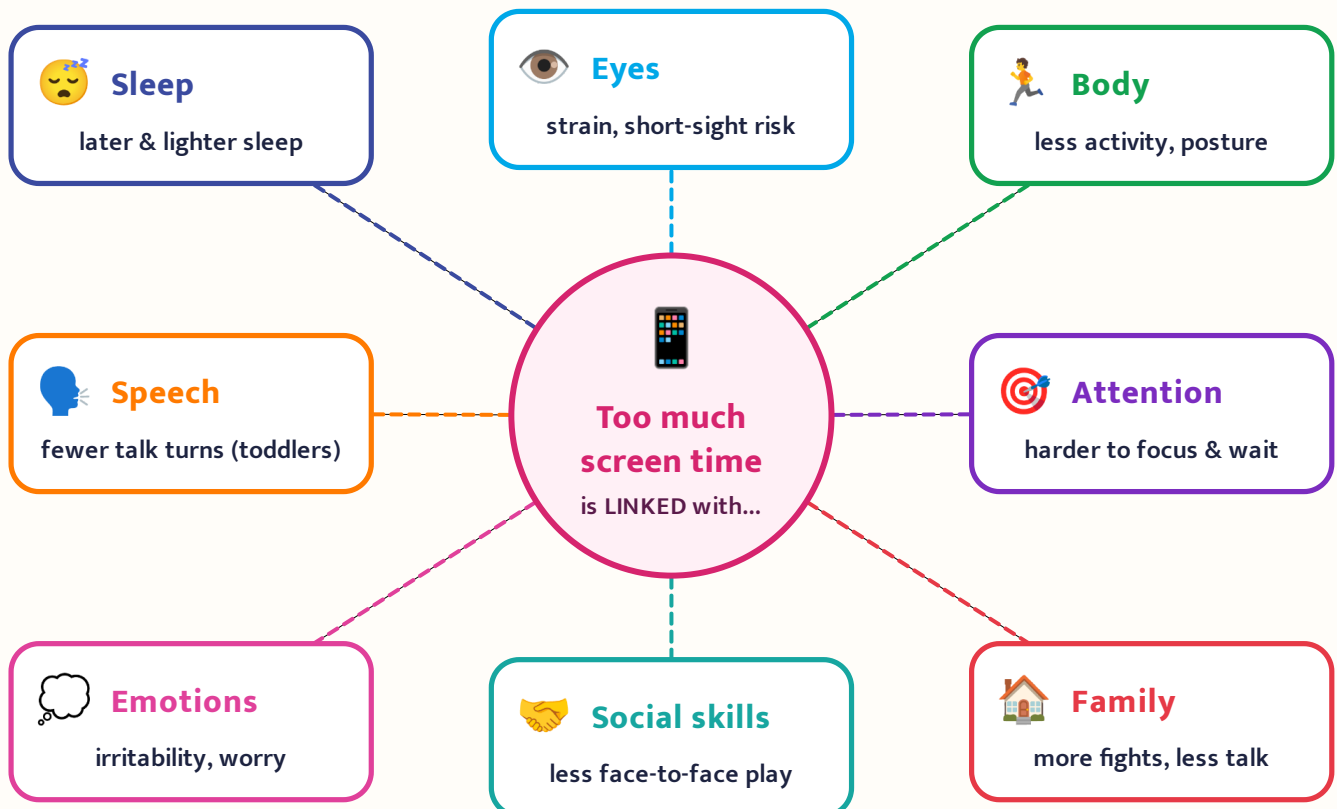
 Evidence-based

 Sushma Ma'am says


This chapter is not here to scare you. Screens are part of modern life, and many children use them without harm. But research has found **links** between heavy screen use and some problems. Knowing them helps you **protect what matters most** – sleep, eyes, movement, talking and togetherness.

 "Linked with" is not the same as "causes"

Many studies show **associations**: children who use screens a lot are *more likely* to have certain problems. Sometimes the screen contributes; sometimes a worried or lonely child turns to screens more; often both. So we don't say "the phone ruined my child". We say: "Let's protect sleep, play and talk – and watch how my child does."

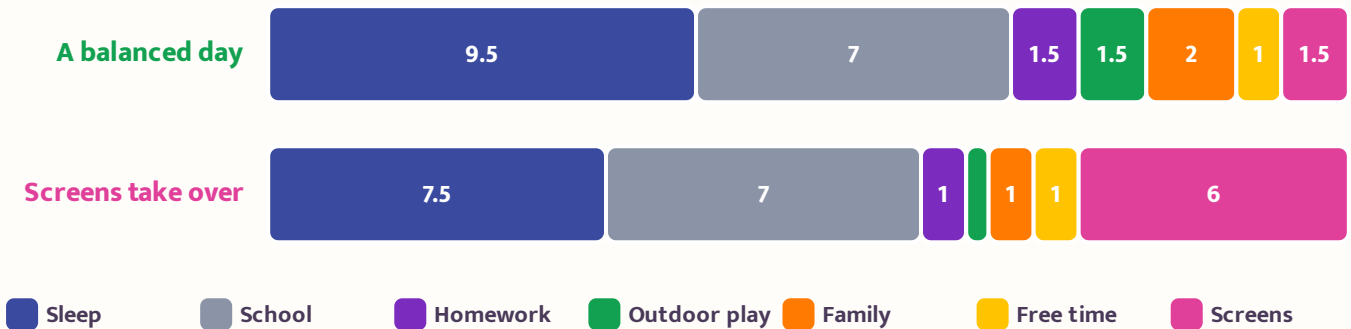


Eight areas where research has found links with heavy screen use.

The hidden cost: what screens push out

Often the biggest harm is not the screen itself but **what it replaces**. A day has only 24 hours. When screen time grows, something else must shrink – and it is usually sleep, outdoor play and family talk, the very things growing children need most.

Illustration: what a heavy-screen day pushes out (12-year-old, 24 hours)

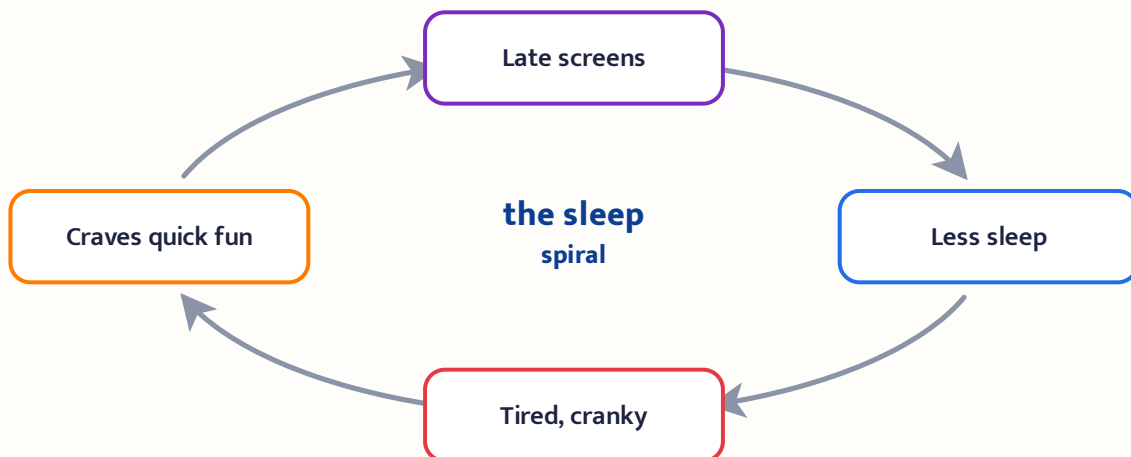


Screens +4.5 h → sleep –2 h, play –1 h, family –1 h, homework –½ h

An example to show the idea – not data from a study.

🧐 1. Sleep

Screens in the evening **delay sleep** in two ways: the content keeps the brain excited ("one more episode"), and the bright light from screens can signal the brain that it is still daytime. Phones in the bedroom also mean late-night messages and gaming. Less sleep then shows up as irritability, poor concentration and more cravings for quick fun the next day – a cycle.

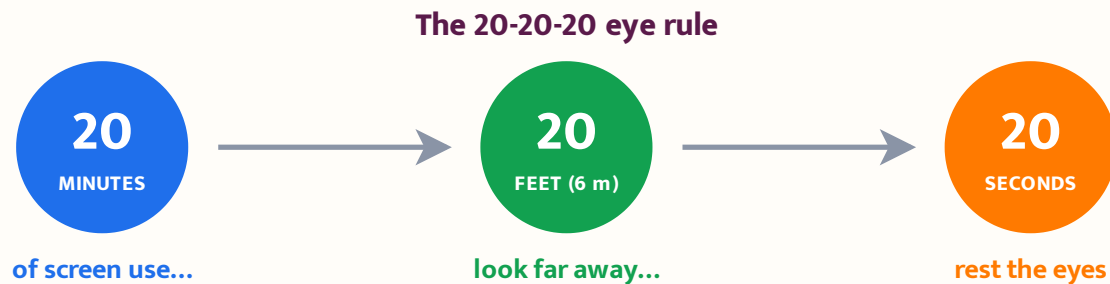


🌟 Protect sleep

Screens off **1 hour before bed** (IAP). All devices **charge outside the bedroom** at night – parents' too. Replace the phone with a story, a chat about the day, or quiet music.

2. Eyes

Long periods of close-up screen work can cause **eye strain** – tired, dry, itchy eyes and headaches, partly because we blink less while staring at screens. Short-sightedness (**myopia**) is becoming more common in children around the world. Research suggests that **more time outdoors** – around 2 hours of daylight a day – is linked with a **lower risk** of myopia, while lots of near work indoors may add to it.



Watch for: squinting, sitting very close to the TV, rubbing eyes, headaches. Get a yearly eye check-up – many schools also run screening camps.

3. Body, activity and posture

Screen time is mostly **sitting time**. It can push out active play, and it often comes with snacking. Heavy screen use has been linked with less physical activity and with weight gain. Looking down at a phone for long periods also strains the neck and back ("text neck"). Children need **active play every day** – running, cycling, dancing, cricket in the gali.

4. Speech and language in toddlers

Young children learn language through **back-and-forth talk** – "serve and return", like a game of catch with words. A screen talks *at* a child but cannot respond *to* the child. Studies have linked more screen time in toddlers with **fewer conversations** at home and with delays in language. A TV playing in the background also reduces how much parents talk to their little ones.

For parents of toddlers

If your 2-year-old uses very few words, doesn't respond to his name, avoids eye contact or doesn't point to show you things, **please see your paediatrician** – don't just blame the phone, and don't wait. Early help works best.

5. Attention and learning

Fast-paced videos and games change scenes every few seconds. After that, a teacher's voice or a chapter of a book can feel slow. Research has linked very heavy screen use with **attention difficulties** and with lower school performance – though the direction is not always clear. Screens in the study area also cause **multitasking**, which makes homework take longer and stick less.



6. Emotions and anxiety

Heavy social media use in teens has been linked with **low mood, anxiety and poor body image**, especially when it replaces sleep, or involves comparison and cyberbullying. Some children use screens to **escape** difficult feelings; when the screen is taken, the feelings come rushing back. Irritability when offline is common. The goal is to help children find **other ways to calm down** – talking, moving, creating.



7. Social skills

Reading faces, taking turns, sharing, handling a small fight and making up – these are learnt in **real play with real people**. Online chat is not the same. When screens replace playground time, children get fewer chances to practise. Encourage group games, family gatherings and hobby classes where children meet face to face.



8. Family relationships

Daily fights over the phone wear everyone down. Parents feel like "police", children feel controlled, and the warm moments shrink. Screens at meals and in bedrooms also mean **less talking**. The good news: when families agree rules *together* and add back shared fun, the fights usually reduce a lot.



9. Online safety

Time is not the only risk. What happens **on** the screen matters too. Children can meet unkind people, unsafe content and money traps. The best protection is not only filters – it is a child who feels safe telling you, "**Something weird happened online.**"

Risk	Warning signs	What to do
Cyberbullying	Upset after using the phone, avoids school or friends	Listen calmly, save screenshots, block and report; inform the school
Strangers / grooming	New "friend" online, secret chats, gifts or requests for photos	Never blame the child; stop contact; report at 1930 / cybercrime.gov.in ; Childline 1098
Unsuitable content	Scared, uses new words, hides the screen	Use age settings and kids' profiles; keep devices in shared rooms; talk openly
Money traps	Unknown payments, "free" coins, loot boxes	Remove saved cards/UPI; turn on purchase approval

Area	Early signs to notice	Simple protection
Sleep	Hard to wake, yawning in class	Devices out of bedroom; 1 hr screen-free before bed
Eyes	Squinting, headaches, rubbing eyes	20-20-20; outdoor play; yearly eye test
Body	Tired easily, avoids games, slouching	Daily active play; screen breaks every 30 min
Speech	Few words for age, little eye contact	Talk, read, sing; TV off in background; see doctor if worried
Attention	Can't sit through homework, bored fast	Phone away during study; short focused blocks
Emotions	Irritable offline, withdrawn, upset after using	Talk daily; watch for bullying; teach calm-down skills

Protect the big five – this week

- ☐ **Sleep:** all devices charge outside bedrooms at night.
- ☐ **Eyes:** 20-20-20 breaks; eye check-up this year.
- ☐ **Movement:** active play every day, outdoors if possible.
- ☐ **Talk:** one screen-free meal together daily.
- ☐ **Togetherness:** one shared offline activity this week.



The good news

Children's brains and bodies are **flexible**. When families bring back sleep, play and talk, most of these problems ease. Parents often notice better moods and fewer fights within a few weeks of steady routines.



Sushma Ma'am's summary

- Research shows **links**, not certain damage. Stay calm, stay watchful.
- Protect the big five: **sleep, eyes, movement, talk, togetherness**.
- For toddlers with speech concerns – see a doctor early.



Sources & further reading

1. World Health Organization (2019). Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5.
2. American Academy of Ophthalmology – computers, digital devices and eye strain; the 20-20-20 rule.
3. American Academy of Pediatrics – Media and Young Minds; Children and Adolescents and Digital Media (policy statements).
4. Harvard Center on the Developing Child – "Serve and return" interaction.
5. National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal – cybercrime.gov.in (helpline 1930); Childline 1098.

CHAPTER

5

PART 1 · UNDERSTAND

Check Your Child: Self-Assessment

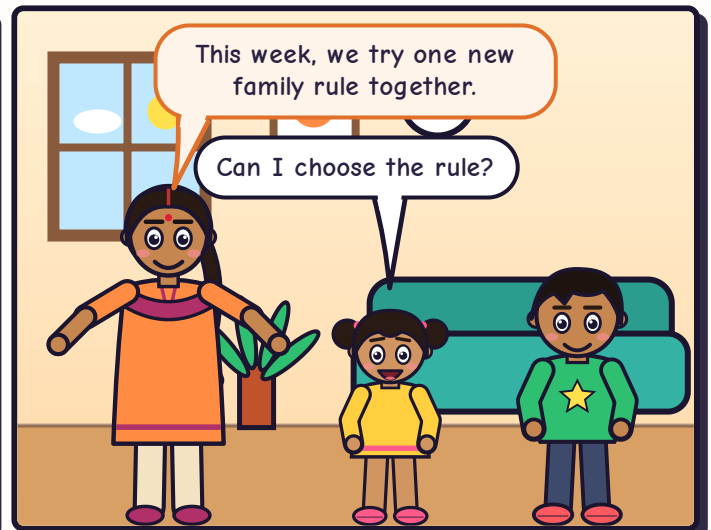
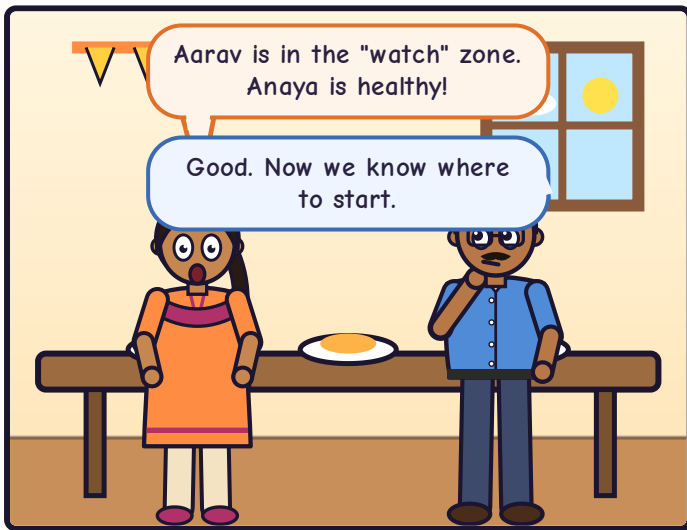
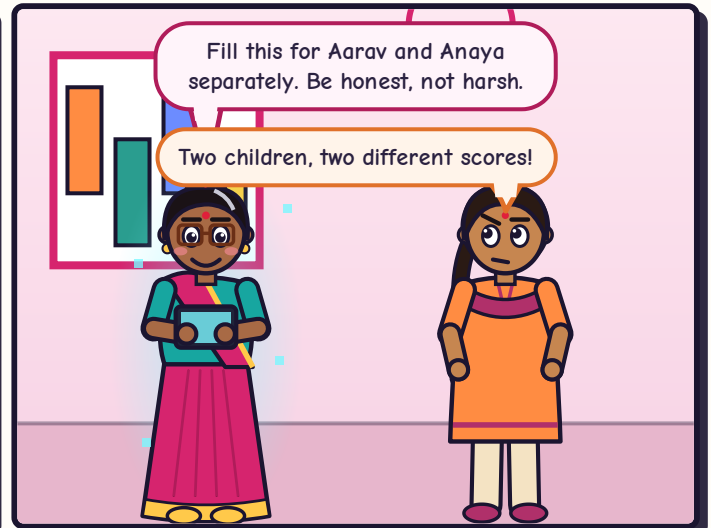
🎯 Find out where your child stands – and when to seek help.

🕒 10 min quiz

✍️ Pen needed



💬 Comic: Where Do We Stand?



💬 Sushma Ma'am says



This check is like a **thermometer, not a diagnosis**. It tells you how warm things are at home right now, so you know which part of this book to lean on. Fill it for **one child at a time**, thinking about the **last 2–3 months**, not one bad day.

Parent check: my child and screens (score 0 / 1 / 2)

	Never (0)	Sometimes (1)	Often (2)
1. My child gets very angry, cries or hits when screen time ends.	☐	☐	☐
2. My child uses screens longer than we agreed, almost every day.	☐	☐	☐
3. Screens come up in almost every conversation or request.	☐	☐	☐
4. My child has lost interest in hobbies, sports or friends he/she used to enjoy.	☐	☐	☐
5. My child sleeps late or wakes tired because of screens.	☐	☐	☐
6. Homework, marks or school reports have dropped.	☐	☐	☐
7. My child hides the device, lies about use or uses it secretly at night.	☐	☐	☐
8. My child seems restless, bored or irritable when there is no screen.	☐	☐	☐
9. My child skips meals, or eats only with a screen.	☐	☐	☐
10. My child uses the screen to calm down whenever upset.	☐	☐	☐
11. Family time and outings feel like a fight because of the phone.	☐	☐	☐
12. My child prefers online friends or games to meeting people in person.	☐	☐	☐
13. My child has spent money on games or apps without asking.	☐	☐	☐
14. My child complains of eye strain, headaches or body aches after screens.	☐	☐	☐
15. Rules we make don't last – within days we are back to the old pattern.	☐	☐	☐

Add up your score (Never = 0, Sometimes = 1, Often = 2). Maximum = 30. My child's score: _____

Score	Zone	What it means & what to do
0–7	 Healthy	Good balance. Keep your routines, keep talking, and use the 21-day plan to <i>stay</i> here.
8–15	 Watch	Habits are slipping. Start the 21-day plan now; focus on bedtime, meals and replacing boredom.
16–23	 Act now	Screens are affecting daily life. Do the plan as a whole family, involve the school/teacher, and re-check after 3 weeks.
24–30	 Seek help	Please talk to a paediatrician, child psychologist or a clinic like NIMHANS SHUT, alongside the plan.

Note

Any score + any red flag below = seek help. A low score does not cancel a red flag. And a high score does not mean "disorder" – only a trained professional can decide that.

Quick signs by age

Children show screen trouble differently at different ages. Use this table alongside the score.

 Toddlers & preschool (2–5)	 School-age (6–12)	 Teens (13–16)
Cries or tantrums whenever the screen goes off	Arguments and bargaining every single day	Phone in hand from waking till sleeping
Eats only while watching	Rushes homework to get back to games	Stays up late on phone; tired at school
Few words for age, less eye contact	Lost interest in outdoor play	Mood swings tied to likes, chats, games
Can't play alone without a device	Sneaks the phone, deletes history	Withdraws from family, secretive, very defensive
Watches while falling asleep	Talks only about games/YouTubers	Grades dropping, skipping classes or tuition

Red Flag – Seek Help

- Talks about **hopelessness, self-harm or not wanting to live** – get help **today** (Tele-MANAS **14416**; emergency **112**).
- **Violence** – hitting, breaking things, threatening family when the device is taken.
- **Refusing school** or dropping out of daily life for weeks.
- **Not eating or sleeping** properly for days; big weight change.
- Signs of **online abuse, blackmail or contact with a stranger** – report at **1930** / [cybercrime.gov.in](https://www.cybercrime.gov.in); Childline **1098**.
- A toddler with **speech delay or loss of skills** he/she had before.

Look deeper: what need is the screen meeting?

Every child who reaches for a screen is getting **something** from it. If we only remove the screen, the need stays – and the child finds another screen. Find the need, and offer a healthier way to meet it.

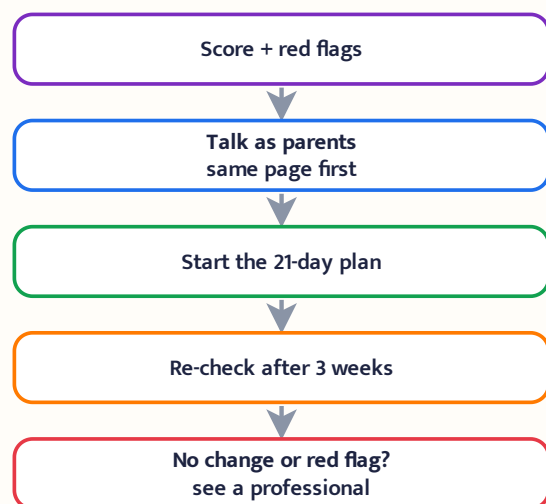
If the screen gives...	You may notice...	Healthier ways to meet the need
 Escape from boredom	Picks up the phone the moment nothing is planned	Boredom jar, hobby box, chores with music, free play outdoors
 Relief from stress or worry	More screen before exams, after scoldings or fights	Talk time, breathing, a walk with you; look at the source of stress
 Friendship and belonging	Games or chats with classmates; fear of missing out	Invite friends home, team sports, clubs; agreed chat times
 Feeling good at something	Proud of game levels and ranks	Real-life skills with levels: music grades, sports, coding, cooking
 Calming down	Needs the phone to stop crying or to fall asleep	Cuddles, stories, soft music, a calm corner – taught when the child is calm

Worksheet: 3-day screen diary

Numbers from your memory are usually lower than the truth – for children and for us! For three ordinary days (include one weekend day), quietly note what you see. Don't comment or punish yet; just observe like a scientist.

Day	Total fun screen time	When? (times)	What? (apps, shows, games)	Mood before → after	Stopping: easy / hard?
Day 1					
Day 2					
Day 3 (weekend)					

What to do with your result



Child Psychology Insight

Children change fastest when they feel **understood, not accused**. Don't show your child the score like a report card. Instead say: *"I've noticed screens are making some things hard for us. Let's fix it as a team."*

Where to get help in India

- Your paediatrician – the best first step.
- **Tele-MANAS: 14416** or 1-800-891-4416 (free, 24×7).
- **NIMHANS SHUT Clinic**, Bengaluru – for healthy use of technology.
- School counsellor; child psychologist or psychiatrist.

Talking to your child about it

Choose a calm moment – a walk, a car ride, while cooking together – not right after a fight. Talk about the **family**, not the child's faults, and ask for their ideas. Children who help make a plan are far more likely to follow it.

Start the talk without blame

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "Your score is 22. You are addicted."	✓ "I've noticed we're all on screens a lot, and bedtime has become hard. What do you think?"
✗ "From tomorrow, no phone. Final."	✓ "What do you love most about your games? Let's keep that and fix the hard parts."
✗ "You never listen!"	✓ "Which one rule should we try first as a family – you choose."



Track your progress – re-check after the 21 days

Child's name	Score today	After 21 days	After 3 months	What changed most?



Think it over

Which statements did I mark "Often" – and what need might sit behind them?



Sushma Ma'am's summary

- The quiz is a **thermometer, not a diagnosis**.
- Score each child separately; re-check after the 21 days.
- Red flags always mean: **get professional help** – you are not failing, you are protecting.



Sources & further reading

1. This checklist is a parent awareness tool written for this book; it is not a validated clinical scale.
2. WHO ICD-11: 6C51 Gaming disorder: icd.who.int
3. Tele-MANAS (Government of India) – telemanas.mohfw.gov.in; National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal – cybercrime.gov.in (helpline 1930)

CHAPTER

6

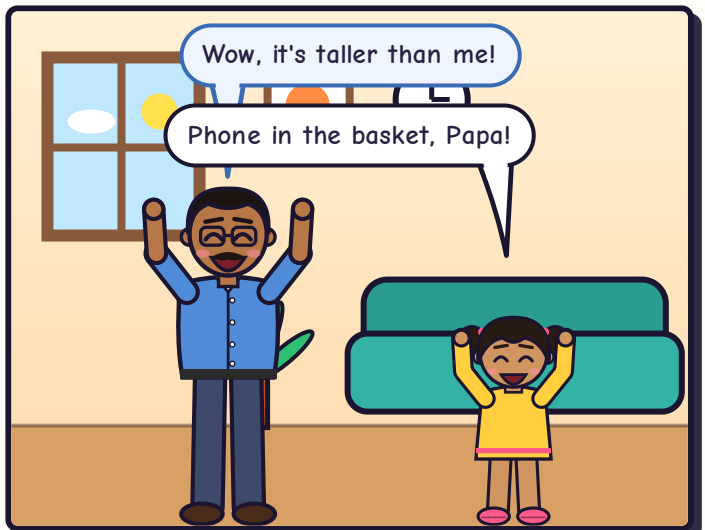
PART 1 · UNDERSTAND

It Starts With Us: Parents' Screens

 See your own screen habits – and lead by example.

 15 min read

 Self-audit

 Comic: "Papa, Look!"

 Sushma Ma'am says


This is the chapter parents find hardest – and the most powerful. Children don't do what we **say**, they do what we **do**. I am not asking you to be perfect. I use my phone too! I'm asking you to be **aware** – because when parents change a little, children change a lot.

Children copy what they see

Psychologist Albert Bandura showed that children learn a great deal by **watching and imitating** the adults around them – this is called **social learning** or **modelling**. If Papa scrolls at dinner and Mummy checks WhatsApp at every ping, the child learns: "Phones come first." Rules that adults don't follow feel unfair, and children notice immediately.



What your child notices about YOUR phone

Age 2–5

Notices your face. A parent looking at a phone instead of at them feels like "gone" – they cling, whine or act up to get you back.

Age 6–9

Notices fairness. "Why can Papa watch at dinner and not me?" Rules must apply to everyone.

Age 10–13

Copies your habits exactly – checking at every ping, scrolling in bed, gaming to relax.

Age 14–16

Notices hypocrisy fast and argues back. Admitting your own struggle earns more respect than lectures.

"Technoference": when the phone steps between us

Researchers use the word **technoference** for everyday interruptions in family time caused by devices – a parent looking at a message in the middle of a story, or half-listening while scrolling. Each moment seems small. But for a child, it can feel like *"I am less interesting than that phone."*



What Research Says

- Studies have linked more technoference in families with **more attention-seeking and acting-out behaviour** in young children.
- Observations of parents with young children have found that when a parent is absorbed in a phone, there are **fewer back-and-forth conversations** and responses to the child.
- Teens also notice: many say they wish their parents were **less distracted** by phones.



Child Psychology Insight

A child's bid for attention – "Mummy, look!" – is a small request for **connection**. Attachment research shows that responding to these bids warmly, most of the time, builds a secure bond. You don't need to respond every single time – but a phone that wins **most** of the time sends a strong message.

Parent self-audit

Be honest – nobody will see this but you (score 0 / 1 / 2)

	Rarely (0)	Sometimes (1)	Often (2)
1. I check my phone within minutes of waking up.	☐	☐	☐
2. I use my phone during meals.	☐	☐	☐
3. My child has had to repeat something because I was on my phone.	☐	☐	☐
4. I scroll while my child is talking to me or playing near me.	☐	☐	☐
5. I give my child the phone to get some peace and quiet.	☐	☐	☐
6. I use my phone in bed before sleeping.	☐	☐	☐
7. I check the phone while driving or at red lights with my child in the car.	☐	☐	☐
8. I get irritated when my child interrupts my screen time.	☐	☐	☐
9. The family WhatsApp / office group gets my attention before my child does.	☐	☐	☐
10. I make rules for my child that I don't follow myself.	☐	☐	☐

0–6: A great model – keep it up and share your tricks with family.

7–13: Like most of us! Pick 2 habits to change this week.

14–20: Your child is learning phone habits from you. Start the 21-day plan with yourself.

✓ Five small changes for parents

1 A phone basket near the door or dining table – everyone's phone goes in at meal time, including yours.

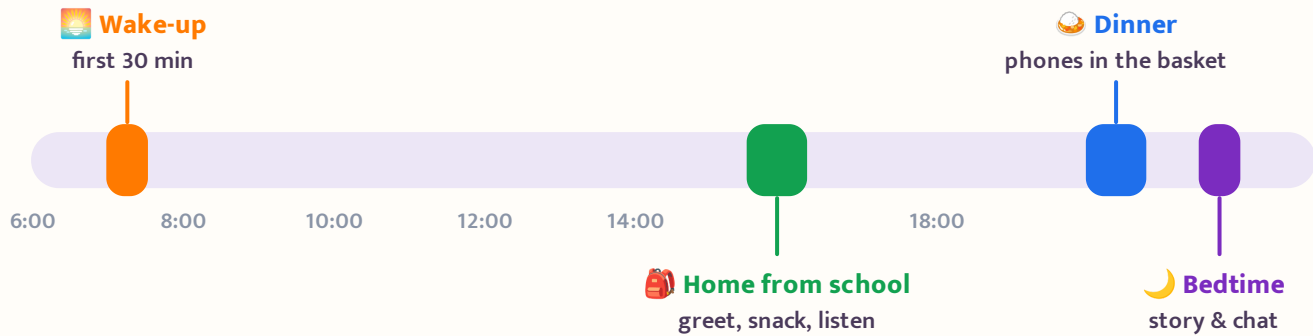
2 The first and last 30 minutes of your child's day are phone-free for you.

3 Say it out loud when you use the phone: "I'm checking Nani's message, then I'll put it away."

4 Mute group chats and turn off non-essential notifications.

5 Ask your child to be your coach: "If you catch me scrolling at dinner, you can remind me."

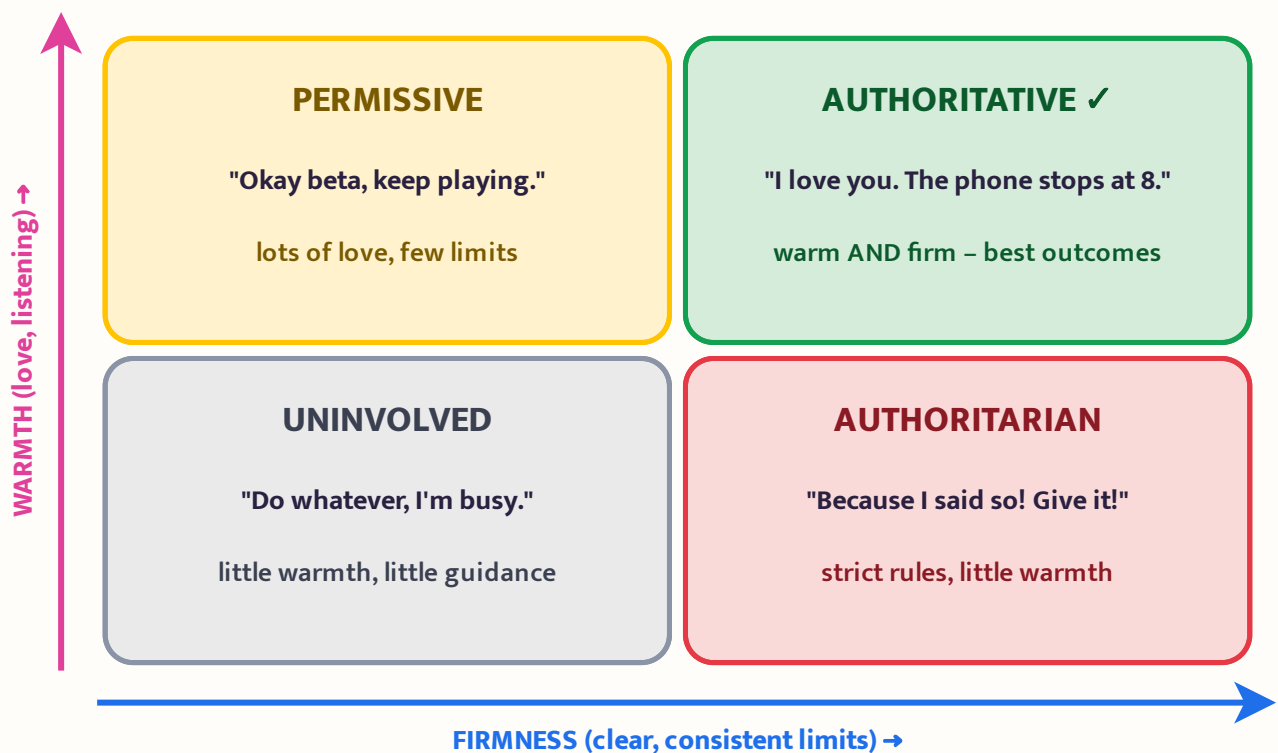
A parent's day: four phone-free anchors



You don't need a phone-free day – just phone-free moments when your child needs you most.

Your parenting style matters

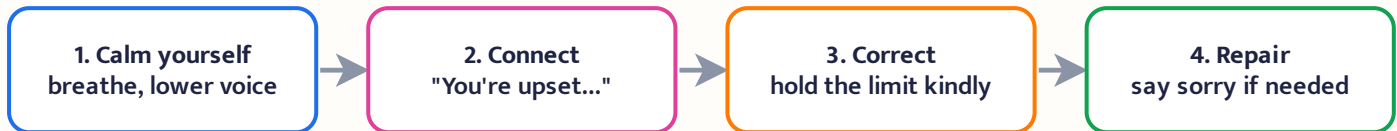
Psychologists (starting with Diana Baumrind) describe four broad parenting styles using two ingredients: **warmth** (love, listening) and **firmness** (clear, consistent limits). Most of us move between styles on different days. Research consistently favours the **authoritative** style – high warmth *and* clear limits – including for screen rules.



Style	With screens it looks like...	Child often learns...
Authoritarian	Snatching phones, shouting, sudden bans	To hide, lie and rebel
Permissive	No limits; phone to avoid tantrums	Tantrums work; can't stop alone
Uninvolved	Doesn't know what the child watches	Nobody cares; screens fill the gap
Authoritative	Rules made together, explained, kept kindly	Self-control and trust

Connection before correction

When a child is upset about the phone, the thinking brain goes offline. Lectures bounce off. First **connect** – get down to their level, name the feeling – and only then **correct**. Afterwards, if you shouted, **repair**: "I'm sorry I yelled. I was worried. Let's try again." Repair teaches children that relationships can survive mistakes.



Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "Give me that phone RIGHT NOW!"	✓ "You were in the middle of something fun – it's hard to stop. Time is up, so I'll keep it safe."
✗ "You are glued to that thing all day!"	✓ "I miss you. Can we do something together after this level?"
✗ "I'm an adult, I can use my phone."	✓ "You're right, I was on my phone too long. Let's both put ours in the basket."

Getting the whole family on the same team

In Indian homes a child is raised by many adults – parents, Dadi-Dadu, Nani, chachas, an older cousin, sometimes a nanny. If one adult says "no phone at lunch" and another hands it over, the child learns to go to the "yes" person. You don't need everyone to be perfect – you need them to agree on **two or three simple house rules**.

Talking to the other adults

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ To your spouse, in front of the kids: "You never follow the rules!"	✓ Later, in private: "Can we both try the phone basket at dinner this week? I need your help."
✗ To Dadi: "You are spoiling him with the phone."	✓ "Mummy-ji, the doctor says no phone during meals. Could you tell him one of your stories instead? He loves them."
✗ To the nanny: "Just keep her quiet."	✓ "Please give the tablet only from 5 to 5:30. Here are some blocks, books and colours for the rest of the time."

Activity: The 24-hour parent challenge

- For one day, notice **every time you pick up your phone** in front of your child. Make a tally mark on paper.
- At night, circle the pick-ups that were **really necessary**.
- Choose one time of day to make phone-free for you from tomorrow.



Before you start the 21 days

When is my phone most "in the way" with my child? What is one moment I will protect?

Which adult at home do I need to bring on board, and how will I start that talk kindly?

My one promise to my child this week:



Sushma Ma'am's summary

- Children learn screen habits by **watching us** (modelling).
- Small phone interruptions add up – protect meals, bedtime and "look at me" moments.
- Be **warm AND firm** – the authoritative style works best.
- **Connection before correction**, and repair after mistakes.



Sources & further reading

1. Bandura, A. – social learning theory (observational learning / modelling).
2. McDaniel, B. T. & Radesky, J. S. – research on "technoference" in parent–child interactions.
3. Baumrind, D. – parenting styles (authoritative, authoritarian, permissive); Maccoby & Martin – uninvolved style.
4. American Academy of Pediatrics – Family Media Plan; parents as media role models. [healthychildren.org](https://www.healthychildren.org)

WEEK 1 • DAYS 1–7

Aware & Reset

Observe, talk as a family, create screen-free zones and a calm bedtime.



DAY

1

WEEK 1

Become a Screen Detective

🎯 Watch the family's screen habits for 3 days – no judging.

🕒 10 min a day × 3 days

👤 Parents



Day 1 comic: The Screen Detective



Sushma Ma'am says



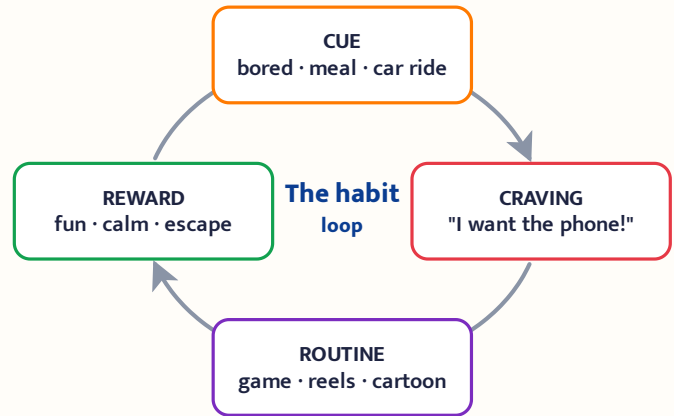
Welcome to Day 1! Today we change **nothing** – we only **notice**. A good doctor examines before prescribing, and a good parent observes before making rules. For three days, watch your family's screen habits like a friendly detective: curious, calm, and without scolding anyone.

Why this works

Most families have no clear picture of their real screen time. Minutes hide inside small moments – the car ride, the lunch plate, the 'just checking' before bed – and they add up quietly. When you write it down, the pattern becomes visible. And once you can see a pattern, you can change it.

Child Psychology Insight

Every screen habit runs on a **habit loop**: a **cue** (boredom, hunger, a car ride, a sad feeling) → a **craving** ("I want the phone!") → a **routine** (game, reels, cartoon) → a **reward** (fun, calm, escape from a bad feeling). Children are not 'weak'; their brains are simply learning what works quickly. When you find the cue, you find the best place to step in – later in the plan we will give the same need (fun, calm, company) a better answer.



Detective rules

- **Don't announce a crackdown.** If children feel watched and judged, they hide their screen use. Simply say, "I'm noticing how our whole family uses screens this week."
- **Include yourself** – TV serials, news, office WhatsApp, reels. Children notice if the diary is only about them.
- **Record, don't react.** For three days, no new rules. Only notes.

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Find the real numbers.** Open the phone's built-in screen-time report (on Android usually *Settings* → *Digital Wellbeing*; on iPhone *Settings* → *Screen Time*). Note the daily average and the top 3 apps for each device in the house.
- 2 **Fill the Screen Diary** (next page) for 3 days: when, who, what, how long – and, most importantly, **what happened just before**.
- 3 **Watch the "after".** How is your child 10 minutes after the screen goes off – calm, cranky, restless, sleepy? Write one word.
- 4 **Spot the hot-spots.** Circle the times that repeat every day (meals, car, after school, bedtime). These become our targets on Days 3 and 4.
- 5 **Notice one good moment** each day when your child chose something other than a screen – and quietly smile at it.

**Worksheet: our 3-day Screen Diary**

Keep this page on the fridge or photograph it. Fill a line whenever you notice a screen session. The first row is an example.

Day	Time	Who	What & where	Min.	Just before (trigger)	Mood after
1 (example)	7:45 am	Aarav	Game, in the car	20	Bored in traffic	Cranky when asked to stop
1						
1						
1						
2						
2						
2						
2						
3						
3						
3						
3						

 Tick the triggers you spotted

- ☐ Boredom / "nothing to do"
- ☐ Meals (to make them eat)
- ☐ Car rides & waiting rooms
- ☐ Right after school / tuition
- ☐ Parent busy or on a call
- ☐ Sad, angry or lonely feelings
- ☐ Bedtime / can't sleep
- ☐ Friends are online

After 3 days**Total / day**

Papa

Mummy

Child 1

Child 2

Biggest hot-spot:

Biggest surprise:

 Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "You are ALWAYS on that phone!"	✓ "I'm noticing how our whole family uses screens this week – me too."
✗ "How many hours have you wasted today?"	✓ "What were you watching? Show me the best part."
✗ "Why are you so irritable? It's that game!"	✓ "You seem cranky after playing. How does your body feel right now?"
✗ "Wait till I take that phone away!"	✓ "Nothing is changing yet. We'll make a plan together soon."

 Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Note what the screen is **replacing** – lap time, talking, outdoor play. Watch for screens used to feed or calm. (IAP: under 2 – no screens except video calls with family.)

Age 6–9

Make it a game: give your child a "detective badge" and let them note **your** screen time too. Children love catching parents!

Age 10–13

Ask, don't accuse: "Which game do you play most? What do you like about it?" Tweens open up when parents are curious about their world.

Age 14–16

Invite them to check their own screen-time report and guess first. Teens respect data they discover themselves more than lectures.

 If your child says...

- "Why are you spying on me?" → "I'm not spying, I'm noticing – and I'm writing about myself too. Want to see my page?"
- **Uses the phone more, secretly.** Don't confront yet. Just note it – secrecy itself is useful information for the family meeting.
- **You feel guilty seeing the numbers.** Good – that means you care. Guilt is a signal, not a sentence. Tomorrow we start changing things together.

 Tonight's 2-minute reflection

What surprised me most in our screen diary?

Which one trigger, if we handled it better, would change our home the most?

 Today's Win

I looked at our family's screen habits honestly, with curiosity instead of anger. That is the first step of every real change.

DAY

2

WEEK 1

The Family Meeting

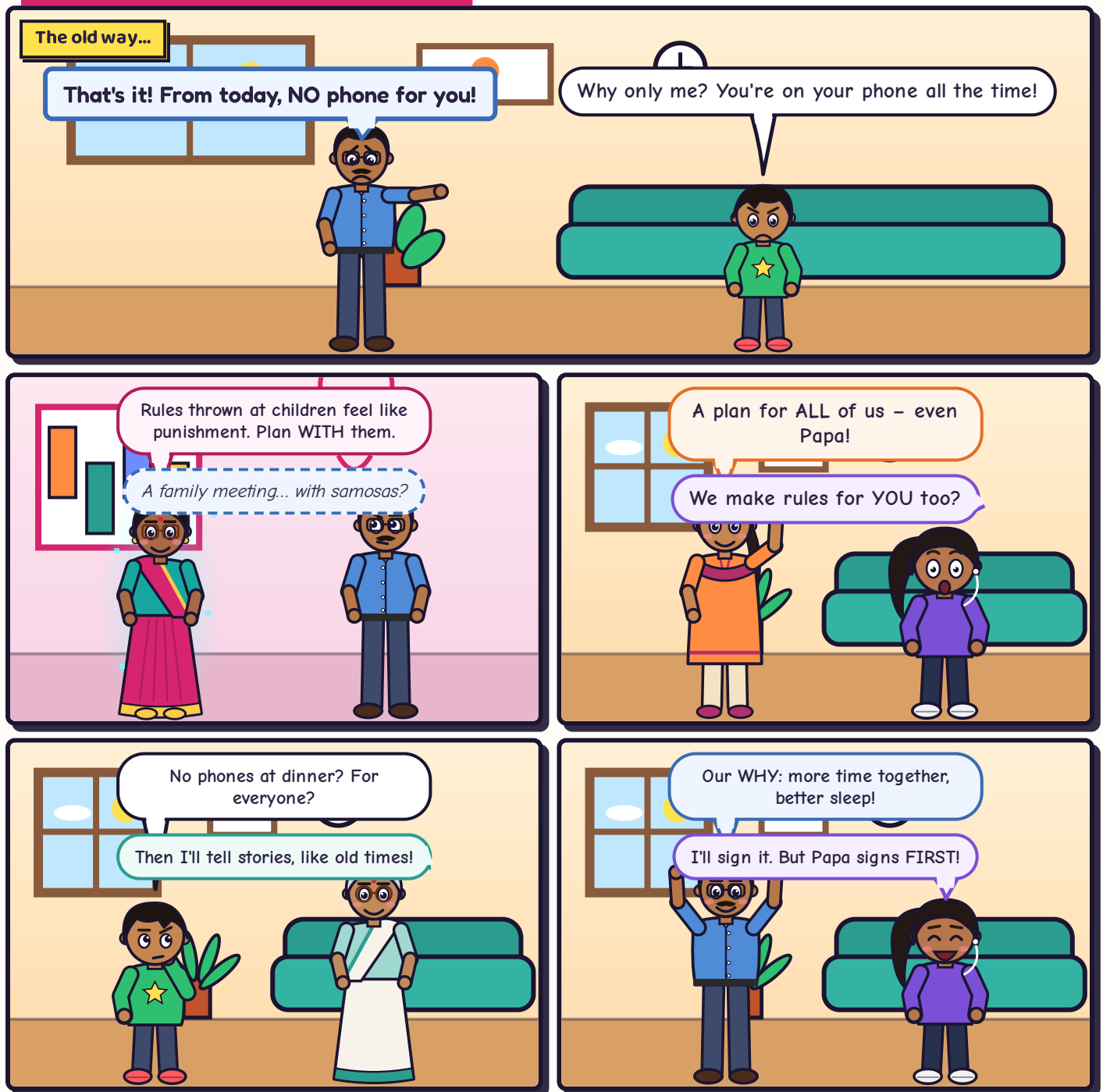
🎯 Announce the plan together – as a team, not a punishment.

🕒 30 min

👨‍👩‍👧‍👦 Whole family



Day 2 comic: The Family Meeting



**Sushma Ma'am says**

Today your family becomes a team. The way you **start** this plan matters as much as the plan itself. If children hear "You are addicted, so we're taking your phone," they hear punishment – and they fight back. If they hear "We **all** want our family to feel better, and we need your ideas," they join in.

Why this works

Children follow rules they helped to make far more willingly than rules handed down to them. It is not magic – it is how motivation works. A plan the child owns feels like **their** decision, so there is less to rebel against. It also shows that the problem is the **habit**, not the child.

**Child Psychology Insight**

Psychologists describe three basic needs behind healthy motivation (Self-Determination Theory, Deci & Ryan): **autonomy** ("I have a choice"), **competence** ("I can do this") and **relatedness** ("we're in this together"). A family meeting feeds all three. A sudden ban takes away all three – which is why it usually triggers tears, anger or secret use. Firm limits are still needed; the difference is that children help **shape** them, and parents keep the final say on safety and sleep.

The 30-minute family meeting – 5 simple parts**Today's Action Steps**

- 1 **Pick a relaxed time** – a weekend evening with snacks, not right after a fight over the phone. Everyone sits in a circle; all phones go in a basket, parents' first.
- 2 **Start with a confession, not a complaint.** "I have noticed that I am on my phone too much – and I miss you. I think all of us can do better."
- 3 **Share the diary gently** – patterns, not blame. "Most of our screen time happens at meals and at night. What do you notice?"
- 4 **Children speak first.** Ask: "What do you love about screens? What do you not like? What would you like us to do more of together?" Write every idea down, even silly ones.
- 5 **Agree only 2–3 first steps** for this week (e.g., no phones at dinner; phones sleep outside bedrooms). Explain that more will come step by step.
- 6 **Make the "Why" poster together** (below), sign it and stick it where everyone sees it. End with a hug or a family high-five.

 Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "You are addicted to that phone."	✓ "Phones are designed to be hard to put down – for adults too. Let's make a plan together."
✗ "From today, new rules. No arguments."	✓ "I want to hear your ideas first. Then we'll decide together."
✗ "This is because of your bad marks."	✓ "This isn't a punishment. It's about sleep, health and more fun together."
✗ "Rules are for children, not for me."	✓ "The rules are for all of us – and you can remind me if I forget."

 Printable: our family "Why" poster

Fill it with your children's words, not yours. Ideas families often write: *more family game nights · better sleep · stronger eyes · more time outdoors · less shouting about phones · more stories with Dadi.*

★ OUR FAMILY'S WHY ★

We want to use screens less, so that we can...

1

2

3

4

Signed by the whole family:

 Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Keep it tiny: "At dinner, phones go to sleep and we talk." Let them put Mummy's phone in the basket – a big, important job!

Age 10–13

Give them a real role: secretary who writes the ideas, or timekeeper. Ask for one rule **they** want the parents to follow.

Age 6–9

Let them draw on the poster and choose the family reward. Use a talking object (a spoon or a ball) – only the holder speaks.

Age 14–16

Talk to them privately first, as a near-adult. Negotiate: fewer rules, but kept. Respect that friends and chats matter deeply at this age.

**If the meeting goes sideways...**

- **Your teen refuses to come.** Don't force it. Hold the meeting anyway, keep a seat and a samosa for them, and share the notes: "We'd really like your ideas before Friday."
- **A child says "This is so unfair!"** Agree with the feeling: "It does feel unfair to change. That's why you get a say." Then move on.
- **Dadi or Dada say "In our time children just obeyed."** Invite them as allies: "You are our story-teller and game-master this month!"
- **It turns into a blame game.** Pause: "We're a team. Let's talk about habits, not people." End early if needed – a short, happy meeting beats a long, angry one.

**Tonight's 2-minute reflection**

What idea did my child suggest that I would never have thought of?

How did my child's face look when they got a real say?

**Today's Win**

We announced the plan as a team, not as a punishment – and our "Why" poster is on the wall.

DAY

3

WEEK 1

Screen-Free Zones & Times

🎯 Make meals, bedrooms and car rides screen-free.

⌚ 45 min

👨‍👩‍👧 Whole family



Day 3 comic: Screen-Free Zones



Sushma Ma'am says



Arguing about minutes is exhausting: "Five more!" "No, now!" Today we use a smarter tool – **places and times** where screens simply don't go, for anyone. A clear boundary like "phones don't come to the table" needs far less policing than a timer.

Why this works

Our brains link habits to **places**. If the phone always comes to the dinner table, the table itself becomes a cue for the phone (remember the habit loop from Day 1). When a place becomes screen-free for everyone, the cue disappears – and so does the daily fight. Children also argue less with a rule that applies to the whole family and never changes.



What Research Says

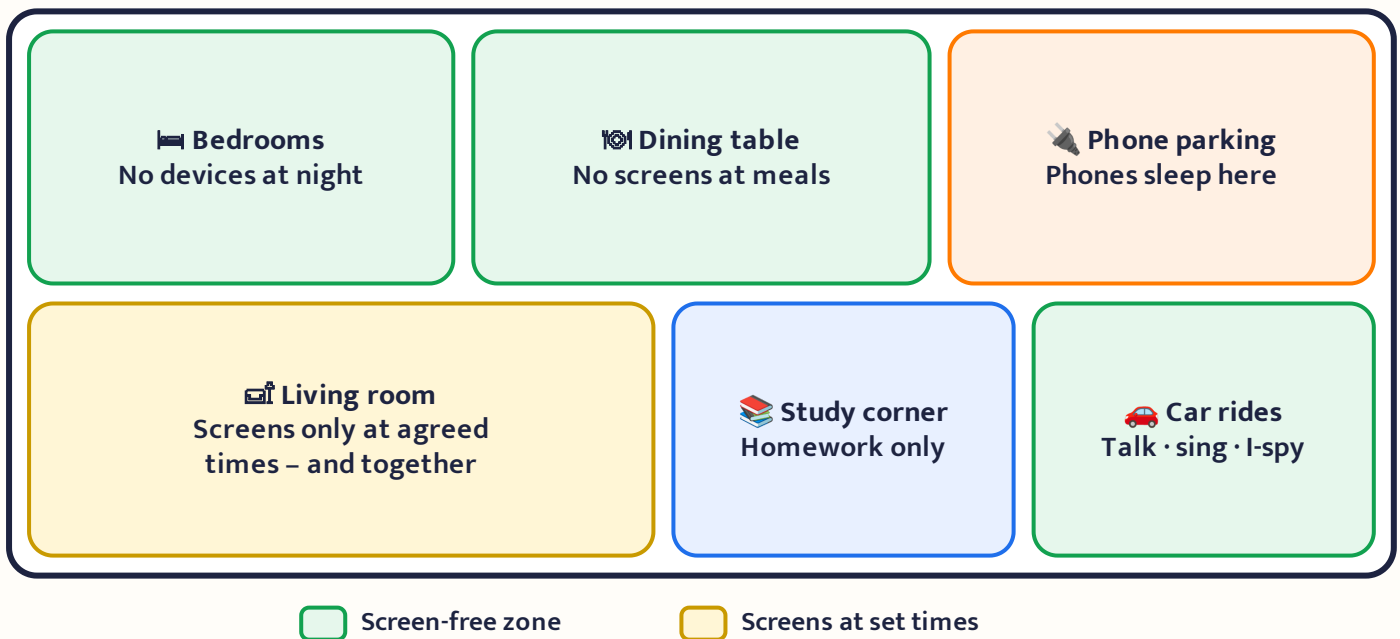
The **Indian Academy of Pediatrics** advises **no screens during meals** and none in the hour before bedtime. The **American Academy of Pediatrics** suggests screen-free zones such as **bedrooms and the dinner table** as part of a Family Media Plan.



Child Psychology Insight

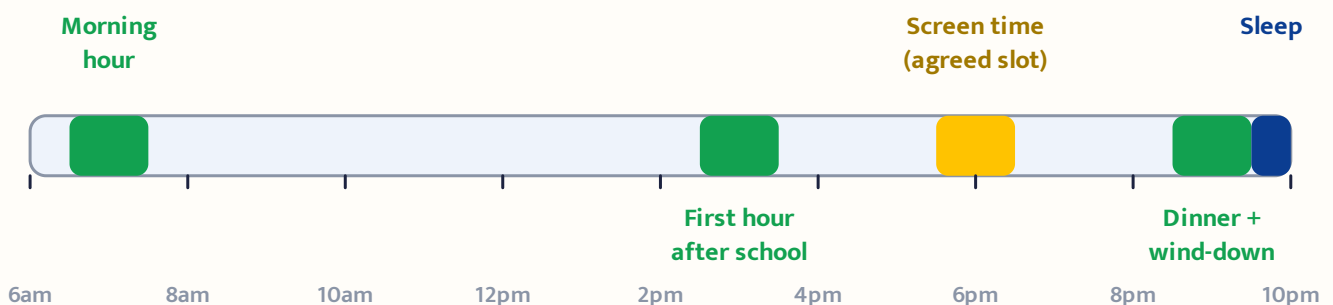
When children eat in front of a cartoon, they eat on autopilot – they don't notice taste, fullness or the people around them. Meal-time talk is one of the richest language and bonding moments of the day. The **first hour after school** matters too: a child coming home is tired, hungry and full of stories. If a screen fills that hour, the stories – and the chance to notice how your child's day really went – are lost.

Our home map of screen-free zones



Start with the green zones. They apply to parents and grandparents too.

...and screen-free times in a school day (example for a 10-year-old)



✓ Today's Action Steps

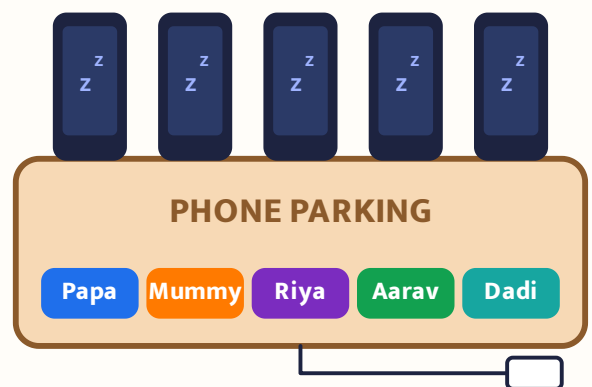
- 1 Choose your first 2 zones** from the map – most families start with the **dining table** and **bedrooms at night**. Add more only when these feel easy.
- 2 Build a phone parking station** near the entrance or in the living room – a basket, a shoebox or a shelf with a multi-plug. Every device "sleeps" there at night, including parents' phones.
- 3 Protect the first hour after school:** snack, wash up, a chat or outdoor play first. "How was your day?" gets short answers; try "What was the funniest thing today?"
- 4 Make car rides talk time.** Keep a "car kit": I-spy, antakshari, 20 questions, a story chain where each person adds one line.
- 5 Fill the gap at meals** with something fun: "rose and thorn" (best and hardest part of the day), guess-the-ingredient, or Dadi's story.



Make it: the phone parking station

- Take a shoebox or basket. Let the children decorate it.
- Make a name tag for every family device.
- Add one multi-plug so phones charge overnight.
- Agree a parking time (e.g., 8:30 pm) and write it on the box.
- A child can be the "parking attendant" who checks in phones.

Good night, phones!



Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "Give me that phone, you're not eating properly!"	✓ "Phones don't come to the table – mine too. Let's see who can guess what's in the sabzi."
✗ "Why is your phone in your room again?"	✓ "It's 8:30 – parking time! I'm parking mine. Want to race?"
✗ "Stop playing that in the car!"	✓ "Car = our chat zone. Your turn to pick the first antakshari song!"



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Meals without screens may bring a few days of fussing. Keep portions small, eat together, talk and sing – hunger and your company will do the work. Never force-feed.

Age 6–9

Give them a job at the table: laying plates, serving salad, "question master" who asks everyone one question.

Age 10–13

Keep gaming consoles and computers in shared spaces, not bedrooms. Let them design the parking station and the rules for guests.

Age 14–16

Explain the "why" (sleep, focus) and negotiate the parking time. If they need an alarm, buy a simple alarm clock – the phone still parks outside.



Common problems & what to do

- **"But I need the phone to study!"** Homework on a device happens at the study corner in a shared space, with the door open, and the phone parks when homework ends.
- **A parent's phone rings during dinner.** Let it ring (emergency calls can be allowed – tell the family in advance). Children watch how you handle this moment very closely.
- **Dadi's TV serial is on during dinner.** Talk to her privately and kindly. Maybe she can record it or watch after dinner – and become the star storyteller at the table.



Tonight's 2-minute reflection

Which zone was easiest to keep? Which one was hardest – and why?

What did we talk about at the table today that we would have missed?



Today's Win

Our home now has screen-free places and times – and the phones have their own parking spot.

DAY

4

WEEK 1

The Digital Sunset

🕒 Screens off 1 hour before sleep, with a calm bedtime routine.

🕒 Every evening

👤 Whole family



Day 4 comic: The Digital Sunset



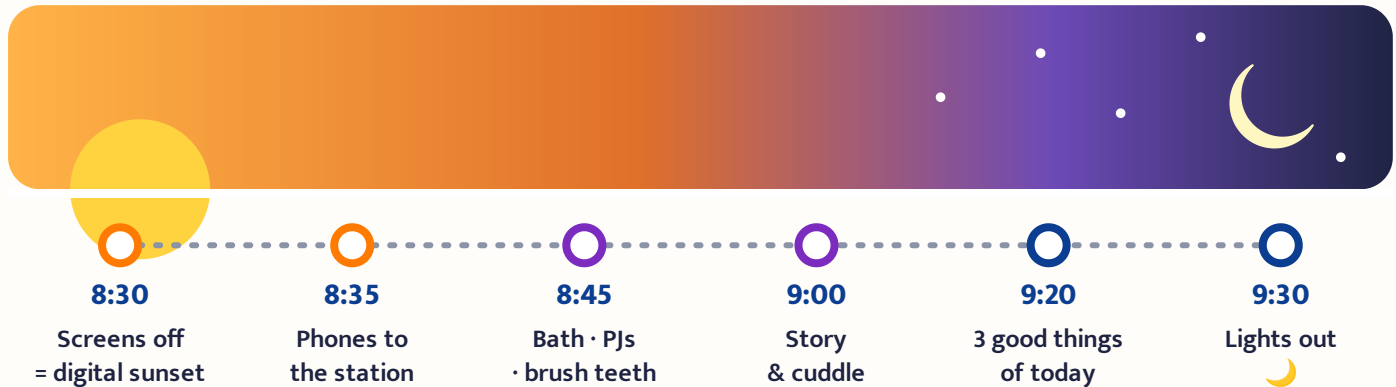
Sushma Ma'am says



Of all the changes in this book, this one may give you the fastest reward: **better sleep**. The sun sets every evening, and so should our screens. Today we create a **digital sunset** – screens off one hour before bed – and replace it with a calm, cosy routine your child will slowly start to love.

Why this works

Screens before bed delay sleep in two ways. First, **stimulation**: an exciting game, a scary video or a group chat keeps the brain alert, just when it should be slowing down. Second, **light**: bright screens in a dark room tell the body "it's still daytime", which can delay the natural sleepiness that comes in the evening. And a phone in the bedroom invites "just one more" – for children and adults alike.



An example digital-sunset evening for a 6–10-year-old. Shift the times to suit your child.



What Research Says

- **IAP** advises no screens in the **1 hour before bedtime**.
- **AAP** recommends keeping devices **out of bedrooms at night** and charging them elsewhere.
- Good sleep supports attention, mood, memory, growth and immunity – many "behaviour problems" improve when sleep improves.

Age

Sleep needed in 24 hours

1–2 years	11–14 hours (incl. naps)
3–5 years	10–13 hours (incl. naps)
6–12 years	9–12 hours
13–18 years	8–10 hours

Source: American Academy of Sleep Medicine
(consensus, endorsed by the AAP).



Child Psychology Insight

Young children feel safe when evenings are **predictable**. A routine done in the same order every night acts like a signal to the body: bath → teeth → story → lights out means "sleep is coming". The last 20 minutes of the day are also golden for connection. Children often share worries at bedtime that they never mention at dinner – but only if nobody is looking at a screen.



Wind-down ideas (no screens)

- Dadi-Nani stories, or "the story of when you were born"
- Picture books, comics, a chapter a night
- Soft music, bhajans, lullabies
- Gentle stretches or "balloon breathing"
- Drawing or a gratitude journal
- A back rub and "rose & thorn" talk



For the teen who says "I need music to sleep"

Fair enough! Offer a cheap speaker or an old device with only music, set on a sleep timer. The phone with chats and reels still parks outside. Agree on this **together** – the goal is sleep, not control.

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Fix a lights-out time** for each child based on the sleep table and school timing. Count back 1 hour – that is your **digital sunset**.
- 2 **Give a 15-minute warning** before sunset: "15 minutes left – finish your level / episode." Stopping at a natural end reduces meltdowns.
- 3 **All devices park at the station** – TV off, parents' phones too. Dim the lights in the house.
- 4 **Follow the same wind-down order** every night (chart below) – bath, teeth, story or chat, three good things, lights out.
- 5 **Keep the weekend close to the weekday time** (within about an hour) so Monday mornings don't become a battle.

🌙 Printable: our wind-down routine chart

Stick it near the bed. Your child ticks each step – young children can use stickers. Fill in your times.

Step	Time	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
📱 Screens off & phones parked		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🛁 Wash / bath & night clothes		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🪥 Brush teeth & toilet		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
📖 Story, reading or chat		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🙏 3 good things / prayer		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🌙 Lights out on time		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

💡 Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "Switch it off NOW and go to sleep!"	✓ "15 minutes to sunset! Finish your level – then it's story time."
✗ "You'll ruin your eyes and your marks!"	✓ "Your brain grows and stores what you learned while you sleep. Let's give it a full night."
✗ "No arguments, I'm the parent."	✓ "I know it's hard to stop. My phone is parking now too. Race you to the station!"
✗ "Why can't you just sleep?!"	✓ "Your body is still a bit busy. Let's do three slow balloon breaths together."



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Bath, one story, one song, same order every night. No screens as a sleep aid. A soft toy can become the "sleep buddy".

Age 6–9

Use a picture chart with stickers. Let them choose the story and the pyjamas – small choices, big cooperation.

Age 10–13

Read together – you a page, they a page. Tweens still love a parent sitting on the bed and chatting.

Age 14–16

Talk about sleep as a performance tool (sports, exams, skin, mood). Agree a phone parking time; offer a real alarm clock.



If your child...

- **Takes the phone back secretly at night.** Stay calm; don't make it a crime. Move the parking station to your room for a week, and talk in the morning about what made it hard.
- **Lies awake for a long time.** In the first week the body is still adjusting. Keep the routine; avoid heavy food, sugar and exciting play late in the evening.
- **Has regular nightmares, snoring or daytime sleepiness despite enough time in bed** – please talk to your paediatrician.



Tonight's 2-minute reflection

What time did each child actually fall asleep tonight?

Which part of our wind-down routine did my child enjoy most?



Today's Win

Our screens set with the sun tonight – and we ended the day with a story instead of a scroll.



Sources & further reading

1. Indian Academy of Pediatrics – screen-time guidance for children (2021).
2. American Academy of Pediatrics – Family Media Plan, [healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan](https://www.healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan).
3. American Academy of Sleep Medicine – recommended amount of sleep for children (consensus statement, endorsed by the AAP).

DAY

5

WEEK 1

Beat Boredom Without a Screen

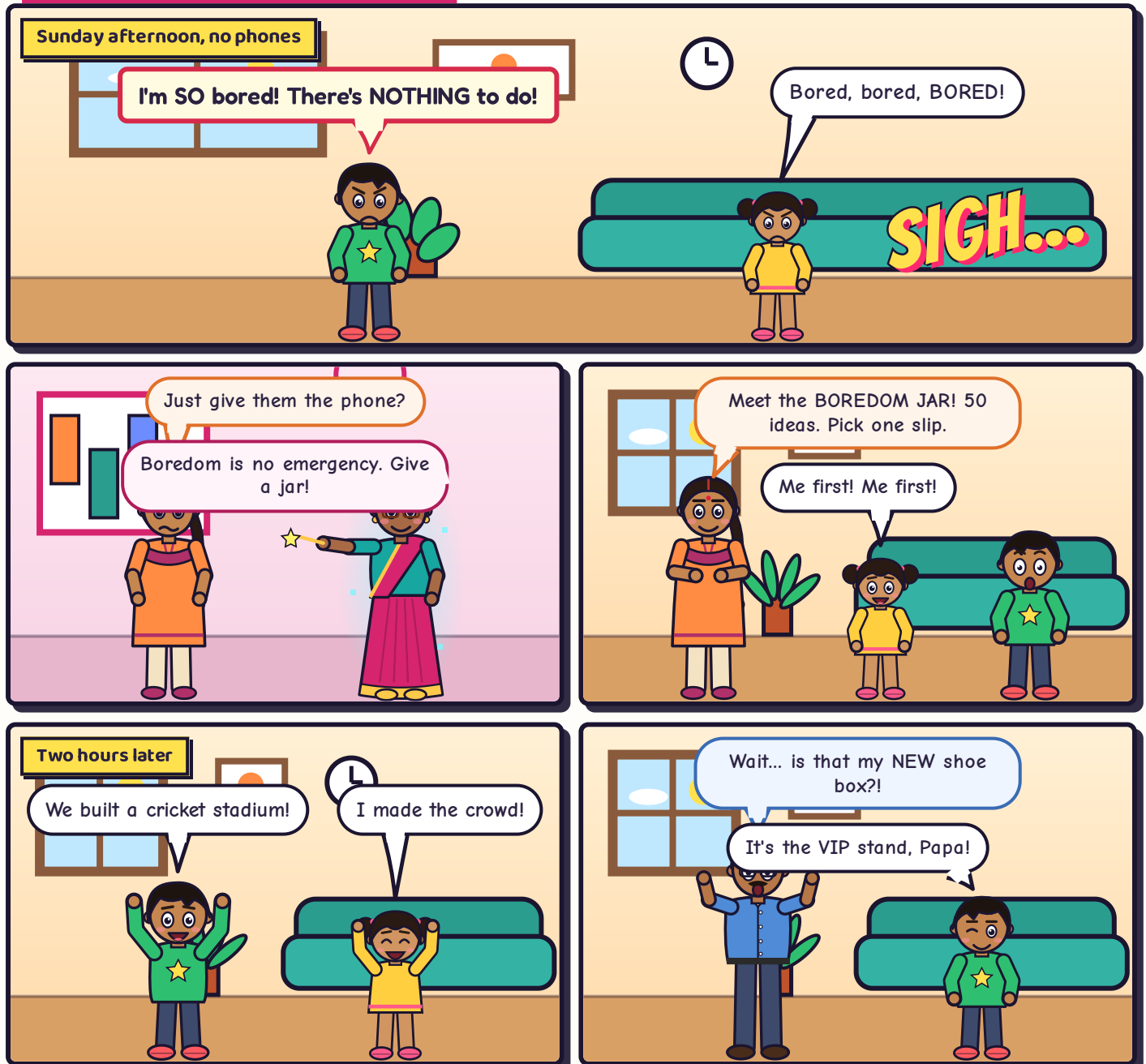
🎯 Make a boredom jar and let boredom spark creativity.

⌚ 40 min

👤 With the children



Day 5 comic: The Boredom Jar



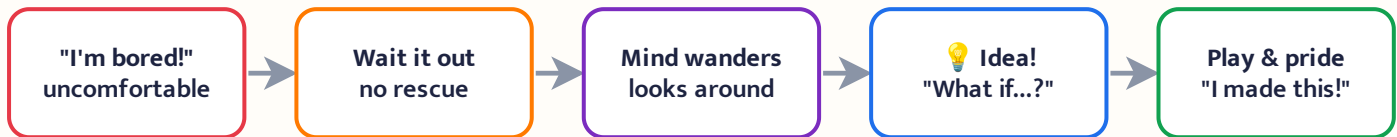
Sushma Ma'am says



"I'm bored!" – these two words send many parents running for the phone. Boredom is not a problem you must solve for your child – it is the **empty space where imagination grows**. Your job is not to entertain – it is to **wait**, and to keep a few good ideas within reach.

Why boredom builds creativity

A screen fills every empty second with someone else's ideas. When nothing is handed to them, children must **look inside and around** for something to do. That uncomfortable pause is exactly where they practise planning, problem-solving and imagination. Children who learn to handle a little boredom grow into teenagers who can entertain themselves – and don't need a feed to feel okay.

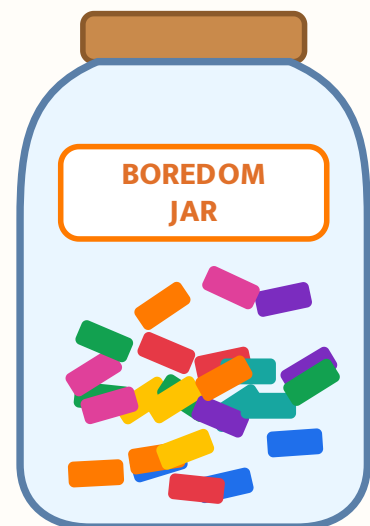


Child Psychology Insight

Psychologists have found that boredom nudges the mind to **wander** and to look for something new – and mind-wandering is closely linked with creative ideas. Boredom is also a lesson in **self-regulation**: learning to sit with a mildly uncomfortable feeling without rushing to escape it. If every boring moment is rescued with a screen, the child never builds this muscle. The first few days are the loudest; after that, children usually start finding things on their own.

✓ Make your boredom jar

- 1 Find a jar** – an old pickle jar, a dabba or a decorated box.
- 2 Cut colourful paper slips** and write one idea per slip (use the 50 ideas below; add your own).
- 3 Let children add their own ideas** – they will be more willing to do them.
- 4 The rule:** "If you say *I'm bored*, you pick a slip – or find your own thing. No swapping more than once!"
- 5 Keep supplies ready:** paper, colours, tape, cardboard, a ball, old clothes for dress-up.



⚠ If your child...

- Rejects every slip.** That's fine – "Then you can find your own thing." Calmly continue your work. Boredom tends to peak just before an idea arrives.
- Makes a huge mess.** Build in clean-up as part of the game ("stadium closes at 7 pm!"). A messy afternoon is better than a silent screen.
- Only wants you to play.** Join for 10 minutes to get it going, then step away: "You carry on, I'll come back to see."



50 boredom-busters by age

Cut, fold and drop into the jar. Mix in a few from the younger list for older children to do *with* siblings.

Age 2–5

1. Make a pillow-and-bedsheet fort
2. Play with dough or atta
3. Stack steel katoris into a tower
4. Dance to 3 songs
5. Wash toys in a tub of water
6. Colour a big sheet of paper
7. Sort things by colour
8. Animal walk: hop like a frog
9. Bubbles on the balcony
10. Help water the plants
11. Puppet show with socks
12. Treasure hunt for 5 spoons

Age 6–9

13. Build a cardboard city
14. Draw your own comic
15. Paper boats or planes contest
16. Carrom, ludo or snakes & ladders
17. Plant a seed and label it
18. Make a rangoli with rice or flowers
19. Invent a new board game
20. Skipping, hopscotch (stapu)
21. Write a letter to Nani
22. Help make a salad or sandwich
23. Shadow puppets with a torch
24. Put on a magic show
25. Leaf and stone collection

Age 10–13

26. Build a cardboard cricket stadium
27. Learn 3 card tricks
28. Write and act a 5-minute play
29. Cook a simple dish (with an adult)
30. Chess or a 500-piece puzzle
31. Make a family newspaper
32. Cycle or skate round the colony
33. Fix or clean your cycle
34. Origami: 5 new models
35. Learn a song on a keyboard or flute
36. Science experiment: volcano with soda
37. Sketch the view from your window
38. Interview Dadi about her childhood

Age 14–16

39. Start a journal or poem notebook
40. Learn to cook one full meal
41. Rearrange or redecorate your room
42. Go for a walk or run with a friend
43. Read a novel from the library
44. Learn a craft: knitting, clay, sketching
45. Plan a family outing – budget & route
46. Teach a younger child something
47. Practise a sport skill for 30 min
48. Volunteer: help a neighbour
49. Write a short story
50. Board-game night with friends

Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
X "Here, take the phone and stop whining."	✓ "Bored? Great – your brain is about to invent something. Jar or your own idea?"
X "Go and study then!"	✓ "I wonder what you'll come up with. Call me when it's ready – I want to see!"
X "When I was young we were never bored!"	✓ "When I was bored as a kid, I made paper boats. Want me to show you?"
X "Stop following me around!"	✓ "Come and help me knead the atta – then you can make your own shapes."

**Age-wise Guide****Age 2–5**

Little ones need you nearby. Set up an "invitation" – a tray of dough and cutters, a box of blocks – then step back and watch.

Age 6–9

Keep a "maker box" of scrap: cartons, bottle caps, ribbons. Praise effort and ideas, not neatness.

Age 10–13

Give real challenges and real tools: a toolkit, a cookbook, a budget of ₹100 for a project. Let siblings team up.

Age 14–16

Teens rarely say "bored" – they scroll. Invite, don't assign: "I'm going for a walk / making pakoras, want to join?"

**Tonight's 2-minute reflection**

What did my child create or discover when I didn't rescue them from boredom?

Which ideas from the jar were the biggest hits?

**Today's Win**

Our boredom jar is ready – and we let boredom do its creative work instead of reaching for a screen.

DAY

6

WEEK 1

Parents Go First

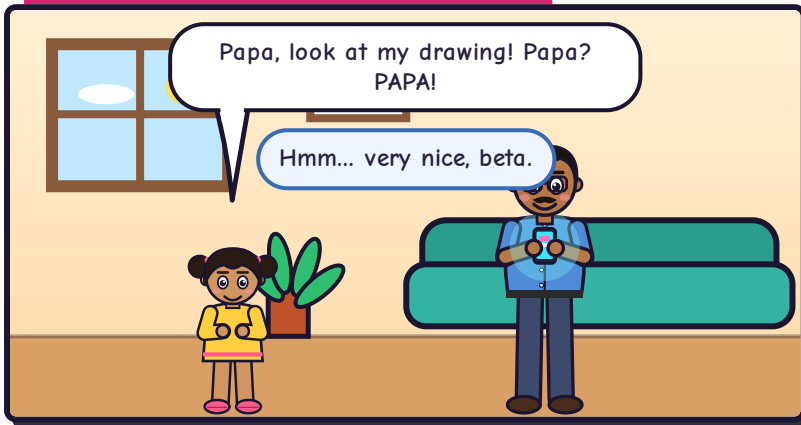
🎯 Tame your own phone: fewer alerts, phone-free hours.

🕒 30 min setup

👤 Parents



Day 6 comic: Parents Go First



Sushma Ma'am says

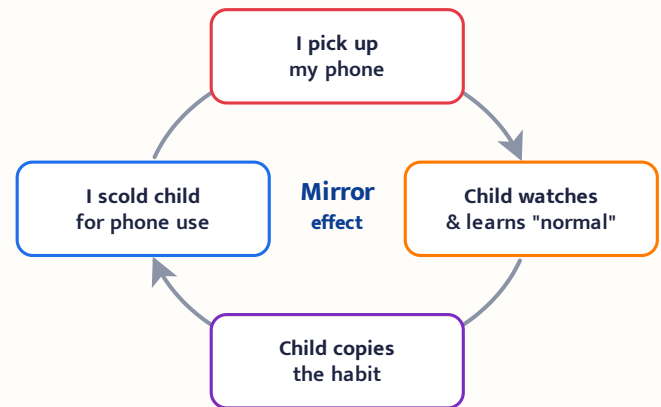


Today is about **us**, the grown-ups. I say this with love, not blame: we cannot ask our children to put down their phones while ours are glued to our hands. The good news? When parents change, children follow – often without a single lecture.

Why this works

Child Psychology Insight

Children learn most behaviour by **watching** the people they love – psychologists call this **social learning** or **modelling** (Albert Bandura). If they see us reach for the phone when we're bored, tired or waiting, they learn: *"This is how grown-ups handle feelings."* Our phone habits also send a quieter message. When we look at the screen while they talk, a child can feel *"I matter less than that phone."*



What Research Says

Researchers use the word **"technoference"** for everyday interruptions of family time by devices. Studies have linked frequent parent phone interruptions with more attention-seeking, whining and acting-out in young children – children often "act up" simply to get their parent's eyes back. The AAP's Family Media Plan includes **parents' own** device habits for exactly this reason.

Honest self-check: my own phone habits

	Never (0)	Sometimes (1)	Often (2)
1. I check my phone within a few minutes of waking up.	☐	☐	☐
2. I look at my phone during meals with the family.	☐	☐	☐
3. I say "one minute, beta" while scrolling.	☐	☐	☐
4. I use my phone in bed before sleeping.	☐	☐	☐
5. I reach for the phone when I feel bored or stressed.	☐	☐	☐
6. My child has complained about my phone use.	☐	☐	☐
7. I use the phone while driving or at a red light.	☐	☐	☐
8. I feel restless if my phone is not near me.	☐	☐	☐

0–4 Great modelling – keep it up and share your tricks with your partner.

5–10 Very common. Pick two steps below and start today.

11–16 Your phone is running your day. Be kind to yourself – and do all the steps this week.

✓ Today's action steps: the parent phone detox

- 1 **Turn off non-essential notifications.** Keep calls, messages from family and truly urgent work. Switch off social media, shopping, games and news alerts. Mute busy WhatsApp groups (society, school, relatives) and check them at fixed times – say, 1 pm and 7 pm.
- 2 **Clean your home screen.** Move social media and video apps off the first screen, into a folder. Every extra tap gives your brain a moment to choose.
- 3 **Set your phone-free hours** – at least the first 30 minutes after coming home, meals, and the family hour before the children sleep. Use Focus / Do Not Disturb mode so only chosen contacts get through.
- 4 **Say it out loud.** "I'm putting my phone away to be with you." Naming it teaches your child what you value – and makes you accountable.
- 5 **Narrate necessary use.** When you must use the phone, say why: "I'm paying the electricity bill – two minutes." It shows the phone is a tool, not a hideout.
- 6 **Park your phone at night** at the family station and use an alarm clock. The children will notice – that is the point.

My phone-free hours plan

Time of day	My phone-free window	What I'll do instead	Kept? (M–S)
Morning			□□□□□□
Coming home			□□□□□□
Meals			□□□□□□
Before kids sleep			□□□□□□

🗣️ Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "Wait, I'm busy." (eyes on phone)	✓ "I'm putting my phone away to be with you. Tell me."
✗ "I'm an adult, I can use my phone."	✓ "You're right, I'm on it too much. Will you help me catch myself?"
✗ (Silently checking the phone at a red light)	✓ "Phone stays in the bag while I drive. Your turn to pick a song!"
✗ "Just one minute, beta..." (20 minutes later)	✓ "I need 5 minutes for work. Set the timer – when it rings, I'm all yours."



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Babies and toddlers read your face all day. Put the phone away during feeding, bath and play – your eye contact builds their language and security.

Age 6–9

Make your child the "phone police" – they can say "Phone parking!" when they catch you. Laugh and obey.

Age 10–13

Share your own struggle honestly: "These apps are hard to put down for me too. Here's what I'm trying."

Age 14–16

Teens spot hypocrisy instantly. Ask them to review your screen-time report with you and suggest one change for you.



Real-life hurdles

- **"My job needs me on call."** Then be available – but in one place. Take work calls in another room, then come back fully. Tell your boss/team your family hour if possible.
- **Your partner isn't on board.** Don't lecture them in front of the kids. Change yourself first and share how it feels – people copy results, not arguments.
- **You slip back after two days.** Totally normal. Notice it without guilt, reset the next morning. Progress, not perfection.



Tonight's 2-minute reflection

How did my child react when I put my phone away for them?

Which notification did I miss least after turning it off?



Today's Win

I went first. My notifications are quieter, and my child heard me say, "I'm putting my phone away to be with you."

DAY
7

WEEK 1

Week 1 Review & Celebrate

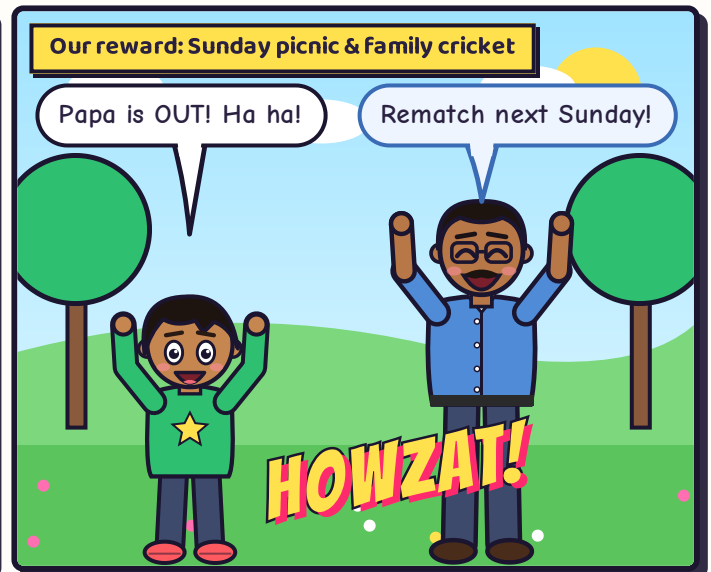
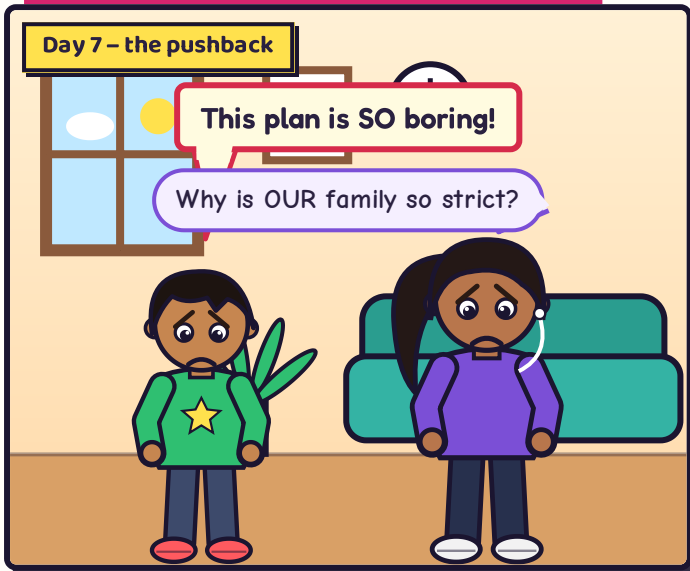
🎯 Look back, handle pushback calmly, celebrate.

🕒 45 min

👨‍👩‍👧‍👦 Whole family



Day 7 comic: Review & Celebrate



Sushma Ma'am says



You made it through Week 1! Today we pause, look back honestly, and **celebrate**. Some days went well and some didn't – that's exactly how real change looks. And if your child pushed back this week, take it as a sign that the plan is actually working. Let me show you why.

Why pushback is a good sign

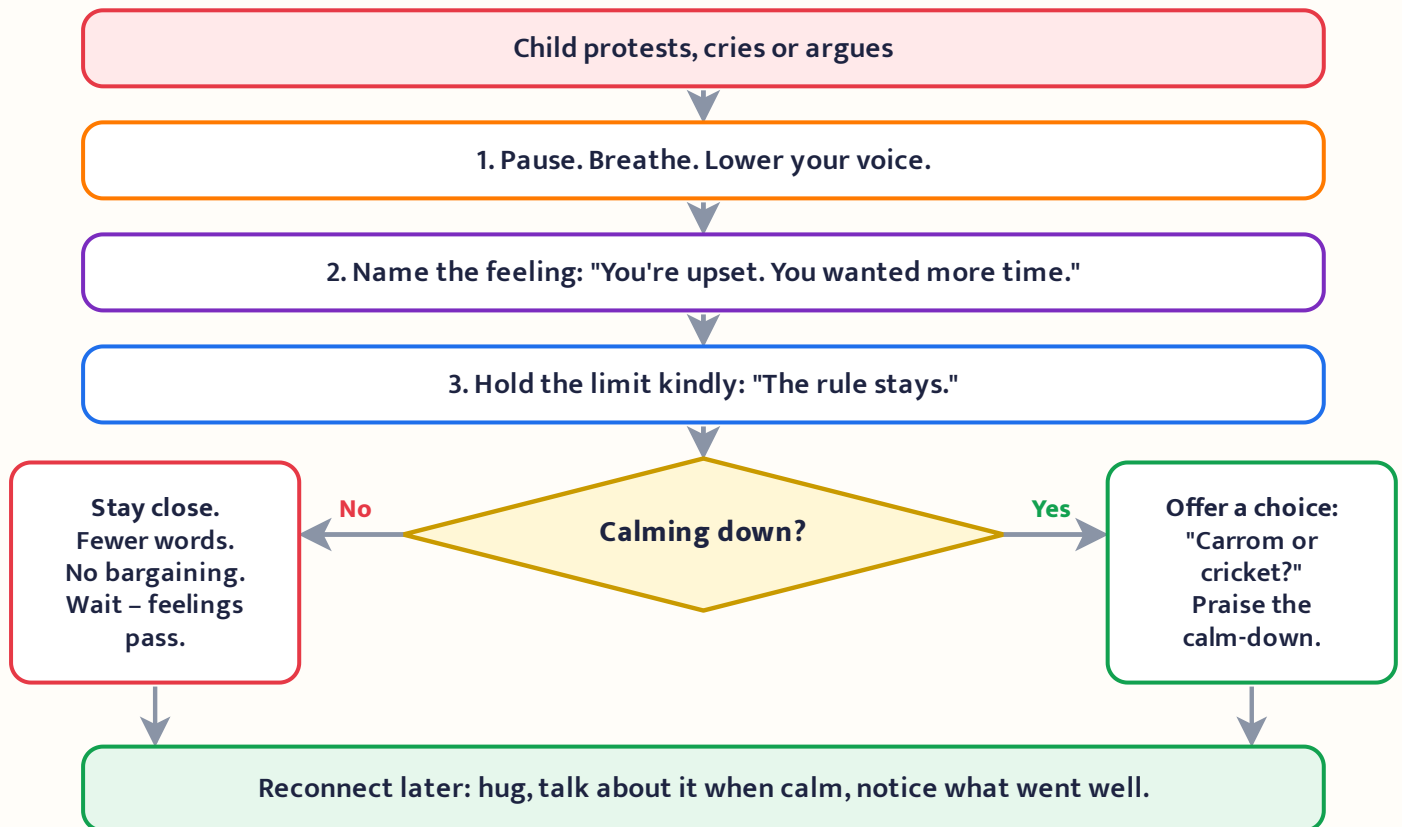
When a behaviour that used to "work" stops working, it often gets **worse before it gets better**. The child tries harder – louder protests, bargaining, tears – to check whether the old rules are really gone. If the parent stays calm and consistent, this wave passes. If the parent gives in during the peak, the child learns that bigger protests work – and the next wave is bigger.



Child Psychology Insight

Psychologists call this an **extinction burst**. It is normal, temporary and not a sign that your child is "addicted" or that you are doing something wrong. The key is **firm + kind**: acknowledge the feeling fully ("You're angry, you miss your game") while keeping the limit ("and the phone is still parked"). Feelings are always allowed; the rule simply doesn't move. Your calm voice is the most powerful tool you have in this moment.

Handling the first pushback – a calm flowchart



If this week felt like a failure...

- **You gave in a few times.** Everyone does. Just don't give in during the loudest moment – wait for calm, then decide.
- **Only one change stuck.** One lasting change is worth more than five that collapse. Keep it and add one more next week.
- **Pushback is extreme** – hitting, breaking things, threats of self-harm, or it doesn't settle after 2–3 weeks. This needs professional support: talk to a paediatrician or child psychologist, or call **Tele-MANAS 14416** (free, 24x7). In an emergency, call **112**.



Our Week 1 review

Sit together for 15 minutes. For each day, colour the stars (did it · stayed calm · had fun) and fill the columns together – let the children speak first.

Day	Stars	What worked	What was hard	Keep / tweak
1 Screen detective	☐ ☐ ☐			
2 Family meeting	☐ ☐ ☐			
3 Screen-free zones	☐ ☐ ☐			
4 Digital sunset	☐ ☐ ☐			
5 Boredom jar	☐ ☐ ☐			
6 Parents go first	☐ ☐ ☐			

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 Hold a 15-minute review meeting** with snacks. Go through the table above, one day at a time.
- 2 Name one win for each person** – including yourself. Be specific: "Aarav, you parked your phone without being reminded on Thursday."
- 3 Choose what to keep and what to tweak.** Maybe the parking time moves to 8:45, or car rides get a new game. Small adjustments keep the plan alive.
- 4 Celebrate with a non-screen reward** the family chose together (ideas below). Rewarding screen-free effort with extra screen time sends a mixed message.
- 5 Write your family reward on the 21-Day Tracker** at the front of the book, and look ahead to Week 2: Replace & Rebuild.

🎉 Non-screen reward ideas – tick your pick

- ☐ Sunday picnic in the park
- ☐ Family cricket or badminton match
- ☐ Children choose the dinner menu
- ☐ Bake or cook something special together
- ☐ Bedsheet-tent "camping" night in the living room
- ☐ Trip to the library or a bookshop
- ☐ Visit Nani / a cousin
- ☐ 15 extra minutes of bedtime story
- ☐ Ice-cream walk after dinner



Colour the badge and write your family name!

 Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "Stop complaining! Other families don't matter."	✓ "It feels unfair when friends have more time. Every family has different rules – ours are about sleep and fun together."
✗ "Fine, take the phone, just stop crying!"	✓ "I'm right here. You can be upset. The phone is still parked."
✗ "If you behave, you'll get an extra hour of games."	✓ "We did so well this week – let's celebrate with a picnic!"
✗ "This week was a failure, you didn't follow anything."	✓ "We had 4 good days out of 7. That's a great start – what will help next week?"

 Age-wise Guide
Age 2–5

Celebrate right away with something physical and joyful: a dance party, a sticker, a special walk. Little ones need rewards soon after the effort.

Age 6–9

Let them colour the tracker stars and the Week 1 badge. Praise effort: "You kept trying even when it was hard."

Age 10–13

Let them run the review meeting and choose the reward within a budget. Ask: "What rule would you change, and why?"

Age 14–16

Recognise their maturity privately. Offer more say in Week 2 in exchange for keeping the agreed basics (sleep, meals).

 Tonight's 2-minute reflection

What is the one change from Week 1 I am most proud of?

How did I handle the first pushback – and what would I do the same or differently next time?

What does my child seem to enjoy most now that screens are less?

 Today's Win

Week 1 is done! We observed, talked, set zones and a bedtime, beat boredom, changed our own habits – and celebrated together without a screen.

WEEK 2 • DAYS 8–14

Replace & Rebuild

Fill the gap with play, stories, chores, creativity and connection.



DAY

8

WEEK 2

Green Time: Outdoor Play

🎯 Spend at least 30 minutes outdoors together, playing.

🕒 30–60 min

👨‍👩‍👧 Whole family



🗨️ Day 8 comic: Papa, the Gilli-Danda Champion



🗨️ Sushma Ma'am says



Last week you took some screen time away. This week we **fill that space** – and the best filler is the sky above your child's head. A child who has run, jumped and laughed outdoors comes home tired in the right way, hungry at dinner and sleepy at bedtime. Today, just go out together – even 30 minutes on the terrace counts.



Why this works

Screens hold children with fast, easy rewards. Outdoor play offers a different, slower kind of reward: the joy of mastering a skill, the thrill of running free, and real friends laughing next to you. The body also needs movement to grow strong bones and muscles, and daylight helps set the body clock so that sleep comes easily at night.



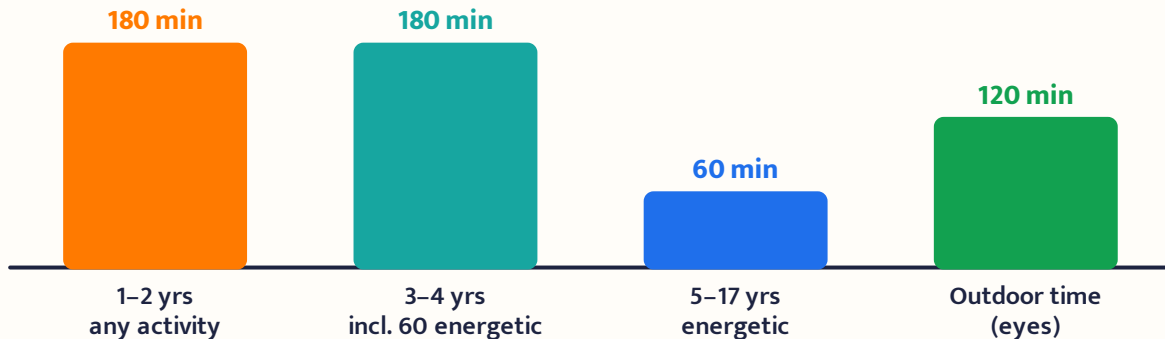
Child Psychology Insight

Play is how children learn self-control. In games like kho-kho or chor-police, children must wait their turn, follow rules, handle losing and switch quickly between running and stopping. Child psychologists call these *executive function* skills – the very "brakes" that help a child put the phone down later. Rough-and-tumble play with a parent also builds trust and teaches a child how to handle strong excitement safely.



What Research Says

- **WHO (2019, under-5s):** children aged 1–4 should spend at least **180 minutes a day** in physical activity of any kind; for 3–4-year-olds, at least 60 minutes of that should be energetic.
- **WHO (5–17 years):** an average of at least **60 minutes a day** of moderate-to-vigorous activity – running, cycling, games, sports.
- **Eyes:** more time outdoors in daylight (around 2 hours a day) is linked with a lower risk of short-sightedness (myopia) in children.



Daily movement and outdoor time – minutes per day (WHO guidance; outdoor time for eye health).

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Pick a fixed "green hour"** – e.g. 5–6 pm, after homework, before screens. Same time daily builds a habit.
- 2 **Go out with them today**, not just send them. Your presence is the invitation.
- 3 **Teach one game from your childhood** – gilli-danda, stapu, pitthu, kho-kho. Children love seeing parents play.
- 4 **Make an outdoor kit** by the door: ball, skipping rope, chalk, shuttlecock, a water bottle.
- 5 **Invite one neighbour's child.** Play with friends beats play alone – and other parents often join in.



No park? No problem – the Play Menu

Many Indian families live in flats with little open space. Children don't need a big ground – a terrace, a building compound, a quiet gali or even a corridor works. Stick this menu on the fridge and let the child choose.

Game	Where	Players	Best for ages	Skill it builds
Stapu / hopscotch (chalk boxes)	Terrace, compound	1+	4+	Balance, counting
Kho-kho	Ground, compound	8+	7+	Speed, teamwork
Gilli-danda	Open ground only	2+	9+, with an adult	Aim, timing
Pitthu / Lagori (seven stones)	Gali, ground	6+	6+	Throwing, strategy
Chor-police, chhupan-chhupai	Anywhere safe	3+	3+	Planning, imagination
Statue / oonch-neechee	Terrace, room	3+	3+	Stopping on cue (self-control!)
Skiping, badminton, cycling	Terrace, lane	1–2	5+	Stamina, coordination
Kabaddi, langdi	Soft ground	6+	8+	Strength, courage



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Free play in a safe space: sand, water, chasing bubbles, walking on a kerb holding your hand. Aim for lots of movement across the day, not one sports session.

Age 6–9

Traditional games, cycling, climbing. They love rules and "races". Give simple challenges: "Can you skip 20 times?"

Age 10–13

Team sports, a coaching class, cricket with the colony gang. Let them organise the game – planning is half the fun.

Age 14–16

Gym, running, dance, a morning walk with a parent. Pair movement with friends or music; respect their choice of sport.



Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Go out and play! You're always stuck to that phone.	✓ I'm going to the terrace with the ball – who wants to beat me at catch?
✗ It's too hot/dirty outside, stay in.	✓ Let's go at 6 when it's cooler. Carry water and a cap.
✗ Don't fall! Don't run! Be careful!	✓ Check your footing – you can do it.
✗ You lost again? You're so slow.	✓ You kept trying even when it was hard. Want to practise together?

**If your child says...**

- **"Outside is boring."** – Boredom is normal for the first few days. Stay 10 minutes with them and start a game yourself; the fun usually begins after the boredom.
- **"No one plays outside any more."** – Be the parent who starts it. Message two families in the building WhatsApp group: "Kids' game on the terrace, 5:30 pm."
- **"Can I take the phone to the park?"** – No phones in the green hour, for adults too. You can keep one phone in your bag for emergencies.

**Activity: Our Green-Hour Week**

Fill in each evening. A tick for every day you were outside for at least 30 minutes – aim for 5 ticks this week!

Day	Where we went	What we played	Minutes	Mood after (😊 😐 😞)
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

**Too hot, rainy or smoggy outside?**

- **Freeze dance** – music on, stop when it stops.
- **Cushion obstacle course** in the living room.
- **Stair race** with a parent (hold the railing!).
- **Animal yoga** – cat, cobra, tree, butterfly.
- **Balloon volleyball** – don't let it touch the floor!

**Today's Win**

We spent time outdoors **together** – and nobody missed the phone for that hour.

**Tonight's 2-minute reflection**

How did my child's mood, appetite or sleep change on the day we went out?

Which game from my own childhood can I teach this week?

DAY

9

WEEK 2

Stories & Books

🎯 Start a 15-minute story time before bed.

🕒 15 min

👵 Grandparents welcome



🗨️ Day 9 comic: Dadi's Magic Stories



🗨️ Sushma Ma'am says



Every screen is a story told *to* your child. A book, or Dadi's voice at bedtime, is a story your child builds *inside* their own head – the pictures, the voices, the ending. That inner picture-making is a muscle. Today we start exercising it, just 15 minutes a day.



Why stories work so well

When you read or tell a story, your child hears rich words they would never hear in daily talk, practises paying attention for a longer time, and imagines how other people feel. Stories also bring you physically close – a lap, a shoulder, a shared blanket. That closeness is exactly what a child is often seeking when they reach for a screen.



Child Psychology Insight

Serve and return. Language grows fastest in back-and-forth talk: the child "serves" (a question, a sound, a point), the adult "returns" it. A screen never waits for your child's answer; Dadi does. That is why shared reading beats even the best educational video for young children.



What Research Says

The **WHO (2019)** guideline for under-5s recommends replacing sedentary screen time with *reading and storytelling with a caregiver*. The **AAP** encourages reading aloud with children from infancy.

Same time
after dinner

Same place
reading corner

Child chooses
the book

Read & chat
"What next?"

Lights off
calm sleep

The bedtime story routine – the same steps every night make it a habit, and replace the "one more video" fight.



Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Create a reading corner** – a cushion, a lamp, a low shelf or basket of books at the child's height.
- 2 **Fix a story time** – 15 minutes after dinner, before bed. Phones stay in the charging spot.
- 3 **Invite the storytellers** – Dadi, Nana, an aunt on the phone. Panchatantra, Jataka, Akbar-Birbal, Tenali Raman, family stories of "when Papa was small".
- 4 **Visit a library or book shop this week** – school library, a community library, or swap books with neighbours.
- 5 **Let them see you read** – a newspaper, a novel, a magazine. Children copy what they see.



Reading routines by age



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Picture books, touch-and-feel books, rhymes, lullabies. Point and name: "Where is the cat?" Same book 20 times is fine – repetition is how they learn.

Age 6–9

You read, then they read a page to you. Comics, Panchatantra, simple chapter books. Ask: "What would you do if you were the crow?"

Age 10–13

Series, mysteries, adventure, biographies of sports stars. Family reading time: everyone reads their own book together for 20 minutes.

Age 14–16

Let them choose – graphic novels, fantasy, non-fiction about their interests. Talk about books like friends do, not like a test.

Audiobooks and story podcasts – are they "screens"?

	Audiobook / story podcast	Videos / cartoons
Imagination	Child builds the pictures	Pictures are given ready-made
Eyes & body	Eyes free – can draw, build, lie down	Eyes fixed on a bright screen
Bedtime	OK on a speaker, screen face-down, with a timer	Delays sleep – avoid 1 hour before bed
Best use	Car rides, quiet time – on a speaker, not in the child's hands	Occasionally, watched together

Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Put the tablet away and read something useful!	✓ I found a book about cricket legends – want to read the first chapter with me?
✗ Comics are a waste. Read proper books.	✓ You finished the whole comic! Which part made you laugh?
✗ Read 20 pages or no TV.	✓ It's story time – you choose the book tonight.

Common traps

- **Turning reading into homework.** Quizzing after every page kills the joy. Chat, don't test.
- **Only "useful" books allowed.** Joke books, comics and sports magazines are reading too. Interest first, quality later.
- **Child can't sit still.** Let them hold a soft toy, act out the story, or listen while drawing. Start with 5 minutes.

Activity: Our Family Story Jar & Reading Log

Write 10 story ideas on chits ("a talking auto-rickshaw", "Dadi's village", "a lost puppy in Chandni Chowk") and put them in a jar. On nights without a book, pull a chit and make up a story together – each person adds one line.

Date	Book / story	Who read or told it	Favourite part



The storyteller's toolkit

Classic story	From	Ages	Talk about...
The Thirsty Crow	Classic fable	3+	Don't give up – think of a clever way
The Monkey and the Crocodile	Panchatantra	4+	Staying calm in danger; true friends
The Lion and the Clever Hare	Panchatantra	5+	Brains beat bullying
The Talkative Tortoise	Panchatantra	5+	Think before you speak
The Blue Jackal	Panchatantra	6+	Being yourself
Birbal's Khichdi	Akbar–Birbal	7+	Fairness, and patience
Tenali Raman and the Thieves	Tenali Raman	7+	Smart thinking under pressure
The Monkey King's Bridge	Jataka tales	8+	Leaders who care for others



Tell it like Dadi

- Give each character a **different voice**.
- **Pause and ask:** "What should he do now?"
- Let the child **finish familiar lines**.
- **Use props** – a spoon becomes the crocodile!
- End with a **question**, not a lecture.



Make a "When I Was Small" book

- Staple 6 sheets of paper into a book.
- Each grown-up tells one story from their childhood.
- The child draws a picture and writes the title.
- Read it together at bedtime – again and again!



Tonight's 2-minute reflection

What story or book did my child enjoy most today, and why?

Who in our family can become our regular storyteller?



Today's Win

Tonight ended with a story instead of a screen – and a child who fell asleep wondering "what happens next?"

DAY
10

WEEK 2

Tantrums & Meltdowns

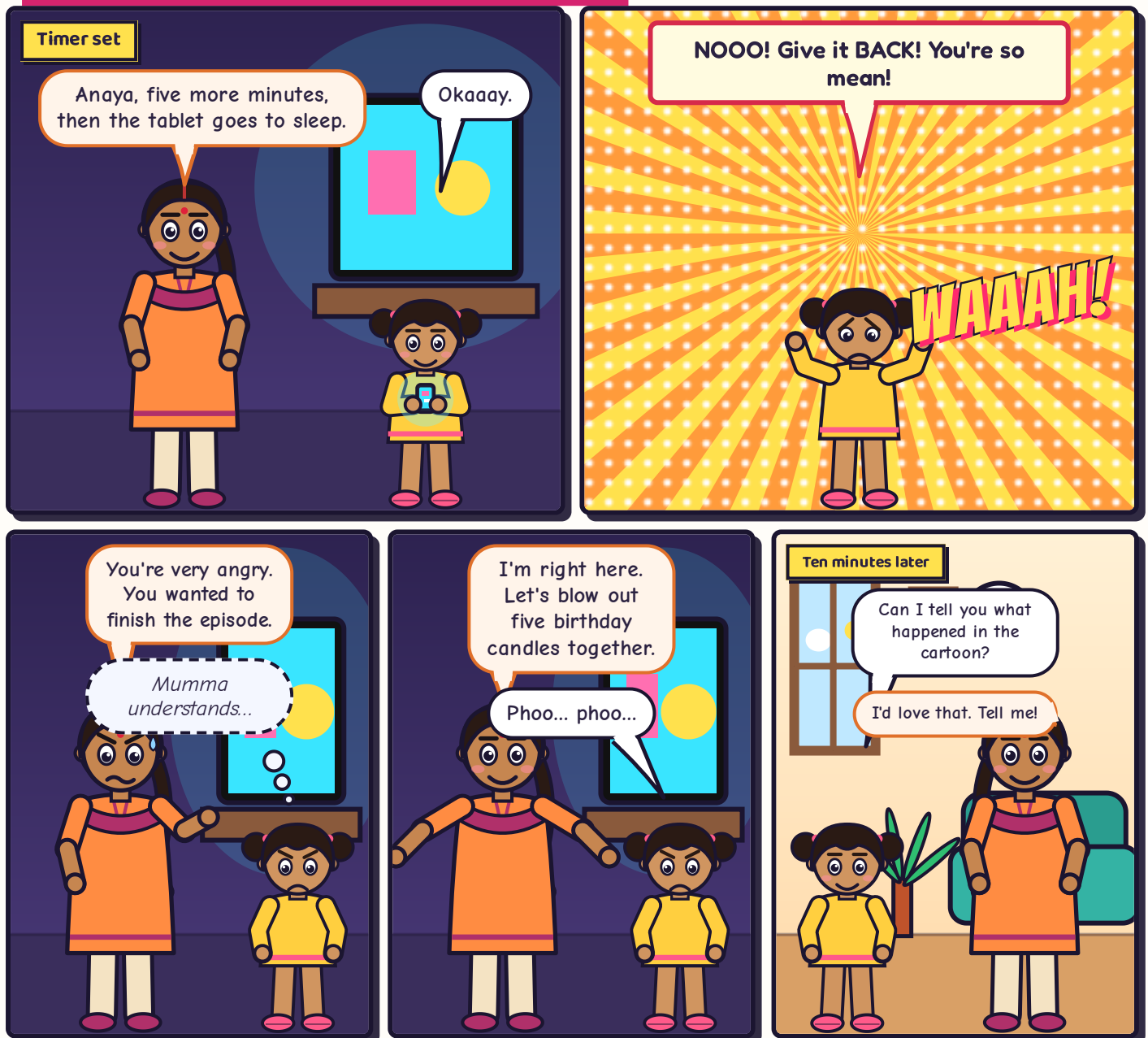
🎯 Stay calm, name the feeling, hold the limit.

🕒 Practise all day

👤 Parents first



Day 10 comic: When the Tablet Goes to Sleep



Sushma Ma'am says

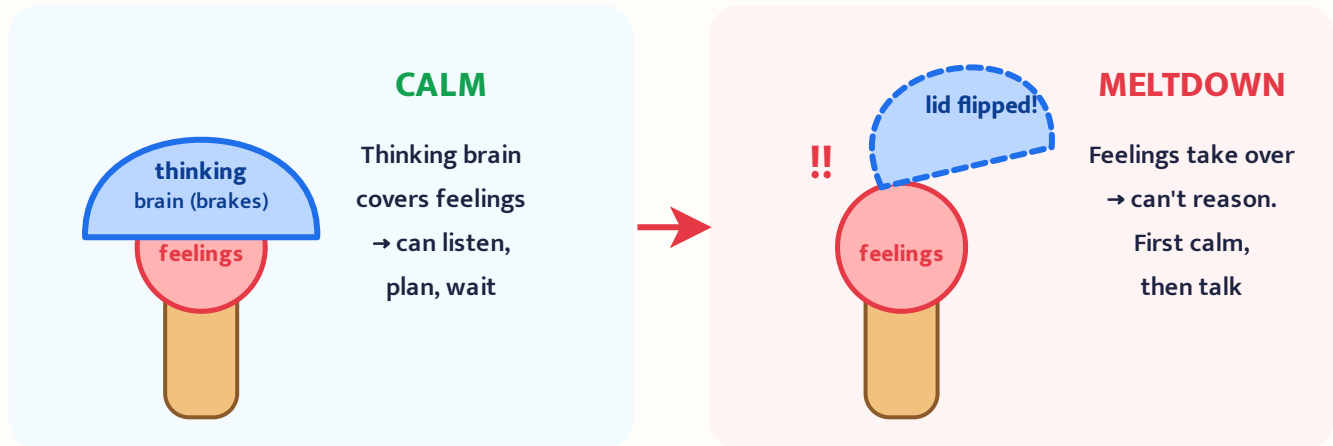


A meltdown when the screen stops does **not** mean your child is spoilt, or that you are a bad parent. It means a young brain is losing something it loved, all at once. Our job is not to stop every storm – it is to be the calm harbour the child can come back to. Today you learn how.



Why meltdowns happen when screens stop

Three things collide at that moment. (1) **Sudden loss of reward**: the brain was enjoying a steady flow of fun, and it is cut off mid-scene. (2) **Hard transition**: switching from something exciting to something ordinary (dinner, homework, bath) is difficult even for adults. (3) **Immature brakes**: the thinking part of the brain that says "it's okay, I can watch tomorrow" is still developing – it keeps maturing into the mid-20s.



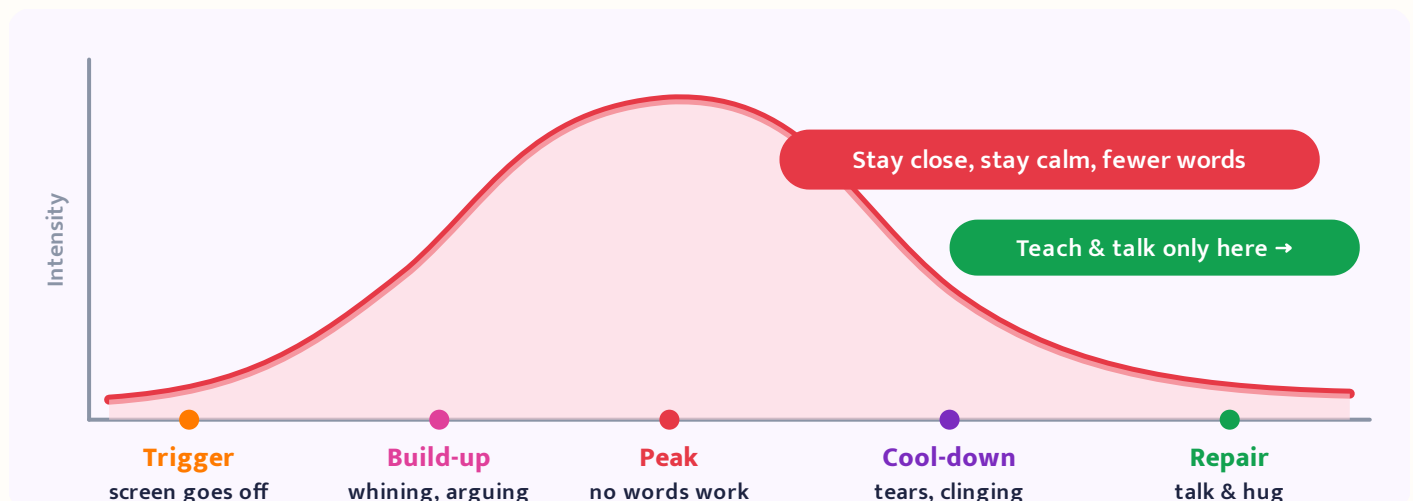
The "hand model of the brain" (Dr Dan Siegel): in a meltdown the thinking brain "flips its lid" – so reasoning must wait until the child is calm.

Child Psychology Insight

Co-regulation comes before self-regulation. Babies and young children cannot calm themselves yet – they "borrow" calm from a steady adult: your slow voice, soft face and relaxed body. Each time you stay calm through a storm, you are lending your child a nervous system. Over years, with hundreds of such moments, they learn to do it alone.



The shape of a meltdown



Every meltdown rises, peaks and falls. Talking, teaching and consequences belong to the cool-down and repair stage – not the peak.



Emotion coaching in 5 steps

Psychologist Dr John Gottman described "emotion coaching" – parents who treat a child's big feelings as a chance to connect and teach. Here is how it looks on a tough evening:

✓ Emotion coaching – step by step

- 1 **Notice early.** Whining, a red face, a tight jaw – catch the storm while it is small.
- 2 **See it as a chance to connect,** not a battle to win. Take one slow breath yourself first.
- 3 **Listen and accept the feeling.** Get down to their eye level. "You really wanted to keep playing."
- 4 **Name it to tame it.** "You're feeling angry and disappointed." Naming a feeling helps the thinking brain come back online.
- 5 **Hold the limit, then solve together.** "The tablet is done for today. Feelings are okay; hitting is not. What can we do next time the timer rings?"

💡 "Name it to tame it" (Dr Dan Siegel)

When a child can put a word to a feeling – *angry, sad, frustrated, jealous, disappointed* – the storm usually becomes smaller. Build a feelings vocabulary at calm times, with a feelings chart on the fridge: faces for happy, sad, angry, scared, worried, excited. Ask, "Which face are you right now?"



Calm-down tools

5-4-3-2-1 grounding (for ages 6+ and for parents too!) pulls attention out of the storm and into the room:

 5	 4	 3	 2	 1
things you SEE	things you can TOUCH	things you HEAR	things you SMELL	thing you TASTE



For little ones (2–6)

- **Birthday candles:** hold up 5 fingers, blow each one out slowly.
- **Smell the flower, blow the candle.**
- **Tight hug, count to 10** (only if the child wants touch).
- **A calm corner** with a cushion, soft toy and picture book.



For older kids & teens

- **Box breathing:** in 4, hold 4, out 4, hold 4.
- **Move it out:** a walk to the gate, 20 jumps, pushing a wall.
- **Space with a promise:** "Take 10 minutes. I'll come and check on you."
- **Write or draw** the feeling in a notebook.



Prevent the storm: transition warnings



Agree the end before you begin. Let the child press "off" themselves, and have something pleasant waiting.

- **Stop at natural endings** – end of an episode or a level, not mid-scene. Turn off autoplay.
- **Use a timer both of you can see** – a kitchen timer or sand timer, so the "bad guy" is the timer, not you.
- **Avoid screens when the child is already tired or hungry** – meltdowns are far more likely then.

Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Stop crying right now or no TV for a week!	✓ It's hard to stop when it's fun. I'm here. Cry if you need to.
✗ Big boys don't cry. Look at your sister.	✓ You're upset – that's okay. Let's breathe together.
✗ Fine, take the phone, just stop shouting!	✓ I won't change my answer, and I won't leave you. We'll get through this.
✗ Why are you behaving like this?	✓ Your body is telling me you're really angry. Show me how big the anger is.

What never to do during a meltdown

- **Never hit, slap or shake** a child – it teaches that big feelings are handled with violence, and breaks trust.
- **Don't give in** by handing back the device – the brain learns "a big enough scream brings the screen back".
- **Don't shame, mock or record** the tantrum or post it on family WhatsApp groups.
- **Don't lecture or threaten at the peak.** No one can learn with a flipped lid. Teach later.
- **Seek help** if meltdowns are very frequent, last a very long time, include self-harm or hurting others, or continue well past early childhood – talk to your paediatrician or a child psychologist. Tele-MANAS: **14416**.

Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Tantrums are normal at this age. Keep them safe, stay close, use few words. Distraction works well after the peak.

Age 10–13

Anger may look like slammed doors and "you're so unfair!". Give space with a promise to return; talk it through later.

Age 6–9

Teach feeling words and the calm corner. Practise "birthday candles" at calm times so it works in stormy ones.

Age 14–16

Don't argue in front of siblings or friends. Respect privacy: "Let's talk when we're both calm." Agree phone rules together in advance.

**If it happens again tomorrow...**

- **It will – and that's okay.** Change takes repetition. Most families notice meltdowns getting shorter within a week or two of calm, consistent limits.
- **If you lost your temper,** repair: "I shouted. I'm sorry. I'm learning too." Repair teaches more than being perfect.

**Activity: My Calm-Down Plan**

Fill this in **with your child at a calm time** – never during a storm. Stick it near the calm corner and practise it on good days, so it works on hard ones.

When I have big feelings...**My answer**

My body tells me I'm getting upset when... (hot face, tight fists, loud voice)

My signal for "I need a break" (a word or hand sign)

My calm spot at home

Three things that help me calm down

The grown-up I can go to

When I feel better, I can...

**Tonight's 2-minute reflection**

What were the early warning signs before my child's last meltdown?

What helps me stay calm when my child is not?

**Today's Win**

I stayed calm, named the feeling and held the limit – I was the harbour in the storm.

DAY

11

WEEK 2

Chores & Responsibility

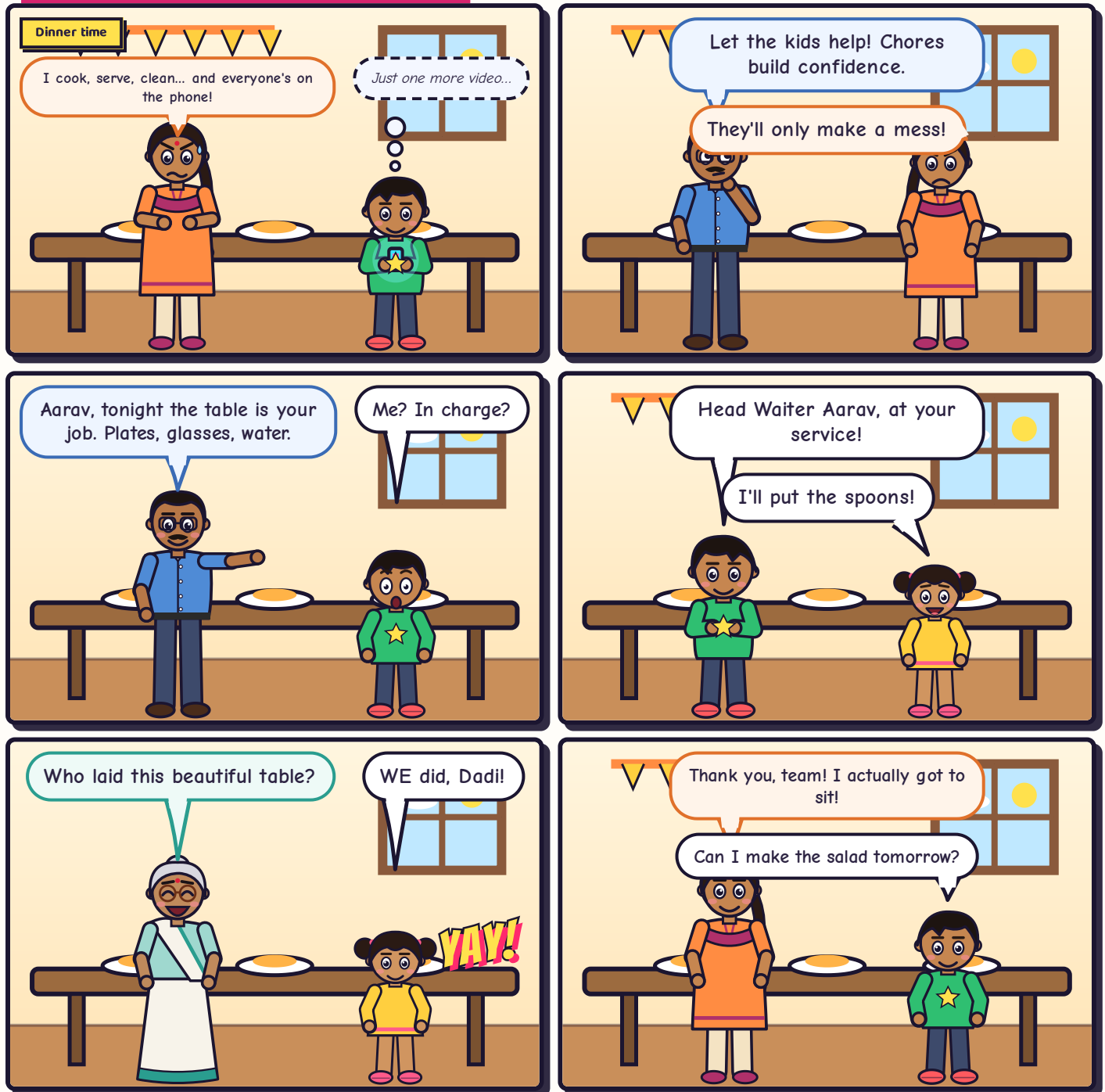
🎯 Give each child one real daily job.

🕒 20 min

👨‍👩‍👧‍👦 Whole family



🗨️ Day 11 comic: Head Waiter Aarav



**Sushma Ma'am says**

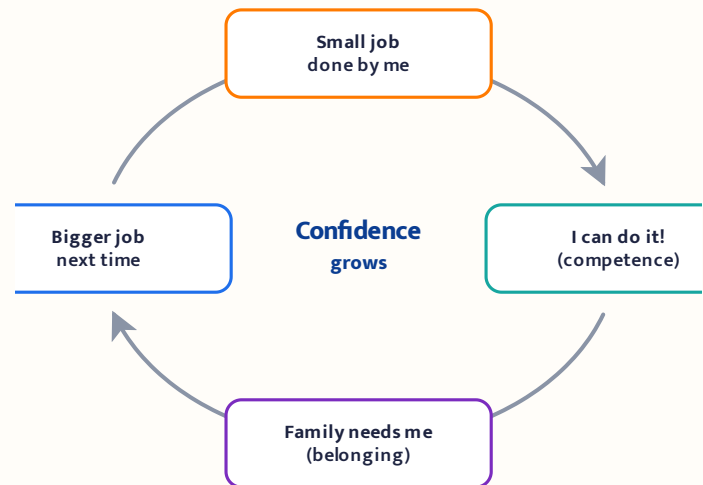
In many Indian homes, children are told, "You just study, we'll do everything else." It comes from love – but it can leave a child with lots of free time, a phone, and no sense that the family needs them. Today we give every child a small, real job. Not as punishment – as membership.

**Why chores beat screens**

A game gives a child a feeling of "I'm good at something" – points, levels, badges. That feeling is a real human need, called **competence**. Chores give the same feeling in the real world: "I made the salad. I fed the dog. The family ate at the table I laid." Children who help at home also practise planning, patience and finishing a task – the same skills they need for studies.

**Child Psychology Insight**

Self-Determination Theory (Deci & Ryan) says children thrive when three needs are met: **competence** (I can), **autonomy** (I choose) and **relatedness** (I belong). A well-chosen chore meets all three.



The confidence cycle of real responsibility.

**Age-appropriate chores**

Boys and girls get the same chores. Start small, show them how, do it together a few times, then let them do it alone. Adjust to your child's abilities – these are ideas, not rules.

Age	Chores they can do
2–3	Put toys in a basket · put dirty clothes in the laundry bucket · water a plant with a small mug · bring their own slippers
4–5	Place spoons and napkins · match socks · wipe small spills · feed a pet · sort vegetables (potatoes here, onions there)
6–9	Make their bed · pack the school bag · fold clothes · lay the table · fill water bottles · shell peas · water all plants
10–13	Sweep a room · wash dishes · take out garbage · simple cooking with an adult (salad, sandwich, Maggi) · buy small items from the kirana
14–16	Cook a simple meal (dal-chawal, poha) · manage own laundry · iron clothes · help a sibling with homework · plan a family outing budget

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Hold a 5-minute family meeting:** "Our home runs because everyone helps. Which job would you like?" Let them choose from 2–3 options.
- 2 **Teach, don't just tell** – "I do, we do, you do": show it, do it together, then let them try.
- 3 **Accept imperfect work.** A crooked bedsheet made by a 7-year-old is perfect. Don't redo it in front of them.
- 4 **Link chores to the daily rhythm** – "after school bag, then snack", "after dinner, clear your plate".
- 5 **Thank them like a team member:** "Thanks for filling the bottles – it saved me time."



Activity: Our Family Chore Chart – cut out and stick on the fridge

Write each person's daily job (parents too!). Tick ✓ or put a sticker each day it is done. Change jobs every Sunday so no one gets bored.

Name	My job	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun



Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Leave it, you'll spoil it. I'll do it myself.	✓ Let me show you once, then it's your job.
✗ If you don't clean your room, no phone!	✓ When your room is tidy, then we can go to the park.
✗ Good boy.	✓ You remembered the bottles without being told – that's being responsible.
✗ Why should I pay you for helping at home?	✓ Everyday jobs are what family members do. Extra big jobs can earn a special treat.



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

They *want* to help – say yes, even when it's slower. Make it a game: "Can you find all the red toys?"

Age 10–13

Give real responsibility with a title: "Plant Manager", "Head Waiter". Let them decide *how* to do it.

Age 6–9

Picture chore charts and stickers work well. One daily job + one weekend "big" job.

Age 14–16

Life skills they'll need in a hostel or job: cooking, laundry, budgeting. Treat them like a capable young adult.



If your child says...

- **"Why me? Ananya doesn't do anything!"** – Show that everyone has a job matched to their age. Fair doesn't mean the same.
- **"I forgot."** – Use a visual reminder instead of nagging. Let small natural consequences happen (no water bottle in the fridge = warm water).
- **"Our maid/didi does that."** – Helpers are a blessing, but children still learn to care for their own things and space.



Table Setter

Age 5+ Name _____



Plant Manager

Age 3+ Name _____



Bottle Captain

Age 6+ Name _____



Shoe Keeper

Age 4+ Name _____



Bag Packer

Age 6+ Name _____



Laundry Helper

Age 5+ Name _____



Salad Chef

Age 8+ Name _____



Recycling Hero

Age 7+ Name _____

Cut out the job cards, let each child pick one, and pin it on the fridge. Swap cards every Sunday.



Tonight's 2-minute reflection

Which job did my child do today, and how did they look afterwards?

What am I doing for my child that they could do themselves?



Today's Win

My child did one real job for the family today – and felt needed.

DAY
12

WEEK 2

Creative Hobbies

🎯 Try one new hands-on activity together.

🕒 45 min

👨👩 Parent + child



Day 12 comic: Riya Finds Her Colours

Saturday afternoon

Scroll... scroll... everyone is doing something cool except me.

Remember your sketches from Class 5? They were so good.

That was ages ago, Mumma.

I bought colours. Draw with me? I'm terrible, so be kind!

Okay... just for ten minutes.

Mumma, is that a cat or a potato?

It's abstract art!

Evening

Two hours flew by. I didn't even check my phone!

Sushma Ma'am says



Children often reach for a screen not because it is so wonderful, but because their hands are empty and nothing else is ready. A hobby is a "yes" waiting in the corner. It doesn't need to be expensive or impressive. It only needs to belong to your child.



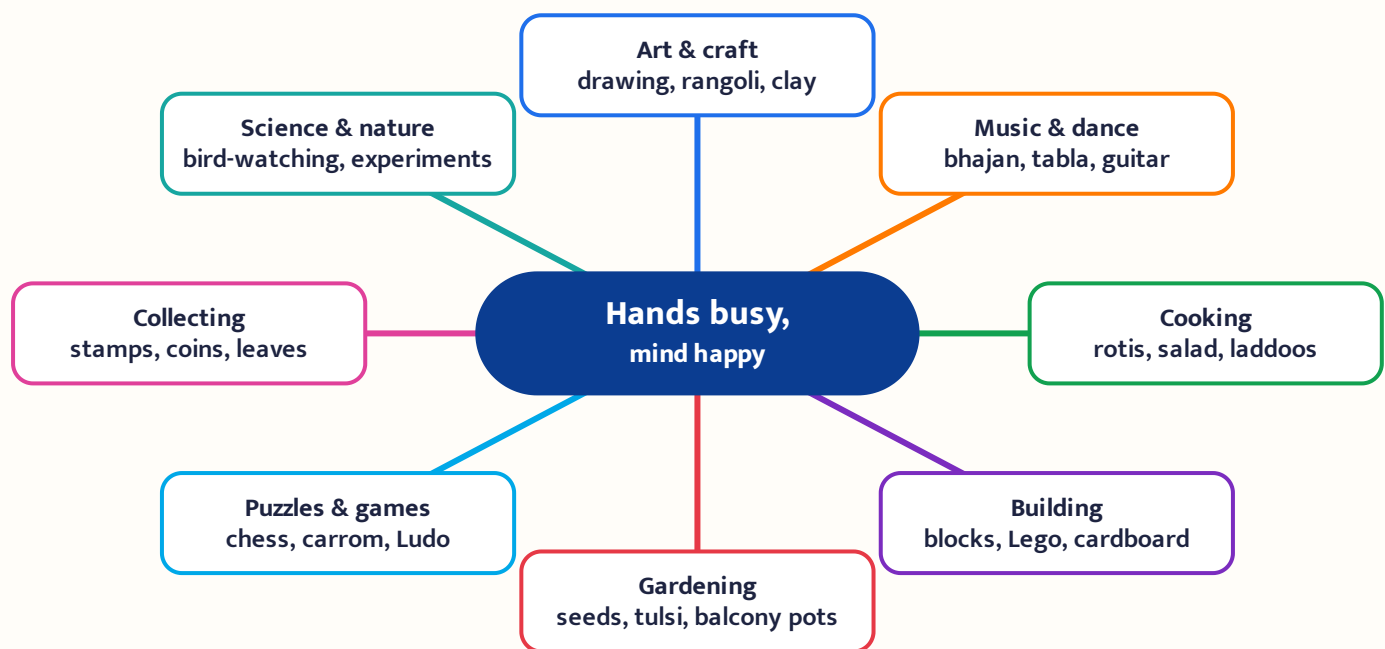
Why this works

When a child is deeply absorbed in drawing, building or cooking, time "flies". Psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi called this state **flow** – when a task is just challenging enough for your skill. Screens can create a similar absorption, but hobbies add something screens rarely do: a finished thing you made with your own hands, and skills that keep growing for years.



Child Psychology Insight

Intrinsic motivation – doing something because it is enjoyable in itself – is fragile. Too much pressure ("Join the competition! Get a certificate!") can turn play into work. In the first weeks, protect the fun: no marks, no comparing with cousins, no "is this useful for your career?"



A world of hobbies – many need almost no money.



Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Set up a "yes box"** – paper, crayons, clay, old boxes, tape, glue, a pack of cards – kept where the child can reach it without asking.
- 2 **Try one new thing together today** – draw, bake, plant seeds, learn a song on YouTube *together*, then put the phone away and practise.
- 3 **Cook with your child** – washing, stirring, rolling rotis, decorating. Kitchen time teaches maths, patience and safety.
- 4 **Allow mess and "failure"** – spread newspaper, keep old clothes. The burnt cookie is part of learning.
- 5 **Display their work** – a fridge gallery, a WhatsApp photo to Nani, a plant they can show guests.

**Cooking with kids – safely**

- **2–5:** wash veggies, tear coriander, mix, knead dough.
- **6–9:** measure, peel, roll rotis, make a sandwich.
- **10–13:** cut with a child-safe knife, boil and stir with supervision.
- **14+:** cook a full simple dish; adult nearby for gas and pressure cooker.

**Gardening in a flat**

- Methi, dhania, mustard grow in a week in any pot.
- Plant a lemon or tomato seed from the kitchen.
- Give the child a "plant diary" – measure and draw it every 3 days.
- Watering becomes a daily screen-free ritual.

**Age-wise Guide****Age 2–5**

Process, not product: finger painting, play-dough, sand, banging pots, singing. Offer 2 choices, not 20.

Age 6–9

Try many things briefly – they are exploring. Crafts, simple origami, a small garden, carrom, a musical instrument.

Age 10–13

Deeper skills: chess club, cooking a full dish, building models, learning an instrument properly. Let them lead.

Age 14–16

Hobbies linked to identity: photography, writing, fitness, music with friends, volunteering. Respect their taste even if it isn't yours.

**Hobby Discovery Worksheet**

Try one thing every day or two for the next two weeks. After each try, fill in the row **with your child**. The hobbies with the most 😊 and "Yes" are your winners.

Hobby we tried	Date	How long did it hold attention?	Enjoyed? 😊 😞	Try again? Yes / No

My child seemed happiest and most absorbed when...

.....

.....

 Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ What's the use of drawing? Focus on maths.	✓ I love how you used colour in the sky. Tell me about it.
✗ You quit guitar too, just like everything else.	✓ Guitar wasn't your thing – that's how we discover what is.
✗ Look how neat your cousin's painting is.	✓ This one looks like you made it – it has your style.

 Common traps

- **Choosing the hobby for the child** because it looks good on a CV. Offer, don't impose.
- **Too many classes.** A child with no free time at all still needs unstructured play – and rest.
- **Hobby that becomes a screen hobby** – "I'll just watch 50 drawing videos." One short tutorial, then hands on paper.

Our "yes box" starter kit – tick what you have

- ☐ Paper, crayons, sketch pens
- ☐ Old boxes, bottles, tape, glue
- ☐ Clay or atta dough
- ☐ A deck of cards, Ludo or carrom
- ☐ Seeds and a small pot
- ☐ Wool, beads, thread
- ☐ A notebook for stories and doodles
- ☐ Old magazines to cut and paste

 15-minute ideas for busy evenings

- Paper-boat race in a bucket of water
- Shadow puppets with a torch on the wall
- Draw the family as animals
- Make a card for Dadi or a friend
- A 10-line story, one line each

**Tonight's 2-minute reflection**

When did I last see my child completely absorbed in something without a screen?

What hobby of my own could I share with my child?

**Today's Win**

We made something with our own hands today – and it went up on the fridge.

DAY
13

WEEK 2

Good Screen Time

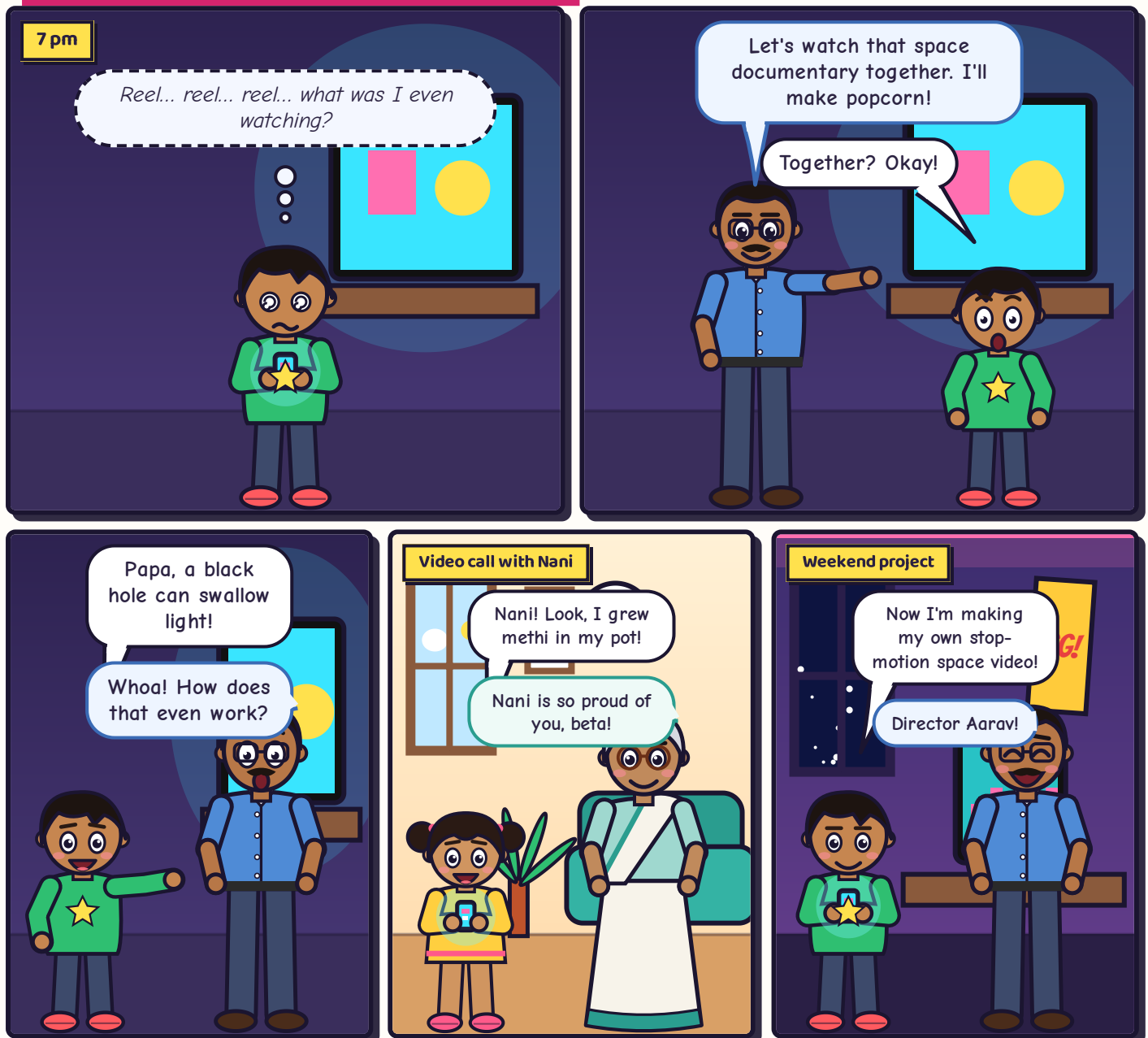
🎯 Watch one show together and build a family Green list.

🕒 40 min

📺 Watch together



Day 13 comic: From Scrolling to Creating



Sushma Ma'am says



Not all screen time is equal. Thirty minutes of mindless reels and thirty minutes of watching a nature documentary with Papa, asking questions, are completely different experiences. This plan is not anti-technology. Today we learn to make screens a **tool** in the family, not a babysitter.



Why this works

Researcher Lisa Guernsey suggests asking about the **3 Cs**: the **Content** (what is it?), the **Context** (how, when and with whom is it watched?) and the **Child** (what does *this* child need?). The same cartoon can be calming for one child and over-exciting for another. And almost any content becomes more valuable when a loving adult watches with the child and talks about it.



What Research Says

- The **AAP** recommends **co-viewing** – watching with your child and talking about what you see – especially for young children.
- The **IAP** and **AAP** both make an exception for **video calls with family**, even for babies under 2.
- **IAP**: for ages 2–5, at most 1 hour a day of supervised, quality content.

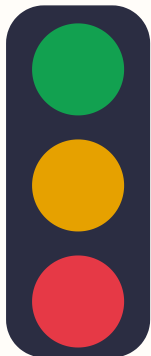


Child Psychology Insight

Scaffolding (Lev Vygotsky): a child learns most when an adult helps them stretch just beyond what they can do alone. Your questions during a show – "Why do you think she did that?" – turn passive watching into active thinking.



The content traffic light



GREEN – go ahead

Video call with Nani · slow, age-right show · making/creating · learning together

AMBER – limit & watch together

Fast cartoons · online games with friends · YouTube with autoplay OFF

RED – not for now

Endless reels/shorts · violent or adult content · games with loot boxes · chatting with strangers

A simple family guide. Decide together which shows and apps sit in which colour.

How to choose good content – a 6-point check

Before you press play

- ☐ **Age-right** – check the age rating, and watch 10 minutes yourself first.
- ☐ **Slow and calm** rather than fast cuts, loud noises and constant flashing.
- ☐ **Has an ending** – episodes or films, not endless feeds. Autoplay OFF.
- ☐ **No ads, in-app purchases or loot boxes** aimed at children.
- ☐ **Shows kindness and good values** – characters solve problems, not just fight.
- ☐ **Leads to real life** – after the show, the child wants to draw, build, ask or go outside.

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Co-view one show today.** Sit together – no second phone for you. Laugh, react, pause to ask.
- 2 **Ask 3 talk-back questions:** "What would you have done?" "Is that real or pretend?" "How did he feel?"
- 3 **Build a family "Green list"** of 5–10 shows, channels and apps you are all happy with.
- 4 **Schedule a video call with grandparents** – let the child show a drawing, sing a song or give a "house tour".
- 5 **Try one "create" project** – a photo story, a recipe video, a stop-motion clip, a digital drawing, simple coding (e.g. Scratch).



Create, don't just consume

Instead of just...	Try creating...	Skill it builds
Watching cooking reels	Film Dadi's recipe step by step, with your narration	Planning, speaking, family history
Playing the same game	Design your own simple game in Scratch, or on paper	Logic, creativity
Scrolling photos	A photo walk: 10 pictures of "things that are yellow"	Observation, art
Watching music videos	Learn one song and record it for Nani	Practice, confidence



Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Go watch your cartoon, I'm busy.	✓ Let's watch one episode together, then you tell me your favourite part.
✗ All your videos are rubbish.	✓ Show me a creator you like. What do you enjoy about them?
✗ Stop wasting time on the phone.	✓ You know so much about space now – could you make a short video explaining it to Anaya?



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Under 2: only video calls with family. 2–5: max 1 hour, always with you, slow shows. Talk about it: "Where did the bunny go?"

Age 10–13

Watch *their* favourite YouTuber or game with them. Discuss ads, clickbait, "is this real?" Coding and video editing are great.

Age 6–9

Co-view often. Choose from your Green list. Introduce simple creating: drawing apps, photo stories.

Age 14–16

Be curious, not controlling. Ask them to teach you something online. Talk about influencers, body image and how algorithms choose what they see.

 If your child says...

- **"Watching with you is boring."** – Let them choose what you watch together sometimes. Your interest in their world is the point.
- **"But it's educational!"** – Great – then it can be on the Green list. Educational content still counts in daily screen time.
- **"Everyone in my class watches it."** – Watch one episode together, then decide: "What did you think? Is it okay for your age?"

 Activity: Our Family Green List

Sit together and list 5–10 shows, channels and apps everyone agrees on. Mark each Green or Amber, stick the list near the TV, and review it once a month.

Show / channel / app	For whom	Green / Amber	Why we like it

 Talk-back questions: little ones (2–8)

- "What do you think will happen next?"
- "How is she feeling? How do you know?"
- "Is that real or pretend?"
- "Can we try that at home?"

 Talk-back questions: older kids & teens

- "Why do you think they made this video?"
- "Is this an ad, even if it doesn't say so?"
- "What would you change about the ending?"
- "How did you feel after watching it?"

 Tonight's 2-minute reflection

What did I learn about my child while watching together?

Which app or show should move from Amber to Red in our home?

 Today's Win

We watched **together**, talked about it, and made a screen a tool for connection.

DAY
14

WEEK 2

Week 2 Review

🎯 Review, adjust, and praise the effort.

🕒 30 min

👨👩👧👦 Family meeting



Day 14 comic: The Sunday Family Meeting



Sushma Ma'am says



Two weeks! Pause and look back. Some days went beautifully, some fell apart – both are normal. Today is not about grading yourself. It is about noticing what worked, fixing what didn't, and celebrating how far your family has come.



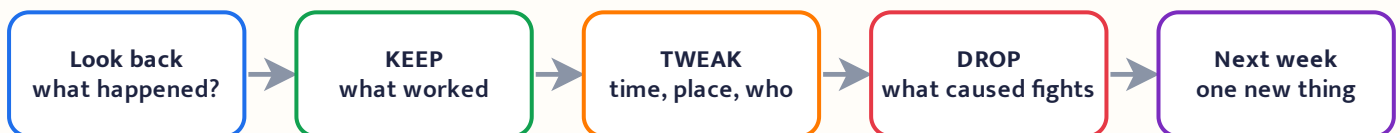
Week 2 at a glance – fill in together

Day	Idea	Tried it? ✓	How it went (1–5 ★)	Keep / Tweak / Drop
8	Green hour outdoors			
9	Bedtime stories & reading			
10	Calm meltdown handling			
11	Chore chart			
12	A creative hobby			
13	Co-viewing & Green list			



Adjusting the plan

A plan that doesn't fit your family will not last. Use the **Keep – Tweak – Drop** filter below. Changing the plan is not failure; it is how every good plan grows.



- **Green hour clashing with tuition?** Move it to the morning, or split into two 20-minute slots.
- **Story time turning into a fight?** Let the child choose the book and who reads.
- **Chores forgotten?** Attach them to something that already happens daily (after brushing, after school).
- **Parents slipping on their own phones?** Say it out loud: "I broke our rule – I'm putting mine away." Children respect honesty.



Praise that works: effort, not labels

Psychologist Carol Dweck's research on **mindsets** found that praising children for being "smart" or "talented" can make them avoid challenges, while praising **effort, strategies and progress** helps them keep trying when things get hard. The same applies to screen habits: we want children who believe "I can get better at stopping", not "I'm just addicted".

Label praise ✗	Effort / descriptive praise ✓
"Good boy!"	"You switched off when the timer rang, even though the game was exciting. That took real self-control."
"You're so smart."	"You tried three ways to solve that puzzle – and the last one worked!"
"Wow, beautiful drawing!"	"You took your time with the colours in the sky. Tell me about it."
"You're a born cricketer."	"All that practice on the terrace is showing in your batting."

**Rewards that help (and ones that backfire)**

- **Helpful:** experiences and time together – choosing Sunday's dinner, a park trip, a game night with Papa.
- **Helpful for young kids:** a sticker chart for a *new* habit, faded out once the habit sticks.
- **Backfires:** using extra screen time as the main reward – it makes screens seem even more precious.
- **Backfires:** paying for every small task – the child starts asking "What will I get?"

**Siblings are different – and that's okay**

A 6-year-old and a 14-year-old need different rules, chores and screen limits. Explain: "**Fair means everyone gets what they need**, not everyone gets the same." Never compare ("Why can't you be like your sister?"). Notice each child's own progress, and give each one some one-on-one time this week.

✓ Today's review ritual

- 1 **Hold a 20-minute Sunday family meeting.** Snacks, no phones, everyone speaks – starting with the youngest.
- 2 **Share one "rose" and one "thorn"** each: the best moment and the hardest moment of the week.
- 3 **Fill the review table above together** and choose Keep / Tweak / Drop.
- 4 **Give each child one specific effort-praise** in front of the family.
- 5 **Celebrate** with the reward you wrote on the tracker page – an experience, not a gadget.

**Say This, Not That**

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ This plan isn't working. You kids never listen.	✓ Some things worked, some didn't. Let's figure out what to change together.
✗ Look, your sister got more stars than you.	✓ You've had three calm evenings this week – that's your best yet.
✗ If you're good all week, you get extra game time.	✓ If we stick to our plan, let's go for a family picnic on Sunday.

**Age-wise Guide****Age 2–5**

Keep it simple: one sticker for each good day, a high-five and a hug. Praise out loud to Dadi: "Guess who helped today?"

Age 10–13

Ask for their honest feedback on the rules: "What felt unfair?" They will follow rules they helped design.

Age 6–9

Let them colour the tracker and choose the family reward. They love being "in charge" of the meeting agenda.

Age 14–16

Private praise often works better than public. A note on their desk or a message saying you noticed their effort.

**If week 2 felt like a failure...**

- **Nothing seemed to change?** Look for small signs: shorter meltdowns, one more hour of sleep, one family meal without phones. Small wins add up.
- **Only one parent is following the plan?** Talk privately, not in front of the children. Agree on 2–3 non-negotiables and let the rest be flexible.
- **Things are getting worse** – aggression, not eating or sleeping, refusing school? Revisit the red flags in Part 1 and speak to a professional.

**Tonight's 2-minute reflection**

What am I most proud of from these two weeks – as a parent?

Which one change will we make for Week 3?

What effort did I notice in each child this week?

**Coming up in Week 3: Strengthen & Sustain**

A written **family media plan**, staying **safe online**, building your child's own **self-control**, and a plan that lasts beyond Day 21. Bring your filled review table – we will build on it.

**Today's Win**

Two weeks done! We replaced screen time with play, stories, chores, hobbies and each other – and we are rebuilding, one day at a time.

WEEK 3 · DAYS 15–21

Strengthen & Sustain

A family media plan, safety online, self-control and a plan that lasts.



DAY
15

WEEK 3

Our Family Media Plan

🎯 Write and sign one agreement – for everyone.

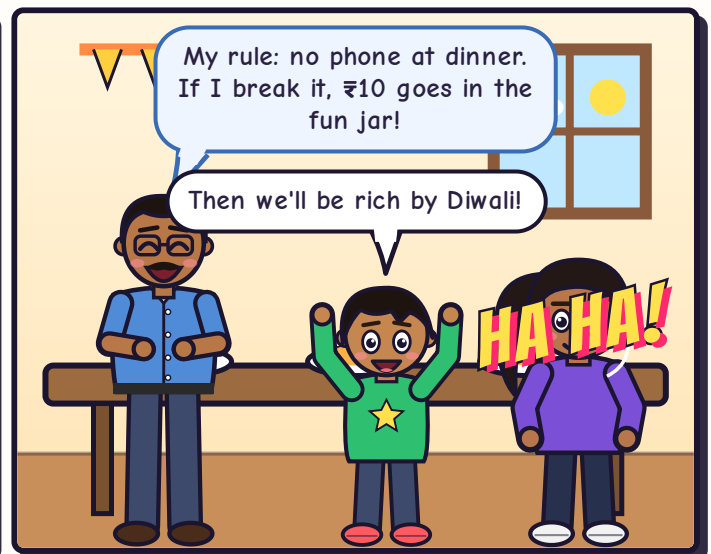
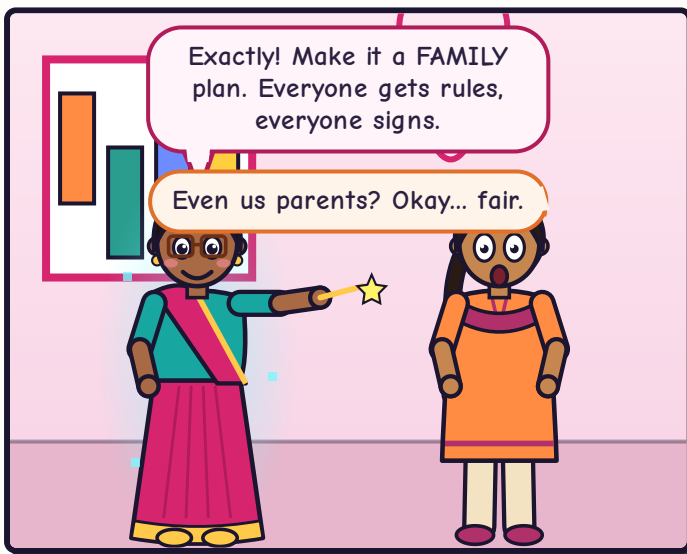
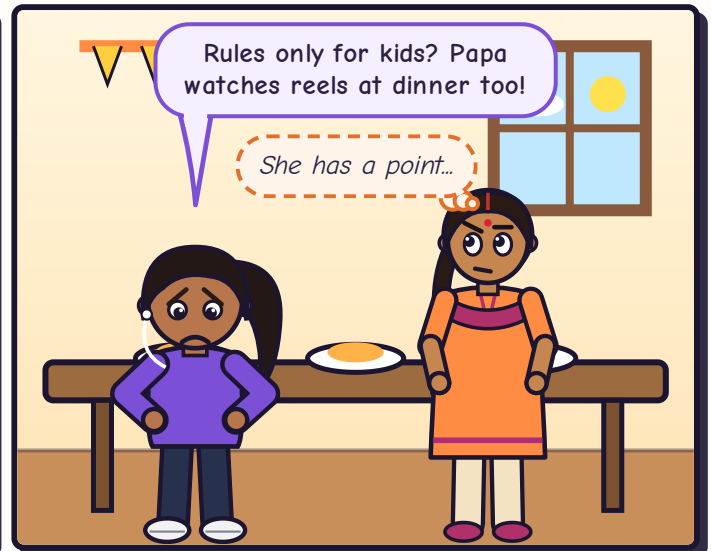
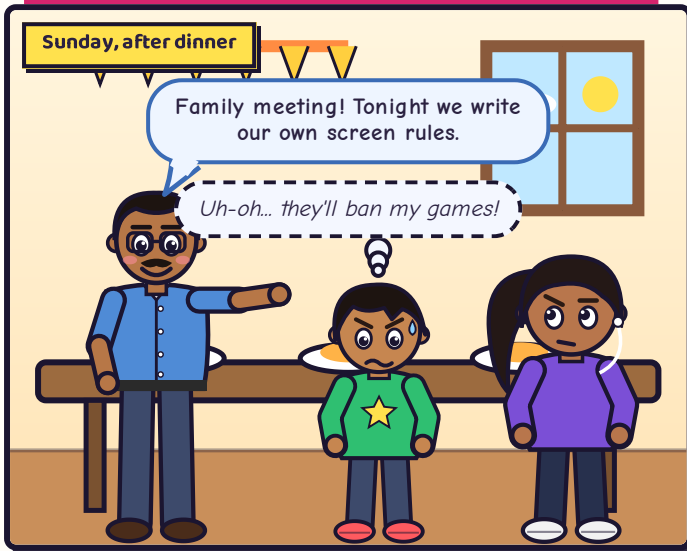
🕒 45 min

👤 Whole family

🖨️ Printable



Day 15 comic: The Family Agreement



Sushma Ma'am says

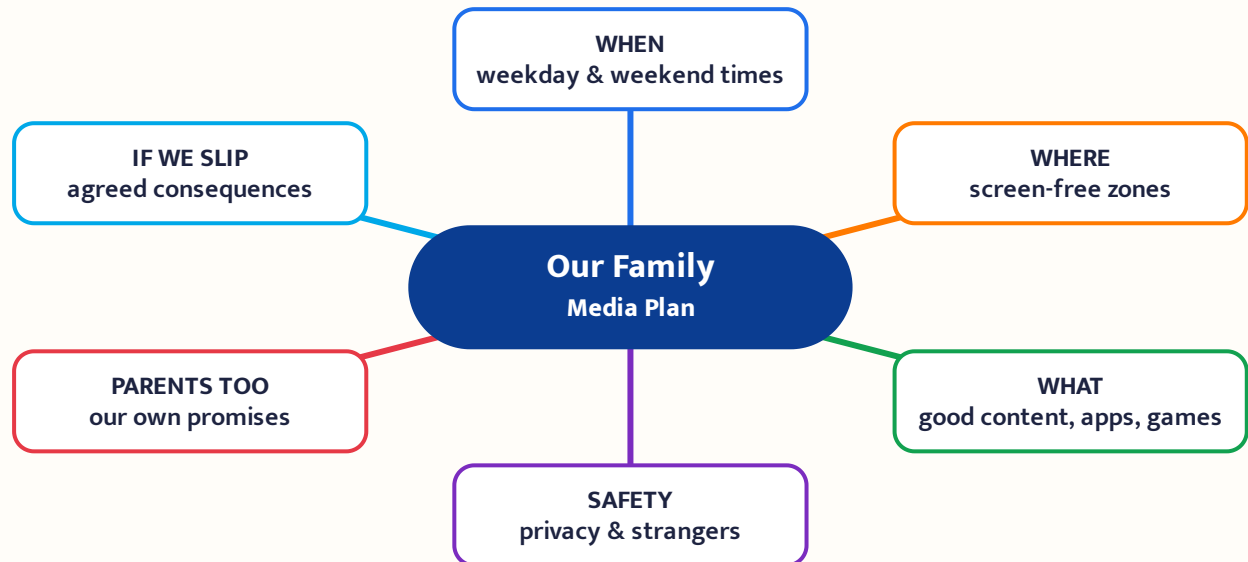


Over two weeks you have tried many small changes. Today we **write them down** – as a family, in one agreement that everyone helps to make and everyone signs, parents included. A rule children help to write is a rule they are far more likely to keep. Keep it simple, keep it on the fridge, and review it every month.



Why a written family plan works

The American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP) recommends that every family create a **Family Media Plan** (you can find their free online tool at healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan). A written plan turns daily fights ("five more minutes!") into a calm reference: "What does our plan say?" The rule becomes the 'bad guy', not you. It also makes rules **predictable** – and children cope far better with limits they know in advance than with sudden ones.



The six parts of a good family media plan – cover all six in your agreement.



Child Psychology Insight

- **Ownership:** when children help set a rule, they experience it as *their* decision. Psychologists call this autonomy – one of the basic needs behind a child's motivation (Self-Determination Theory).
- **Consequences decided in advance** feel fair; consequences shouted in anger feel like punishment and invite revenge or secrecy.
- **Modelling:** children copy what they see. A plan that includes parents' promises teaches fairness and makes the rules believable.



Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Call a 30-minute family meeting** at a relaxed time (not right after a fight). Snacks help!
- 2 **Start with the 'why':** "We want time for sleep, study, play and each other." Ask each child what they love about screens – and what they don't like.
- 3 **Fill the agreement on the next pages together.** Let children write some parts in their own handwriting.
- 4 **Agree on consequences calmly** – small, related and short (less screen time tomorrow, not 'no phone for a month').
- 5 **Everyone signs**, including Dadi if she lives with you. Put it on the fridge and set a monthly review date in your calendar.

PRINT · FILL TOGETHER · SIGN · PUT ON THE FRIDGE



Our Family Media Agreement

Family name: _____ Start date: _____ Review on: _____

On WEEKDAYS (school days)	Our rule
Recreational screen time (after homework)	___ minutes, between ___ and ___
Screens OFF from ... (1 hour before bed)	___ pm
Phones sleep at the charging station	Place: _____
Before any screen, first finish...	☐ homework ☐ play outside ☐ _____

On WEEKENDS & holidays	Our rule
Recreational screen time	___ minutes, in ___ blocks
Family movie / game time (together)	Day: _____ Time: _____
One screen-free outing or activity	Idea: _____

Our screen-free zones

- ☐ Dining table
 ☐ Bedrooms at night
 ☐ In the car (short trips)
- ☐ Family time after ___ pm
 ☐ Pooja / prayer time
 ☐ Other: _____

If this happens...	...then we agreed (decided calmly, in advance)
Time is up but the screen stays on	e.g. 15 minutes less tomorrow
Phone found in the bedroom at night	
Secret apps / games / chats	
Rude words when asked to stop	
A PARENT breaks a rule 😊	e.g. puts ₹10 in the family fun jar

Parents promise to...

- ✓ keep phones away at meals and while you talk to us
- ✓ give a 10-minute warning before screen time ends
- ✓ listen first when you tell us about a problem online
- ✓ play / go out with you: _____

Children promise to...

- ✓ stop when the timer rings (with the 10-min warning)
- ✓ ask before downloading any app or game
- ✓ tell a parent if anything online feels wrong
- ✓ my own promise: _____

This is a living agreement. We will review it together every month and change what is not working.

Papa

Mummy

Child 1

Child 2

Dadi / Nani



Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ These are the rules. Full stop.	✓ Let's make the rules together. What feels fair to you?
✗ If you break this, I'll take your phone forever!	✓ What should happen if someone forgets the rule? Let's decide now, while we're calm.
✗ I'm the parent, I can use my phone whenever I want.	✓ I'll follow the plan too. Remind me if you catch me at the dinner table!
✗ You never follow anything we decide.	✓ Let's check the plan together – which part is hard for you?



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Use **pictures** instead of words: a sun (screen OK), a moon (screens sleep), a plate (no screen). Let them put their thumbprint as a 'signature'.

Age 6–9

Keep **3–5 simple rules**. Let them decorate the agreement with stickers and colours – they will remember it better.

Age 10–13

Let them **propose** the timings and one consequence. Add a 'bonus time' rule they can earn (e.g. extra 15 min on Saturday for a calm week).

Age 14–16

Treat it as a **negotiation between near-adults**. Focus on sleep, safety and studies; give them more say on the rest. Plan to relax rules as they show responsibility.



If the meeting goes wrong...

- **Child refuses to join:** start anyway, keep a seat for them and say "We'd like your ideas – otherwise we'll decide without them." Most children come in.
- **Child asks for 5 hours a day:** don't laugh or lecture. Say "That's your starting number – mine is 1 hour. Let's find something that also leaves time for sleep and play."
- **Parents disagree in front of kids:** pause the meeting, agree privately, then return with one voice.



Tonight's 2-minute reflection

Which rule did your child suggest that surprised you?

Which of your own promises will be hardest for you to keep?



Today's Win

Our family agreement is written, signed and on the fridge. 📄

DAY
16

WEEK 3

Games, Social Media & Teens

🎯 Listen, negotiate, agree on fair limits.

🕒 40 min

👤 Ages 10–16



Day 16 comic: Riya's Likes



Sushma Ma'am says



Tweens and teens don't need a *warden*; they need a *coach*. At this age, friends and belonging matter enormously, and much of that now happens online. If we only ban, they learn to hide. If we listen, negotiate and keep a few non-negotiables (sleep, safety, studies), they learn to manage themselves – which is the real goal.



Why this works: the teen brain wants a say

In early adolescence the brain's reward and social systems become very sensitive – what friends think, likes and comments feel *huge*. The prefrontal cortex (planning, self-control) keeps maturing into the mid-20s. So teens feel strongly but are still learning to put on the brakes. Harsh control at this stage often backfires into rebellion or secrecy; warm limits plus a real voice in decisions builds responsibility.



The 5-step negotiation – use it for any new app, game or phone request.



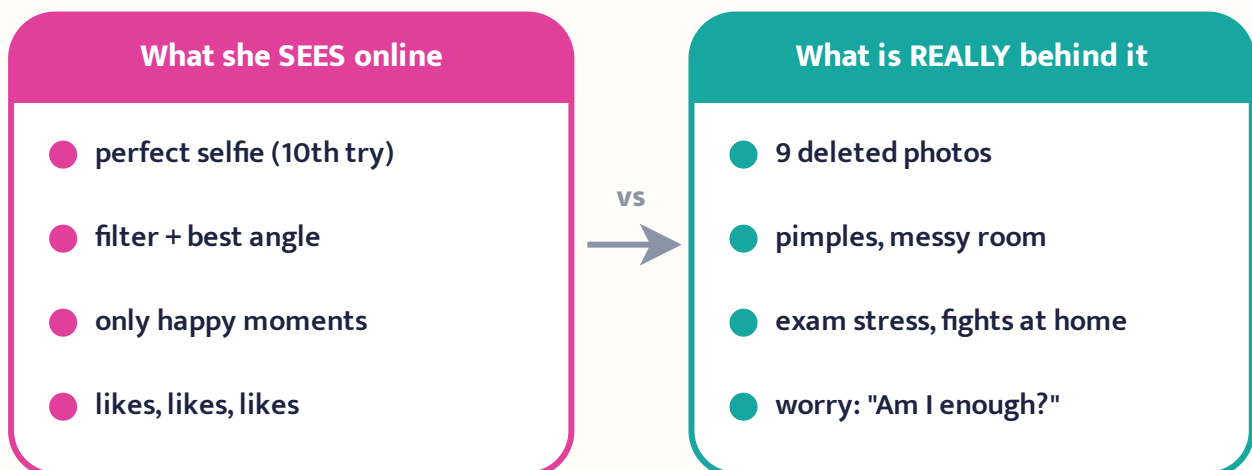
Age limits – what the platforms themselves say

- Most popular social media apps (such as Instagram, Snapchat, Facebook and TikTok where available) require users to be **at least 13 years old** in their own terms of service. WhatsApp's minimum age is also 13 in India. YouTube requires 13+ for a personal account; younger children should use YouTube Kids or a supervised experience.
- India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 treats everyone under 18 as a child and requires verifiable parental consent before platforms process a child's personal data.
- 13 is a **minimum**, not a recommendation. Many families wisely wait longer, and start with a private account, few followers they know in real life, and parents as 'friends'.



Comparison & self-esteem: the highlight reel

Social media shows everyone's *best moments*, edited and filtered. A teen compares her ordinary Tuesday with 200 people's best days – and feels she is not enough. Don't dismiss the feeling ("such a silly thing!"). Name it, and help her see the gap between the reel and the real.



Draw this with your teen – what do people post, and what do they leave out?

**Child Psychology Insight**

- **Autonomy supports motivation.** Teens who feel controlled push back; teens who feel heard are more willing to follow limits they helped set.
- **Self-worth needs real-world anchors** – skills, friendships, helping at home, sport, art. The more of these a child has, the less power likes have.
- **Games are designed to keep playing** (levels, daily rewards, loot boxes). A *time box* agreed in advance protects your child from a design meant to be endless.

Gaming time boxes (for Aarav and friends)

🕒 Start: 5:00 pm

Screen off: 5:45 ✓



A time box has a clear start, a warning and a "landing" – not a sudden switch-off.

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Ask before you advise:** "Show me your favourite game / account. What do you like about it?" Sit with them for 10 minutes with genuine curiosity.
- 2 **Name your 3 non-negotiables:** sleep (no phone in bedroom at night), safety (private account, no strangers), studies first.
- 3 **Negotiate everything else** using the 5 steps. Write the result into your family agreement from Day 15.
- 4 **Set up a gaming time box** with a 10-minute warning and a 'save point' – let them choose *which* 45 minutes.
- 5 **Talk about comparison** once this week – share a time *you* felt 'not enough' after scrolling.

**Say This, Not That**

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Social media is rubbish. You're not getting it.	✓ I know your friends are there. Let's figure out a safe way – and when you'll be ready.
✗ Why do you care about likes? So silly!	✓ It hurts when a post doesn't get noticed. I've felt that too.
✗ Stop that game NOW!	✓ 10 minutes left in your time box – finish the match and save.
✗ Because I said so.	✓ My worry is your sleep. What would you suggest?

 Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

No social media or online multiplayer games. Choose slow, simple apps and **co-view**. Build confidence through real play and praise for effort.

Age 6–9

Offline or family-friendly games only, played in a **common room**. Start teaching time boxes with a visual timer. Talk about 'tricks' games use (daily rewards).

Age 10–13

The **pressure years** – 'everyone has it!'. Check the age rating (PEGI/ESRB, app store) together. Delay social media; allow supervised group chats with real friends.

Age 14–16

More **freedom in exchange for responsibility**. Agree on sleep and safety; let them self-track their screen time weekly and discuss it without judgement.

 Activity: "Ready for social media?" checklist – tick together with your teen

- ☐ I know how to set my account to **private** and who can message me.
- ☐ I will only accept people I **know in real life**.
- ☐ I will not post my school name, address, phone number or live location.
- ☐ If something makes me feel bad, scared or pressured, I will **tell a parent**.
- ☐ My phone sleeps outside my room at night.

 If your teen says...

- **"Everyone in my class has it!"** – "I believe you. Let's list what you'd do on it, and what we'd need to feel it's safe." Check the facts quietly with other parents.
- **"You don't trust me!"** – "I trust you. I don't trust the strangers and the apps designed to keep you scrolling."
- **They made a secret account:** stay calm; focus on safety first ("Who can see it? Anyone bothering you?"), then revisit the agreement together.

 Tonight's 2-minute reflection

What did you learn about your child's online world today?

Which rule could you relax as a reward for responsibility?

 Today's Win

We had a real conversation about games and social media – and we both got a say. 🤝

DAY
17

WEEK 3

Safe Online

🔒 Privacy check-up + 'tell me without fear'.

🕒 40 min

📱 Every device



Day 17 comic: The Free Diamonds Trap



Sushma Ma'am says



The most powerful safety tool is not an app – it is a child who **comes to you** when something goes wrong. Children hide problems when they fear losing the phone or being scolded. Today we set up the privacy basics, and we make one promise that matters more than any setting: "You can tell me anything, and I will help – not punish."



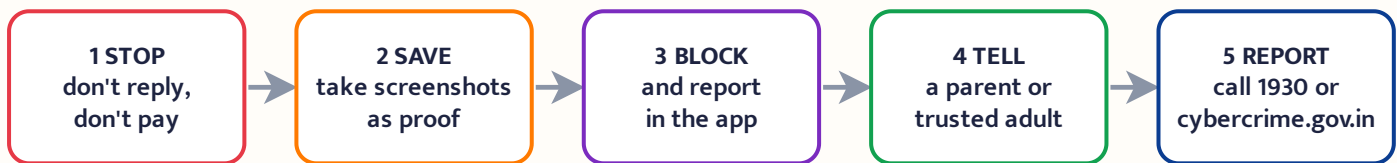
The 'tell me without fear' rule

Online dangers – scams, strangers who pretend to be children, bullying, pressure to share photos – rely on **secrecy and shame**. Predators and scammers often say "Don't tell your parents or you'll get in trouble." When your child knows for certain that telling you will bring help, not punishment, that threat loses its power.



Child Psychology Insight

- **Secure attachment = safe base.** Children explore more safely when they know a calm adult is there to return to. Your reaction the *first* time they tell you decides whether there will be a second time.
- **Shame silences.** A child who was tricked already feels foolish. Separate the child from the mistake: "You were tricked by an adult whose job is tricking people."



Teach this 5-step plan. Stick it near the charging station.

Danger	What it looks like	Family rule
Scams & OTP	"Free diamonds/skins", prize, KYC update, fake customer care, "send OTP"	Never share OTP, PIN, passwords – no bank or game ever asks. Ask a parent before any payment.
Strangers	Friendly gamer, lots of gifts/compliments, "let's chat privately", asks for photos or to meet	Chat only with people you know offline. Never meet an online friend without a parent.
Cyberbullying	Mean comments, left out of groups, embarrassing photos, fake profiles	Don't reply in anger. Screenshot, block, report, tell. Inform the school if classmates are involved.
Sharing photos	Selfies in school uniform, location tags, "just send one pic"	The Dadi test : would you be OK if Dadi, your principal and a stranger saw it? If not – don't post.



Parental controls CAN...

- filter adult content and set age ratings
- set daily limits and a 'bedtime' for the device
- require your approval for downloads and purchases
- e.g. Google Family Link, Apple Screen Time, YouTube Kids, in-game family settings



...but they CANNOT

- catch every stranger, scam or mean message
- work on a friend's phone or school device
- stay un-hacked – smart kids find workarounds
- replace **trust, talk and teaching** – they are training wheels, not the driver

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Make the promise out loud** tonight: "If anything online scares or confuses you, tell me. You will not lose your phone for telling me." And keep it.
- 2 **Do a 20-minute privacy check-up together** on each device and app (checklist below). Let the child press the buttons.
- 3 **Save the help numbers** in every family phone: 1930 (National Cyber Crime Helpline), 1098 (Childline), 112 (emergency).
- 4 **Turn on parental controls** that fit your child's age – and tell your child what they do (no secret spying).
- 5 **Practise one scenario**: "Someone in a game offers free coins for your OTP. What do you do?"

✓ Our privacy check-up (tick when done)

- ☐ Accounts set to **private**; only known friends can message
- ☐ **Location sharing off** in apps and camera (no geotags)
- ☐ Strong passwords, not shared with friends; **two-step verification** on
- ☐ Purchases and downloads need a parent's approval; UPI/cards not saved in games
- ☐ Profile has no school name, phone number or full date of birth
- ☐ Chat in games limited to friends (or off for under-10s)
- ☐ We parents also think before posting our children's photos publicly

💡 Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ How could you be so stupid?!	✓ These people are experts at tricking. I'm so glad you told me.
✗ That's it, no more phone for you!	✓ You're safe. Now let's block, report and change the password together.
✗ Why didn't you tell me earlier?	✓ It must have felt scary to keep that inside. You can always come to me first.
✗ Don't talk to strangers.	✓ Online, someone who says they're 12 might be 40. Who do you know in real life?



Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Use devices only **with you**, in child-safe apps. Teach one rule: "If something on the screen makes you feel yucky, call Mummy/Papa."

Age 10–13

Explain **scams, OTP and grooming** in simple words. Practise saying no. Know their usernames and friends list.

Age 6–9

Teach **private information** (full name, address, school, photos). Chat off in games. Play the "Safe or Unsafe?" game with examples.

Age 14–16

Discuss **sextortion, fake profiles and digital footprint** honestly. Promise help without blame. Teens often tell a sibling or cousin first – make that person an ally.



Act immediately if...

- someone is **threatening or blackmailing** your child (e.g. with photos), asking to meet, or money has been lost – don't pay; save proof; call **1930** or report at **cybercrime.gov.in**; for danger call **112**.
- your child seems **suddenly withdrawn, scared of the phone, or talks of hurting themselves** – stay close, contact the school and a child psychologist, or call Tele-MANAS **14416** / Childline **1098**.



Cut out & keep: our family help numbers

1930

National Cyber Crime Helpline – online fraud, blackmail, hacking

cybercrime.gov.in

Report any cybercrime online (there is a special section for crimes against women and children)

1098

Childline – any child in distress or danger

14416

Tele-MANAS – free mental-health support (also 1-800-891-4416)

112

Emergency – police, ambulance, immediate danger

Save these in every family phone. Report cyber fraud as fast as possible – quick reporting gives the best chance of stopping the money.



Tonight's 2-minute reflection

If your child told you about a mistake online tomorrow, what would your first sentence be?

Which privacy setting surprised you the most?



Today's Win

Our devices are safer, the help numbers are saved – and my child knows they can tell me anything.

DAY
18

WEEK 3

The Self-Control Muscle

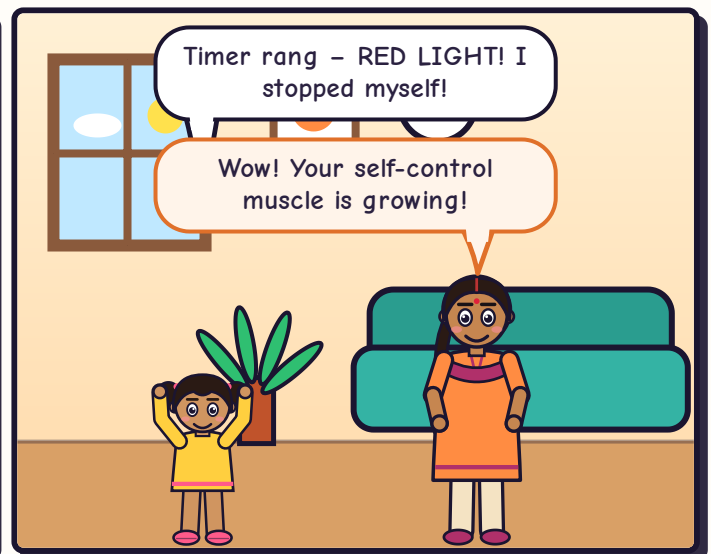
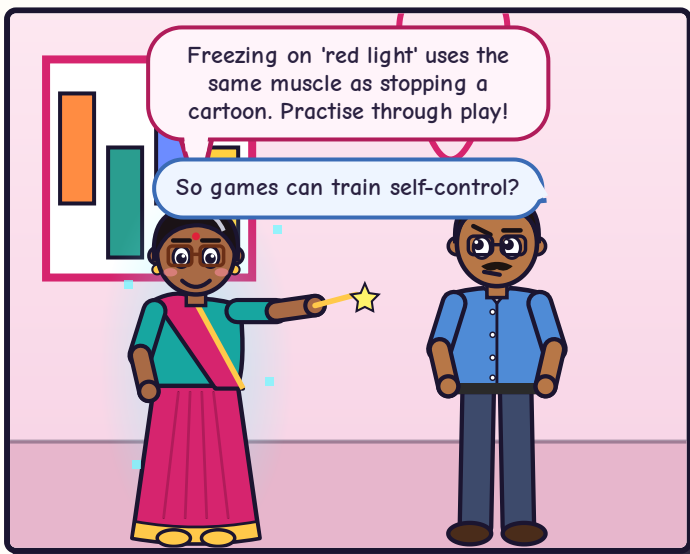
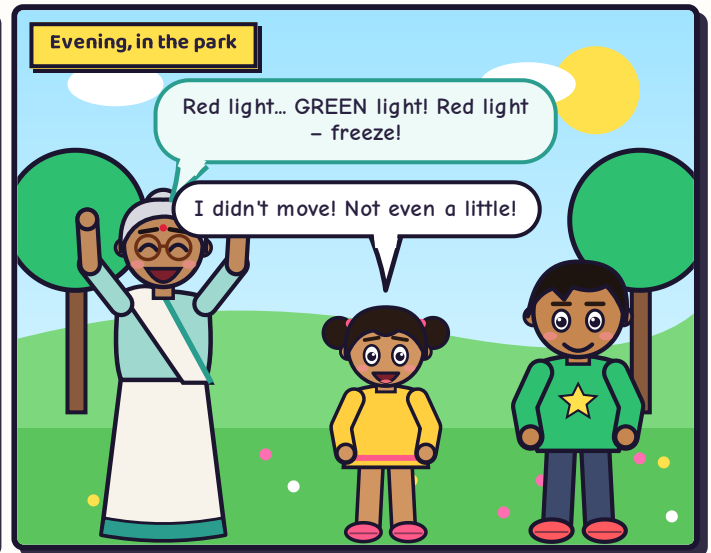
🎯 Train waiting and stopping through play.

🕒 30 min

🎮 Play-based



Day 18 comic: Red Light, Green Light



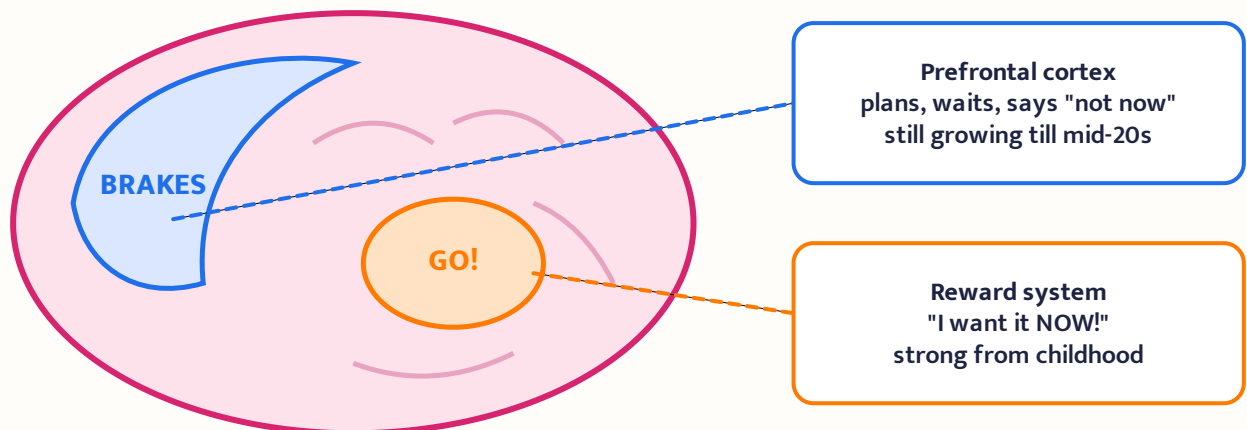
Sushma Ma'am says



Self-control is not something a child either *has* or *doesn't have*. It is like a muscle – it grows with practice, and it gets tired when overused. Today we stop expecting children to 'just stop' and start **training** that muscle in playful, everyday ways.



Why this works: accelerator and brakes



Every practice of waiting strengthens the brakes.

A child's 'want it now' system is strong early; the 'brakes' mature slowly – so they need our help and lots of practice.

Researchers call these abilities **executive functions**: holding information in mind (working memory), stopping an impulse (inhibitory control) and switching plans (flexibility). The Center on the Developing Child at Harvard University describes them as skills that are *built* through practice – through games, routines and supportive adults – rather than skills children are born with.



What Research Says

- In the famous '**marshmallow studies**' by psychologist Walter Mischel, young children were offered one treat now or two if they waited. Children who used **strategies** – looking away, singing, covering the treat – waited much longer. Waiting is a skill that can be taught.
- Later research showed that children wait longer when the adults around them are **reliable** – when promises are kept. So if you say "after homework you get 30 minutes", keep your word.
- **If-then plans** (psychologists call them *implementation intentions*) help people of all ages act on their goals, because the decision is made *before* the temptation arrives.

Self-control game	How to play	Muscle it trains
●● Red light, green light	Run on green, freeze on red. Switch: red = go!	Stopping on a signal
👤 Simon Says	Do the action only if "Simon says..." comes first.	Listening before acting
🗿 Statue / Freeze dance	Dance to music; when it stops, become a statue.	Body control, waiting
🧠 Opposite day	Touch your head when I say "toes", and toes for "head".	Beating the first impulse
♟️ Board games (Ludo, carrom, chess)	Taking turns, following rules, losing gracefully.	Patience, planning, emotions

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Play one self-control game** today (10 minutes is enough). Make it silly and fun – laughter helps learning.
- 2 **Use a visible timer** (sand timer, kitchen timer) for screen time. Seeing time run out helps the brain prepare to stop.
- 3 **Write 3 if-then plans together** for the hardest moments (see below). Stick them where the moment happens.
- 4 **Practise small waits** in daily life: "Let's wait 2 minutes before we open the sweets." Praise the waiting, not just the result.
- 5 **Plan the day together** in the morning: when is screen time, what comes before and after. A plan is external 'brakes'.

IF the timer rings during a game...



THEN I finish this round and save.

IF I feel bored after school...



THEN I pick a card from the boredom jar.

IF I want to check my phone while studying...



THEN I write it on a sticky note for break time.

Examples of if-then plans. Let your child write their own below.



Our family if-then plans

IF _____	THEN _____
IF _____	THEN _____
IF _____	THEN _____
IF _____	THEN _____

€ Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Why can't you control yourself?!	✓ Stopping is hard. Your brain is still learning – let's practise together.
✗ No! Wait!	✓ Yes, right after bath. Let's set the sand timer so you can see it.
✗ Good boy.	✓ You wanted to keep playing, and you still stopped. That took real strength!

**Age-wise Guide****Age 2–5**

Short, physical games: statue, Simon Says, waiting for "go!" before popping soap bubbles. Use **visual timers** and first-then boards ("First bath, then cartoon").

Age 6–9

Red light–green light, board games, simple **if-then plans with pictures**. Let them set the timer themselves.

Age 10–13

Strategy games (chess, carrom), saving money for something they want, **self-set goals** with a weekly check-in.

Age 14–16

Explain the brain science – teens love knowing *why*. Help them use app timers, 'focus modes' and their own if-then plans; you only check in.

**Common problems**

- **Meltdown when the timer rings:** it's a *tired* muscle, not a bad child. Stay calm, name the feeling, hold the limit, and avoid screen time late in the day when self-control is lowest.
- **Child 'cheats' in Simon Says:** laugh and replay. The goal is practice, not perfection.
- **You promised and forgot:** apologise and make it up. Reliability builds waiting power.

**Activity: 7-day brake-training tracker**

Day	Game we played	Stopped on the timer?	Specific praise I gave
Mon		☐ yes ☐ almost	
Tue		☐ yes ☐ almost	
Wed		☐ yes ☐ almost	
Thu		☐ yes ☐ almost	
Fri		☐ yes ☐ almost	
Sat		☐ yes ☐ almost	
Sun		☐ yes ☐ almost	

**Tonight's 2-minute reflection**

When did your child show self-control today – even a little?

Which if-then plan do *you* need for your own phone use?

**Today's Win**

We played a self-control game and wrote our if-then plans. The brakes are getting stronger! 🚦

DAY
19

WEEK 3

Study Time & Devices

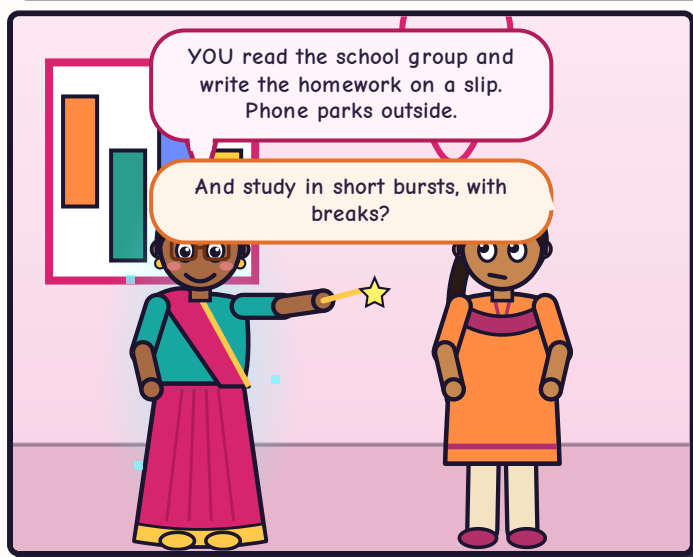
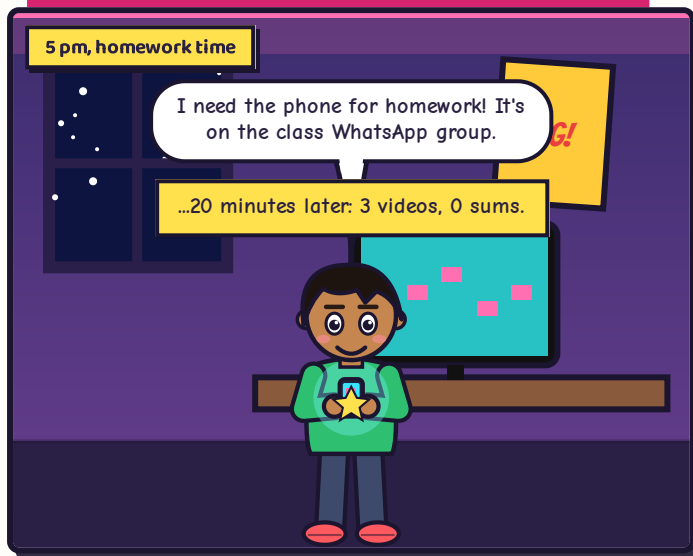
🎯 Homework without a phone on the desk.

🕒 30 min

📖 School days



Day 19 comic: The Homework Phone



Sushma Ma'am says



"I need the phone for homework" is the most common – and often most honest – reason children give. Schools do use WhatsApp groups and online resources. But a phone on the study table is like a plate of jalebis on a diet table. Today we separate **getting the information** from **doing the work**.



Why this works: attention is a spotlight

Attention can shine on one thing at a time. Every notification pulls the spotlight away, and it takes time to bring it back. Research on multitasking consistently shows that switching between tasks costs time and increases mistakes – for adults and even more for children, whose brakes are still developing. Short, focused blocks with planned breaks work *with* a child's attention span instead of against it.



Child Psychology Insight

- **Out of sight, out of mind** is real: a phone that is merely *visible* is a cue that invites checking. Distance beats willpower.
- **Small wins motivate.** Finishing a 20-minute 'tomato' gives a sense of competence, which fuels the next one.
- **Movement breaks** refresh attention better than screen breaks, which tend to stretch and make returning harder.

The Pomodoro method for kids 🍅

Example for a 10-year-old (about 1.5 hours of homework)



Phone parked OUTSIDE the room · one task per focus block · breaks away from screens

Younger children: 10–15 min blocks · Teens: 25–40 min blocks

'Pomodoro' is Italian for tomato – after the tomato-shaped kitchen timer. Adjust block length to your child's age.



Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Parents manage school WhatsApp groups.** Read the homework message and write it on a slip or whiteboard for your child. Children under 13 don't need to be in these groups themselves.
- 2 **Create a phone parking spot outside the study room.** Everyone's phone parks there during homework – including yours if you sit with them.
- 3 **Download or print what's needed first.** If a worksheet or video is needed, get it ready before the session, then use it on a larger screen in a common area.
- 4 **Try 3 'tomatoes' today** with a kitchen timer. Let your child choose what to do in the breaks (water, stretch, 10 jumps, pet the dog).
- 5 **Set online-class rules:** device in a common area, only the class tab open, notifications off, camera on if the school allows.

Distraction-free study zone	✓ Have	✗ Remove
Desk	Books, pencils, water bottle, timer, homework slip	Phone, tablet, toys, snacks packets
Room	Good light, quiet, someone nearby for help	TV on in the background, loud family chat
Computer (if needed)	Only the needed tab; parent-approved sites	Games, chat apps, autoplay videos

Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Give me that phone, you're just lying!	✓ I'll check the group and write down your homework. The phone can rest outside.
✗ Sit and study for two hours!	✓ Let's do one tomato – 20 minutes – then a break. You set the timer.
✗ You're so distracted, what's wrong with you?	✓ Phones are designed to pull attention. Let's make your desk a no-buzz zone.

Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

No homework on screens. Short 'learning play' sessions of **5–10 minutes** with you, then movement.

Age 6–9

10–15 minute focus blocks with you nearby. Homework slip written by parent from the school group. Reward: a sticker per tomato.

Age 10–13

20–25 minute blocks. Teach them to plan tasks on paper first. Shared family computer in a common area for online work.

Age 14–16

25–40 minute blocks they manage themselves. Help them use 'Do not disturb' / focus modes, and keep the phone in another room during exam prep.

Activity: Tomato tracker

Colour a tomato for each focus block done.

Day	Tomatoes	 parked?
Mon	   	☐
Tue	   	☐
Wed	   	☐
Thu	   	☐
Fri	   	☐
Sat	   	☐



Homework slip (parent fills from the school group)

Date: _____

Subject	Task	✓
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

Our after-school homework routine



Same order every school day – a predictable routine means fewer arguments.

When a teen really needs a device for study

- Use a **laptop or desktop in a common area** rather than the personal phone, with only the needed tabs open.
- Turn on **focus / Do Not Disturb mode** and mute chat apps for the session; agree on the task *before* starting ("find 3 facts for the project").
- Online test or class? Fine – the device goes back to the parking spot as soon as it ends.

If your child says...

- **"My teacher said we need the phone."** – Check with the teacher or other parents. Often a parent's phone or a family computer in the living room works just as well.
- **"I study better with music / YouTube in the background."** – For teens, allow instrumental music from a speaker (not the phone in hand). Videos with talking split attention.
- **"I need to ask a friend a doubt."** – Great! Note it down; call the friend at break time from the parking spot.

Tonight's 2-minute reflection

How much faster was homework with the phone parked outside?

Which school group messages can you take over this week?

Today's Win

Homework happened without the phone on the desk – and we found our tomato rhythm. 🍅

DAY
20

WEEK 3

Slip-Ups & Relapse-Proofing

🎯 Plan for slips; restart without guilt.

🕒 30 min

👤 Parents first



Day 20 comic: After the Holidays



Sushma Ma'am says

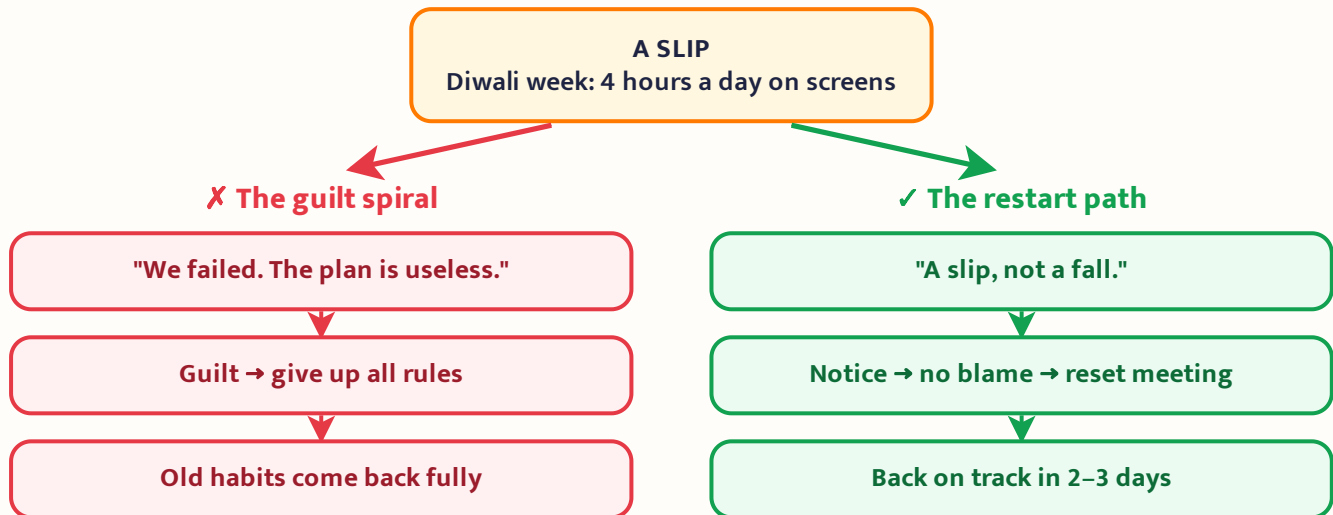


Every family slips. Holidays, a sick child, guests, a festival, a parent's work deadline – and suddenly the screens are back. This is **normal**, not failure. What matters is not whether you slip, but how quickly and how kindly you restart. Today we prepare for slips *before* they happen.



Why this works: escaping the "all-or-nothing" trap

Psychologists who study habit change have described a common trap: after one slip, people think "I've already broken the rule, so what's the point?" and give up completely (some researchers nickname it the "what-the-hell effect"). This all-or-nothing thinking turns a small slip into a full return of old habits. Planning ahead for high-risk situations, and treating a slip as information rather than failure, keeps the new habits alive.



Same slip, two different endings. Your reaction decides the path.



Child Psychology Insight

- **Children watch how we handle mistakes.** When a parent says "We slipped – let's start again", children learn resilience and self-compassion, not perfectionism.
- **Habits are tied to places and routines.** Travel and holidays remove the cues (charging station, bedtime routine) that held the habit – so bring a few cues with you.

Risky situation	Our plan in advance
 Holidays / vacations	Relax limits a little <i>on purpose</i> (e.g. 2 hours), but keep sleep and meal rules. Plan one outdoor thing daily.
 Long travel	Screens OK for part of the journey; pack cards, a colouring book, window games ("spot 5 red cars").
 Illness	Extra screen time is fine while sick. Prefer calm shows, audio stories. Say clearly: "When you are well, we go back to our plan."
 Festivals & weddings	Give children a role: decorating, rangoli, serving guests, photographer for 10 minutes.
 Guests & cousins	Tell visiting families your plan politely. Keep a box of board games, cricket bat, carrom ready.
 Busy weeks for parents	Ask Dadi/Nani or a neighbour for help; use audio stories instead of video; accept "good enough".

✓ Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Fill in the table above** for your family – which situations are coming up in the next 3 months?
- 2 **Agree on a 'holiday version'** of your family plan in advance – slightly relaxed, but with 2–3 fixed anchors (sleep, meals, one outdoor activity).
- 3 **Learn your warning signs** (checklist below) and put them on the fridge next to your agreement.
- 4 **Use the 3-step restart** after any slip: 1) Notice without blame. 2) Hold a 10-minute reset meeting. 3) Restart with just the *two most important rules* for 3 days, then add the rest.

🚦 Warning signs we are sliding back (2 or more ticks = time for a reset meeting)

- ☐ Phones are coming back to the dining table or bedrooms
- ☐ More arguments and meltdowns when screen time ends
- ☐ Bedtime is getting later; tired mornings
- ☐ "I'm bored" without screens – the boredom jar is untouched
- ☐ Homework or outdoor play is being skipped
- ☐ We parents are scrolling more too

🗣️ Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ We've ruined everything. What's the point?	✓ Holidays were fun! Now let's get back to our plan – starting tonight.
✗ You kids are hopeless without rules.	✓ We all slipped – me too. What helped us last time?
✗ From tomorrow, NO phone at all!	✓ Let's start with two rules for three days: phones sleep outside, no screens at meals.

😊 Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Routines slip fastest here. Bring back the **bedtime routine and the first-then board** first; toddlers readjust within days.

Age 6–9

Use a **"back to school" sticker chart** for the first week after a slip. Celebrate the first screen-free evening.

Age 10–13

Ask them to **lead the reset meeting**. They often suggest stricter rules than you would!

Age 14–16

Treat it like an adult conversation: "Holidays changed our routine. What do *you* want to get back to?" Offer support, not surveillance.

**Common traps**

- **Punishing the slip with a total ban** – this makes children resent the plan and hide screens.
- **Waiting for 'next Monday' to restart** – restart tonight, with something small.
- **Blaming each other** ("Your mother spoils them!") – slips are a family event, and so is the restart.

**Activity: our 'holiday version' of the plan (fill before the next break)**

On holidays / trips...	Our plan
Screen time per day	___ hours, in ___ blocks
Anchors we keep no matter what	☐ bedtime ___ pm ☐ no screens at meals ☐ phones sleep outside bedrooms
One daily outdoor / family activity	_____
Screen-free things we pack	☐ cards ☐ colouring book ☐ story book ☐ _____
Restart day after the holiday	Date _____ · reset meeting at ___ pm

**Tonight's 2-minute reflection**

Which situation in the next month is most likely to cause a slip?

What will you say to yourself when it happens?

**Today's Win**

We have a plan for holidays, travel and busy weeks – and we know how to restart without guilt.

DAY
21

WEEK 3

Celebrate & Look Ahead

🎯 Celebrate, then set a 30/60/90-day plan.

🕒 1 evening

👨‍👩‍👧‍👦 Whole family



Day 21 comic: Celebration Night



Sushma Ma'am says



You did it – 21 days! Maybe not perfectly (no family does), but you showed up, you talked, you played, you made rules together and you kept going after slips. Today we **celebrate**, because celebration tells the brain *this matters*. And we make a simple plan so these habits last long after this book is closed.



CERTIFICATE OF ACHIEVEMENT

21-Day Screen Champions



This is proudly presented to the family of

for completing the 21-Day Plan together – for talking, playing, making rules as a team,
and choosing each other over screens.

Date

Sushma Ma'am

Your guide

Family signature



Why celebrating matters

New habits are fragile at first. Research on habit formation suggests that simple daily behaviours become more automatic with repetition over weeks to months – it varies a lot from person to person, so 21 days is a *start*, not a finish line. Celebrating progress, noticing what each person did well and naming the family's new identity ("We are a family that eats without phones") helps the habits stick.



Child Psychology Insight

- **Identity drives behaviour.** When children see themselves as 'a family that plays together', they act that way without being told.
- **Specific praise builds competence:** "You stopped the game on time all week" teaches more than "good job".
- **Rewards should be experiences, not screens.** A picnic or special meal strengthens connection; 'extra gaming' as a prize makes screens look even more precious.

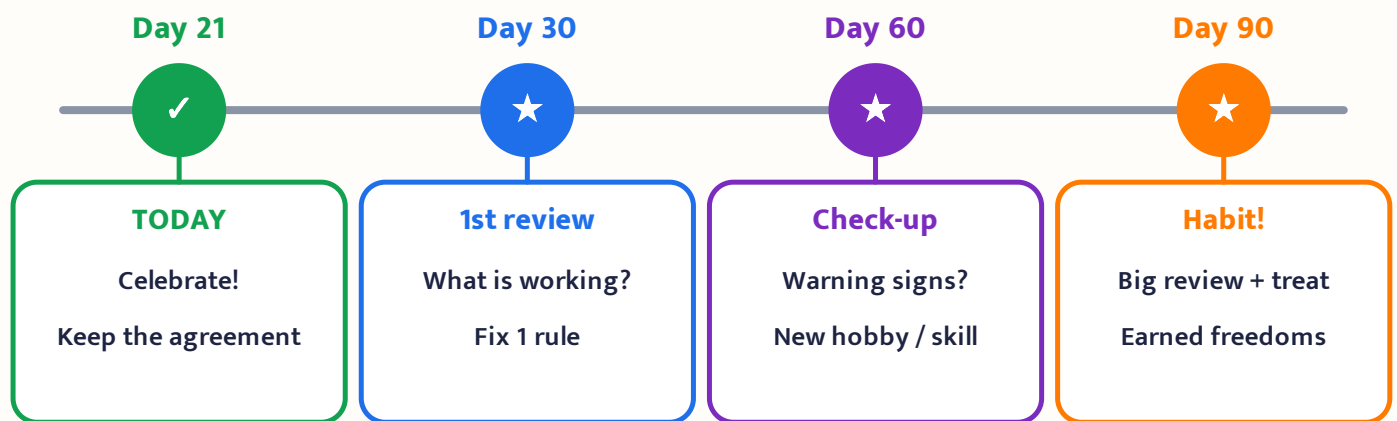


Today's Action Steps

- 1 **Hold a small family celebration** – a special meal, a picnic, Dadi's kheer, a family cricket match. No phones, except one for a family photo!
- 2 **Give awards to everyone**, parents too: 'Best Board-Game Champion', 'Bedtime Hero', 'Kindest Reminder'. Let the children make them.
- 3 **Fill in and sign the certificate** above, and put it next to your family agreement.
- 4 **Put the 30/60/90-day review dates** in your phone calendar now (yes – a good use of the phone!).
- 5 **Write a letter to your future family** (below) and seal it in an envelope to open on Day 90.



Your 30 / 60 / 90-day maintenance plan



Short, regular reviews keep the plan alive – and let you relax rules as children grow.

At each review, ask...	Day 30	Day 60	Day 90
Which rule is working best?			
Which rule needs changing?			
Any warning signs (Day 20)?			
What new thing did we enjoy together?			
Which freedom has a child earned?			

Age-wise Guide

Age 2–5

Celebrate with **stickers, a special outing and a big hug**. Keep routines exactly the same – toddlers love predictability.

Age 6–9

Let them **plan the celebration** and make award cards. Add one new screen-free hobby for the next 30 days.

Age 10–13

Review the agreement with them and **give one earned freedom** (e.g. choosing their own weekend screen slot).

Age 14–16

Ask for honest feedback: "What helped? What felt unfair?" Move towards **self-management** – they set goals, you support.

Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ Finally, the 21 days are over!	✓ We've built something good. Let's keep it going together.
✗ Now you can have the phone back.	✓ You've shown real responsibility – let's decide together what changes now.
✗ Good job, everyone.	✓ Aarav, you stopped on time. Riya, phone outside at night. Anaya, no cartoons at lunch. I'm proud!

 A letter to our future family (open on Day 90)

Dear us, three months from now... What did we learn? What do we promise each other?

With love, _____

 After Day 21, watch out for...

- **"We're cured, so no more rules."** – Keep the core rules (bedrooms, meals, bedtime). Relax the rest gradually.
- **New device, new rules needed** – a new phone, a birthday gift console or a new app is the time to revisit the agreement *before* it's handed over.
- **Still worried?** If screen use keeps harming sleep, studies, mood or relationships despite your efforts, see Part 3 and talk to a professional (e.g. NIMHANS SHUT Clinic, Tele-MANAS 14416).

 Tonight's 2-minute reflection

What is the biggest change you have seen in your family in 21 days?

What did *you* learn about yourself as a parent?

Which one habit will you protect no matter what?

 Our 21-day win

We are a family that talks, plays and chooses each other – screens are our tools, not our boss. Congratulations! 🎉

 Sources & Further reading

1. American Academy of Pediatrics – Family Media Plan: [healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan](https://www.healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan)
2. Indian Academy of Pediatrics – Screen time guidelines for children and adolescents (2021)
3. Center on the Developing Child, Harvard University – Executive function & self-regulation (developingchild.harvard.edu)
4. Walter Mischel – research on delay of gratification (the 'marshmallow test'); Kidd, Palmeri & Aslin (2013) – children wait longer when adults are reliable
5. Deci & Ryan – Self-Determination Theory (autonomy, competence, relatedness)
6. G. Alan Marlatt – relapse prevention and the 'abstinence violation effect' (the all-or-nothing trap after a slip)
7. Lally et al. (2009), University College London – how habits form in everyday life
8. Francesco Cirillo – the Pomodoro Technique
9. Peter Gollwitzer – implementation intentions (if-then planning)
10. Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (Government of India); platform terms of service for minimum ages
11. National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal: cybercrime.gov.in · Helpline 1930 · Childline 1098 · Tele-MANAS 14416

PART 3

Special Situations & Help

Toddlers, teens, working parents, red flags, FAQs, resources and your certificate.



CHAPTER

7

PART 3 · SPECIAL SITUATIONS & HELP

Toddlers & the 'Phone While Eating' Habit

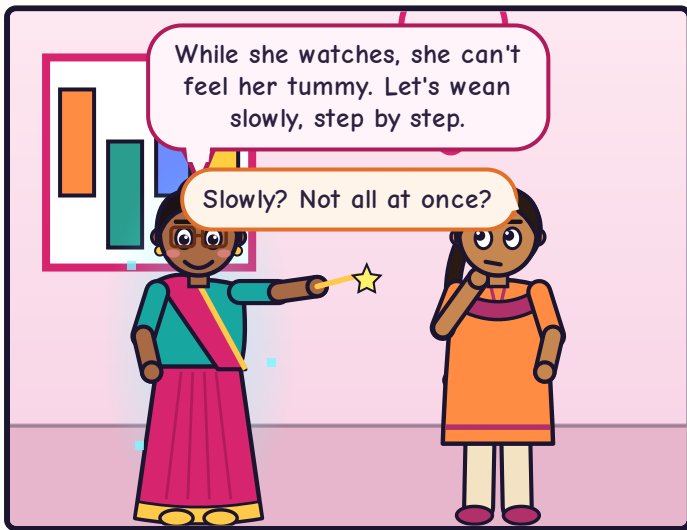
🛡️ Protect the under-5 brain and wean off mealtime screens gently.

👶 Ages 0–5

🍽️ Mealtimes



💬 Comic: The Moon Roti



💬 Sushma Ma'am says



"She only eats with cartoons" is one of the most common things I hear from Indian parents. You started it with love – to get food into a fussy child. Now we will gently undo it, **one small step at a time**, without fights at the table.



Why the under-5 years need special care

The first five years are when a child's brain builds language, attention and self-control fastest. It grows through **back-and-forth**: the child babbles, you answer; she points, you name the thing. Psychologists call this "serve and return". A screen can show colours and songs, but it cannot notice your child and respond to her – so every hour on a screen is usually an hour of lost talking, playing and moving.



What Research Says

- **WHO (2019)**: under 1 year – no screen time; at 1 year – sedentary screen time is not recommended; 2–4 years – no more than 1 hour a day, and less is better. Reading and storytelling with a caregiver are encouraged instead.
- **Indian Academy of Pediatrics (2021)**: no screens under 2 years except video calls with family; 2–5 years – at most 1 hour a day, supervised, good-quality content; **no screens during meals** and in the hour before bed.

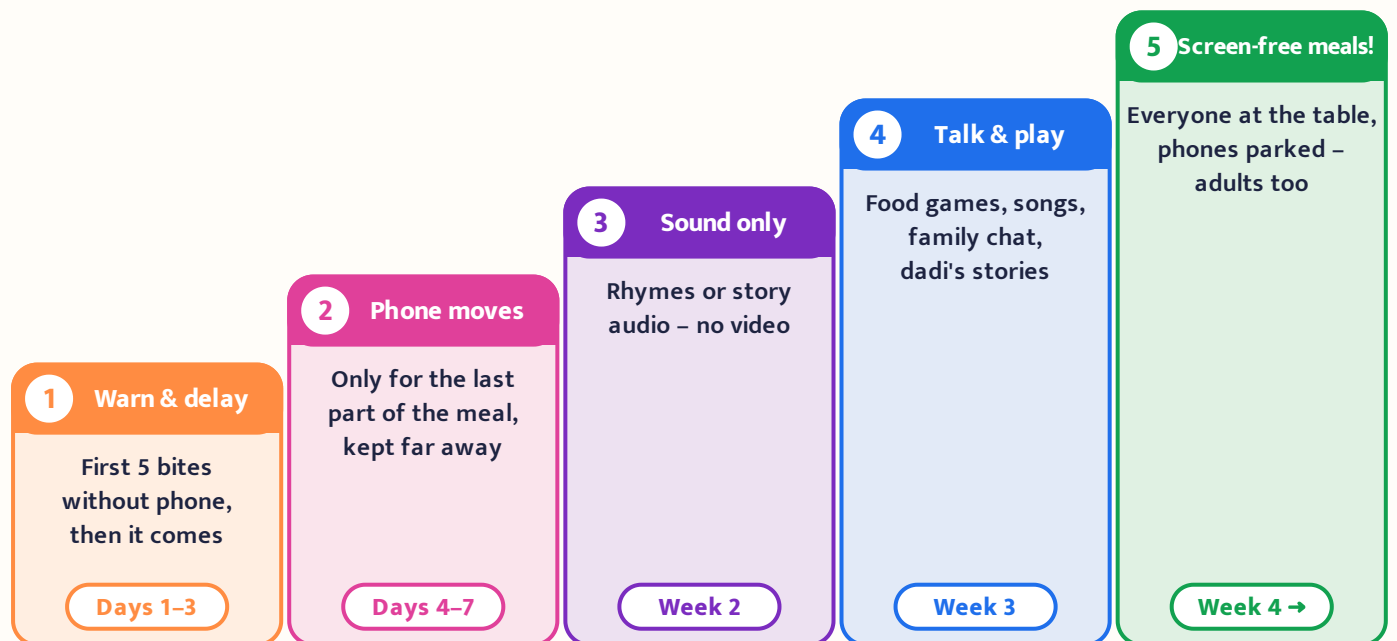


Why "phone while eating" becomes a trap

- **Hunger signals get switched off.** A child glued to a cartoon does not notice when she is full or still hungry, so eating becomes something done *to* her, not *by* her.
- **Conditioning:** after many meals, the brain links "food" with "screen". Soon the child believes she *cannot* eat without it – that is a learned habit, not a personality.
- **Lost learning:** mealtime is a natural lesson in words, colours, tastes, textures and table manners – and a daily dose of family talk.



Weaning off the mealtime screen – the 5-step ladder



Climb one step at a time. Stay on a step longer if your child needs it – the pace is a guide, not a rule.

✓ How to climb the ladder

- 1 **Tell her before, not during.** "From today, the first five bites are for you and me, then the cartoon comes." Children cope better with changes they are warned about.
- 2 **Serve small portions of food she likes** on the first days. Hunger is your friend – no snacks or milk in the hour before a meal.
- 3 **Let her feed herself**, even if it is messy. Self-feeding keeps her attention on the plate and builds pride.
- 4 **Replace, don't just remove:** colour games ("find something green"), counting peas, a funny food story, a song between bites.
- 5 **End the meal calmly after 20–30 minutes**, even if she ate little. No force-feeding, no bribes – she will eat better at the next meal.
- 6 **Eat together and park your own phone.** Toddlers copy faces, not instructions.

Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "Eat quickly, otherwise no cartoon!"	✓ "Cartoon comes after five bites. Let's count them together – one..."
✗ "If you don't eat, I'll call the police uncle!"	✓ "Is your tummy full or does it want two more bites?"
✗ "You are so stubborn!"	✓ "You miss the cartoon. It's hard. I'm here – shall we make a moon roti?"

Speech & development – when to check with a doctor

- Not saying a few words by around 18 months, or not joining two words by 2 years.
- Not responding to name, rarely pointing or making eye contact, or **losing words or skills** she had before.
- Screens are not the cause of every delay – but cutting screen time and **talking, reading and playing more** helps every child. See your paediatrician early; early help works best.

Sushma Ma'am's summary

- Under 2: no screens (video calls with family are fine). 2–5: at most 1 hour, never during meals or before bed.
- Wean slowly – five steps, warm voice, no force-feeding.
- Talk, sing and read at the table – that is your toddler's best "app".

Sources & further reading

1. World Health Organization (2019). Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5 years of age.
2. Indian Academy of Pediatrics (2021). Screen-time guidance for infants, children and adolescents.
3. American Academy of Pediatrics – HealthyChildren.org: media and young children; developmental milestones.

CHAPTER

8

PART 3 · SPECIAL SITUATIONS & HELP

Working Parents, Single Parents & Joint Families

 Get every caregiver following the same few rules.


All caregivers



Caregiver card



Sushma Ma'am says

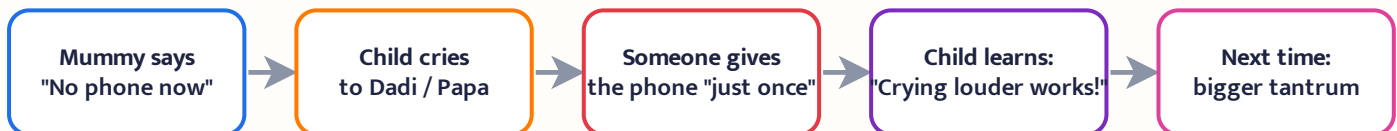


No family runs like a textbook. Mummy may work late, Papa may travel, Dadi may be the one at home all day, or you may be raising your child alone. The goal is not perfection – it is that **every adult around your child follows the same few rules.**



Why consistency matters more than strictness

When one adult says "no" and another says "okay, just once", the child quickly learns that the rule can be broken with enough crying. Every time the tantrum "works", it becomes stronger.



The "just once" loop – mixed messages make tantrums bigger, not smaller.



Child Psychology Insight

This is **intermittent reinforcement**: behaviour that is rewarded only *sometimes* becomes the hardest to stop – the same principle that keeps adults pulling slot machines or refreshing feeds. A calm, predictable "no" from everyone, every time, is kinder in the long run because the child stops fighting a battle she cannot win.



Tips for your family type



Working parents

- First 15 minutes home = **phone-free "hello time"** – hug, snack, hear about the day.
- Park your own phone at the door.
- Decide screen rules on Sunday for the week; don't negotiate daily.
- Guilt makes us say yes to screens – replace guilt with 20 minutes of full attention.



Single parents

- Let **routines and timers** do the reminding, so you are not the "bad guy" all day.
- Keep rules few and simple.
- Ask one trusted adult to be your back-up.
- Be kind to yourself: a tired parent who uses a screen sometimes is still a good parent.



Joint Families

- Hold a short **family meeting** – include grandparents, chachu, bua.
- Agree on 3 rules everyone keeps.
- Give Dadi-Nani a starring role: stories, games, cooking.
- Disagree privately, never in front of the child.



Grandparents – your best allies

Grandparents often give the phone out of love ("let the child enjoy") or because they are tired and their knees hurt. Criticism makes them defensive. **Respect first, then request** – and give them something better to offer than a phone: their stories, their childhood games, their recipes.



Say This, Not That

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "Mummy-ji, you are spoiling him with the phone!"	✓ "Mummy-ji, he listens to you more than anyone. The doctor said no phone at meals – will you help us? He loves your stories."
✗ "Why did you give her the phone AGAIN?"	✓ "Thank you for looking after her all day. Can we try the Caregiver Card together this week?"
✗ To your partner, in front of the kids: "You never follow the rules!"	✓ Later, privately: "I need your help. Can we agree on just three rules and both stick to them?"



Caregiver Instruction Card

For grandparents, didi/maid, crèche, tuition teacher or relatives. Fill it, cut it, stick it on the fridge.

Child's name & age

Screen time allowed today: ____ minutes, only after

Allowed shows / apps / games

Meal times & what to serve

Nap / bed time

Never

- ☐ No screens during meals
- ☐ No screens in bed or 1 hour before sleep
- ☐ No new apps, games or videos without asking me
- ☐ No phone "to stop crying"

If my child cries for the phone

1. Stay calm, get down to eye level, give a hug.
2. Say: "Phone time is over. Let's _____ instead."
3. Offer a favourite activity (below). Do not give in.

Favourite non-screen activities

Call me if... · My number

Thank you for loving our child and keeping our family rules! ❤️



Weekdays vs. weekends

It is fine for weekends to be a little different – children understand "weekend rules" as long as they are **predictable**. Decide them in advance so Saturday does not become an all-day screen marathon.

	School days (example, age 6–10)	Weekend (example)
Fun screen time	30–45 min after homework & play	Up to 1.5–2 hrs, in 2 chunks
Family activity	Dinner together, 15-min story	Outing, park, cooking, relatives
Special	—	Family movie night (together, on the TV)
Same every day	No screens at meals, in bedrooms, 1 hr before bed	Same!



When someone else feeds your toddler

Many working parents leave toddlers with a didi/maid, a crèche or the grandparents. The phone is the easiest tool for a tired caregiver – so give them **better tools and clear permission**.



Give a "meal kit", not a phone

A basket near the dining area: a picture book, a small toy, finger puppets, a spoon to bang. Show the caregiver how you use them.



Say thank you, then be clear

"You take such good care of her. Doctor has said no phone while eating – if she cries, it's okay. Just sing with her." Permission to let her cry a little helps.



Our Family Agreement – 3 rules every adult keeps

Fill this in at a 15-minute family meeting. Keep the rules short, clear and doable – e.g. "No phone at meals", "All phones charge in the hall at 9 pm".

1

2

3

If the child cries or argues, we will all say:

If we disagree, we will talk about it (when/where):

Mummy

Papa

Dadi / Nani

Dada / Nana

Didi / other



What Research Says

The **American Academy of Pediatrics** encourages every family to make a **Family Media Plan** together and to apply limits **consistently**, while the **Indian Academy of Pediatrics (2021)** reminds parents and caregivers that children copy adults – so screen-free meals and bedtimes should apply to grown-ups too.



Sushma Ma'am's summary

- Few rules, same from every adult, every time.
- Win grandparents with respect and a role, not with arguments.
- Write it down: the Caregiver Card turns your rules into everyone's rules.

CHAPTER

9

PART 3 · SPECIAL SITUATIONS & HELP

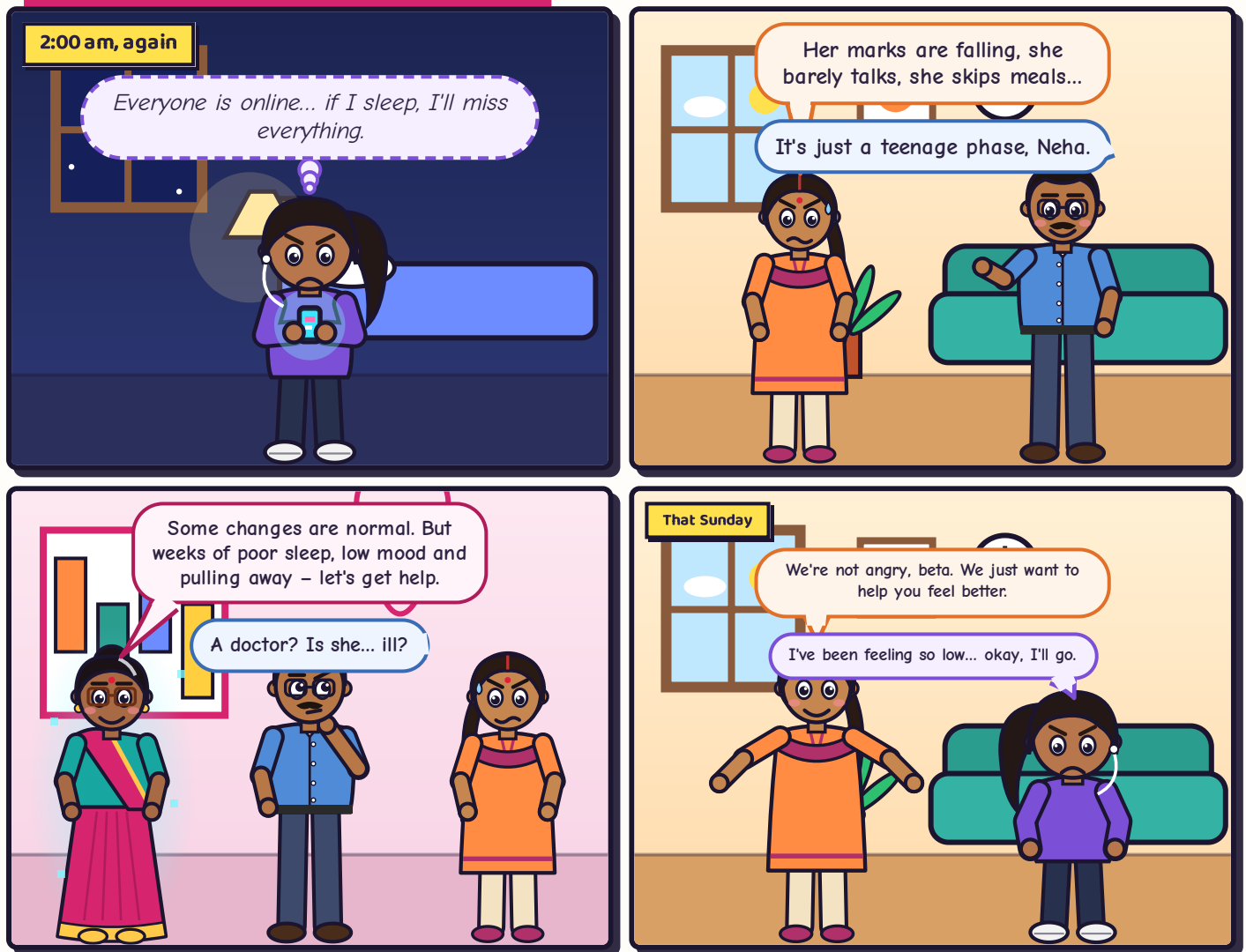
When to Seek Professional Help

📍 Know the red flags, who to see, and where to call.

🚩 Red flags

☎ Helplines

💬 Comic: Asking for Help Is Strength



💬 Sushma Ma'am says



Most children who love screens are **not** "addicted" – they need limits, connection and time. But some children are struggling underneath: with low mood, anxiety, attention or learning difficulties, bullying, or online harm. Asking for professional help early is **not failure** – it is **good parenting**.



What Research Says

The WHO's **ICD-11** lists "gaming disorder" as a health condition: **impaired control** over gaming, gaming taking **priority** over other interests and daily activities, and **continuing despite harm** – usually seen for at least 12 months and causing significant problems in family, school or social life. Loving games, or playing a lot on holidays, is not the same thing. A professional decides this, not a checklist.



Red-Flag checklist – tick what you have seen for 2 weeks or more

- ☐ Sleep is badly disturbed for weeks – up late on the phone, exhausted in the morning.
- ☐ School is suffering: falling marks, skipping classes or refusing to go.
- ☐ Has lost interest in friends, sport, hobbies and family time.
- ☐ Intense rage, hitting or breaking things when the device is limited.
- ☐ Lies, steals money or uses others' cards for games or apps.
- ☐ Seems sad, anxious, hopeless or very irritable most days.
- ☐ Big changes in eating, weight or personal hygiene.
- ☐ Secretive online life with an unknown "friend", or signs of bullying.
- ☐ You have tried a calm, consistent plan for several weeks and nothing is changing.



Get help TODAY – do not wait

- Your child talks about wanting to die, self-harm, or you find signs of it → call **112** in an emergency, or **Tele-MANAS 14416**, and see a doctor the same day.
- Online blackmail ("sextortion"), threats or a stranger asking to meet → stay calm, **don't delete chats**, call **1930** / [cybercrime.gov.in](https://www.cybercrime.gov.in). Tell your child: "You are not in trouble. We will handle this together."



Who does what?

Professional	What they do	Go when...
Paediatrician	Checks overall health, growth, eyes, sleep and development; rules out physical causes; refers you on.	Your first stop for most worries, especially under-5s.
Child psychologist	Assessment and talk-based therapy (e.g. CBT), behaviour plans, parent training. Does not prescribe medicine.	Habits, anger, anxiety, low mood, family conflict over screens.
Child & adolescent psychiatrist	A medical doctor who diagnoses conditions like ADHD, depression or anxiety and can advise on all treatment options, including medicine if needed.	Severe or persistent symptoms, self-harm, or when others refer you.
School counsellor / special educator	Support at school, learning plans, liaison with teachers.	Problems show up mainly at school.

Children with ADHD, autism or anxiety

Screens can affect these children differently, and the general advice in this book may need to be adjusted with a professional. Please **don't suddenly remove all devices** without a plan – for some children the screen is also a way of coping.

ADHD

Fast games give constant rewards, so stopping can be extra hard. Visual timers, short sessions, lots of movement and **very predictable transitions** help.

Autism

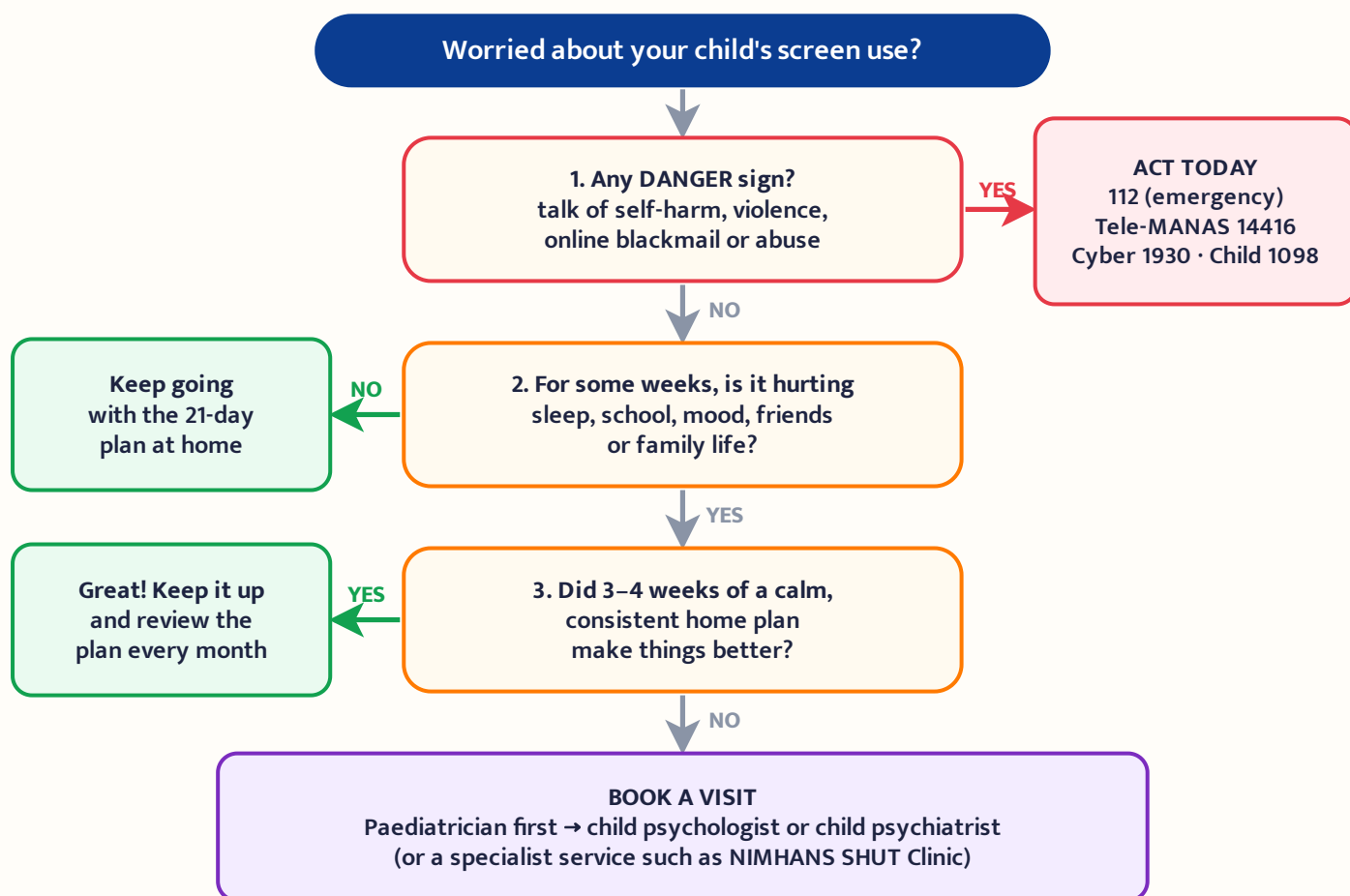
Screens may calm or feed a special interest; changes feel stressful. Use picture schedules, advance warnings and a therapist's plan.

Anxiety

Screens can become an escape from worry, or a place to keep checking. Treat the worry, not just the screen.



A simple decision flowchart



Start at the top. When in doubt, it is always okay to ask your paediatrician.

📌 Helplines in India – save these in your phone today



Tele-MANAS

14416 • 1-800-891-4416

Free, 24×7 mental-health helpline by the Govt. of India. Talk in your language – for parents or teens.



NIMHANS SHUT Clinic

Bengaluru

Service for Healthy Use of Technology – a specialist clinic for problematic use of internet, gaming and phones.



Childline

1098

For any child in danger, abuse or distress – free, 24×7.



Cyber Crime Helpline

1930

Online blackmail, fraud, harassment, morphed photos. Report also at cybercrime.gov.in



Emergency

112

Immediate danger to life or safety. Do not wait.

Our paediatrician

School counsellor

✓ Preparing for the first visit

- 1 Bring your **screen diary** (Day 1) – hours, apps, times, and what happens when you set limits.
- 2 Note sleep, eating, mood and school changes, with rough dates.
- 3 Tell your child honestly: "We are meeting someone who helps families feel better – you are not in trouble."
- 4 Ask: "What can we do at home? When should we come back? What signs should worry us?"



Talking to your child about getting help

Instead of...	Try saying...
✗ "You're addicted. We're taking you to a doctor."	✓ "You've seemed tired and low lately. We love you, and we'd like someone to help us all feel better."
✗ "If you don't behave, I'll send you to a psychiatrist."	✓ "Seeing a counsellor is like seeing a doctor for a fever – it's normal, and it helps."
✗ "Hand over your phone – I'm reading everything."	✓ "If someone online is scaring you, you are NOT in trouble. Tell me, and we'll handle it together."



Sources & further reading

1. World Health Organization. ICD-11: 6C51 Gaming disorder.
2. NIMHANS, Bengaluru – SHUT Clinic (Service for Healthy Use of Technology).
3. Tele-MANAS, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India – 14416 / 1-800-891-4416.
4. National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal – cybercrime.gov.in, helpline 1930; CHILDLINE 1098; Emergency 112.

CHAPTER

10

PART 3 · SPECIAL SITUATIONS & HELP

Parents' Questions Answered

 Clear answers to the questions parents ask most.

 14 questions


Sushma Ma'am says



These are the questions parents ask me most often – in workshops, on WhatsApp, and at the school gate. If your question is not here, the answer usually lies in three words: **connection, consistency, and modelling.**

Q1 School gives homework on a tablet. How do I limit screens then?

Separate **school screen** from **fun screen**. Homework happens at the dining table or in the living room, not the bedroom; when it is done, the device goes back to the charging spot. School time does not count as "fun time" – but it also does not unlock extra games. If the load feels too heavy, talk to the class teacher politely; many schools welcome this feedback.

Q2 "All my friends have phones!" – what do I say?

First empathise: "It feels unfair to be the only one." Then share your reason calmly: "In our family, we decide by readiness, not by what others do." Offer a path: a family device, a basic phone for calls, or a clear readiness goal. Quietly talk to other parents – often "all" means "three", and many will be happy to agree on shared rules.

Q3 What is the right age for a first smartphone?

There is no magic birthday – **readiness matters more than age**. Is your child already following screen rules at home? Sleeping well? Telling you when something online upsets them? Can they keep passwords private? Start small: a basic phone for calls, then a smartphone with limits, apps approved by you and no phone in the bedroom at night. Later is usually easier than earlier.

Q4 Is YouTube Kids safe?

It is **safer** than regular YouTube, but no filter is perfect and autoplay is designed to keep children watching. In the parent settings, choose the right age level or "approved content only", turn off search, and set the built-in timer. Best of all, watch together for young children and keep it in a shared room.

Q5 My teenager watches reels for hours. Should I ban them?

A sudden ban usually leads to secret use. Instead, **explain the design** (infinite scroll, unpredictable rewards – see Part 1) and make her a partner: agree on reel-free times (study, meals, the last hour before sleep), use the phone's own screen-time tools **together**, and fill evenings with things she enjoys. And yes – put your own reels away too.

Q6 My son spent money on a game without asking!

Stay calm – many games are built to make spending feel easy. Then: turn on **purchase approval** (Google Family Link or Apple "Ask to Buy"), remove saved cards and UPI from his device, and never share your PIN. Explain that loot boxes and "gems" are designed like a lucky draw. You can request a refund from the app store. If he wants to spend, agree on a fixed amount from his pocket money.

Q7 Is it okay to use the phone as a reward or punishment?

Try not to. When the phone is the biggest prize, it becomes even more precious in your child's mind. Reward with **time together** – a game with Papa, choosing Sunday's breakfast. Use consequences that are **related, calm and announced in advance**: "If the phone stays in the room past bedtime, it charges in our room for the next two nights." Taking it away for unrelated things ("you fought with your sister") often starts a power struggle.

Q8 My spouse doesn't support the rules. What now?

Talk privately, never in front of the children. Start from the shared goal: "We both want him to sleep well and do well." Agree on just **two or three non-negotiables**, and let each adult work on their own screen habits. Ask them to read Part 1 – understanding the brain science often changes minds more than arguments do.

Q9 My child screams and throws things when I take the phone.

Keep everyone safe first, and stay calm – your calm is contagious. Prevent the next one: give a 5-minute warning, use a timer so "the timer" ends it, and let the child switch off the device themselves. Afterwards, when calm, name the feeling: "It was hard to stop." If outbursts are frequent or violent, see Chapter 9.

Q10 Educational apps are good screen time, right?

Quality matters – creating, learning and video-calling are better than endless scrolling. But for young children, it still counts towards the daily limit, and many "educational" apps use the same reward tricks as games. The best learning for under-5s is still a real person, a real book and real play.

Q11 Should I secretly check my teen's phone?

For young children, parental controls are sensible – just be open about them. For teens, secret spying usually destroys trust and pushes problems underground. Agree openly: "I won't read your chats, but I will check apps and settings with you once a month." If you have a real safety concern (a stranger, blackmail, self-harm), safety comes first – act and get help.

Q12 Online classes and tuition hurt my child's eyes. What helps?

Use the biggest screen you have (laptop or TV rather than a phone), keep it at arm's length, and follow the **20-20-20 rule**: every 20 minutes, look at something 20 feet away for 20 seconds. Get daily outdoor time – more time outdoors (around 2 hours a day) is linked with a lower risk of short-sightedness. Get eyes checked if your child squints or complains of headaches.

Q13 Are video calls with grandparents okay for my 1-year-old?

Yes. Both the IAP and AAP make an exception for video-chatting with family, because it is a real, two-way conversation. Hold your baby on your lap, and help them wave, smile and respond.

Q14 We finished 21 days but slipped back during the holidays. Did we fail?

Not at all – slipping back is a normal part of changing any habit. Notice what triggered it (travel, exams, a new game), hold a 10-minute family meeting, and restart from Week 3. The second time is always faster, because your family already knows the way.

 Sources & further reading

1. Indian Academy of Pediatrics (2021) screen-time guidance; American Academy of Pediatrics – HealthyChildren.org Family Media Plan.
2. YouTube Kids parental settings; Google Family Link; Apple Screen Time & Ask to Buy – official help pages.

CHAPTER

11

PART 3 · SPECIAL SITUATIONS & HELP

Bonus: 100 Screen-Free Activities by Age

 Never run out of ideas again. Ages 2–16 Cut-out slips**Sushma Ma'am says**

Cut these lists into slips for your **boredom jar**, or tick one idea every day. Children are not bored for long when a caring adult says, "Let's try this together!" Rotate ideas weekly and let the child choose between two – choice builds willingness.

Ages 2–5 · 25 ideas**1** Sing rhymes with actions**2** Stack blocks or steel glasses**3** Sort rajma, chana and moong (supervised)**4** Water painting on the floor**5** Play with atta dough**6** Bubble chasing**7** Animal walk: walk like a duck, jump like a frog**8** Picture-book "reading"**9** Puppet show with socks**10** Help wash vegetables**11** Treasure hunt for 5 red things**12** Pouring and filling with cups**13** Chalk drawing on the floor or wall slate**14** Dance freeze**15** Cushion obstacle course**16** Name the sounds game (eyes closed)**17** Sticker book**18** Feed the birds on the balcony**19** Toy tea party**20** Clay or play-dough animals**21** Peek-a-boo and hide-and-seek**22** Colour sorting with clothes pegs**23** Bath-time boats**24** Look at family photo albums**25** Garden walk: touch leaves, smell flowers

Ages 6–9 · 25 ideas

26 Carrom or ludo tournament

27 Paper boats and planes

28 Hopscotch (stapu)

29 Kitchen helper: make a salad or sandwich

30 Grow a plant from a seed

31 Comic strip drawing

32 Cycling in the colony

33 Build a fort with bedsheets

34 Simple science: floating and sinking

35 Rangoli with chalk or flowers

36 Story dice: make up a story

37 Skipping rope challenge

38 Puzzle / jigsaw

39 Letter to a grandparent

40 Pretend shop with toy money

41 Origami animals

42 Nature scavenger hunt

43 Clay modelling

44 Board games: snakes & ladders

45 Learn a new yoga pose each day

46 Shadow puppets with a torch

47 Collect and press leaves

48 Family quiz night

49 Music with steel plates and spoons

50 Read a chapter book aloud together

Ages 10–13 · 25 ideas

51 Chess or Scrabble

52 Cook a simple dish alone (with safety rules)

53 Cricket, football or badminton

54 Start a diary or journal

55 Learn a musical instrument

56 Science kit or DIY circuit

57 Sketching and shading

58 Plan a family outing budget

59 Stargazing from the terrace

60 Read a novel series

61 Teach a younger sibling something

62 Sudoku and logic puzzles

63 Gardening project: balcony herbs

64 Write and act a short play

65 Learn to repair small things

66 Martial arts or dance class

67 Make a family recipe book

68 Volunteer: help a neighbour

69 Kite making and flying

70 Build with cardboard (marble run)

71 Learn basic first aid

72 Swimming or cycling longer routes

73 Collect stamps or coins

74 Write to a pen-pal

75 Board-game design: invent your own

Ages 14–16 · 25 ideas

76 Join a sports team or morning run club

77 Learn a skill: typing, calligraphy, sewing

78 Cook a full family meal

79 Read biographies of role models

80 Photography walk with a basic camera

81 Community service or NGO volunteering

82 Debate or public-speaking practice

83 Gym or home workout plan

84 Learn an instrument or singing seriously

85 Tutor a younger child

86 Plan and budget a family trip

87 Journal: gratitude and goals

88 Trek or nature camp

89 Art: painting, pottery, mandala

90 Learn a new language from books

91 Start a small project: plant nursery, bake sale

92 Chess club or quiz club

93 Weekend cooking challenge with friends

94 Yoga and meditation, 15 minutes

95 Write poems, stories or a blog draft in a notebook

96 Help with home finances: bills, groceries

97 Build a model or robotics kit

98 Heritage walk in your city

99 Board games night with friends

100 Long talk-walk with a parent

CHAPTER

12

PART 3 · SPECIAL SITUATIONS & HELP

Your Toolkit

 Print, fill, stick on the fridge – and celebrate!


Printables



Certificate



Our Family Media Plan

Fill it together at a family meeting · stick it on the fridge · review every month

The _____
Family

Name	School days (fun screen)	Weekends	Allowed apps / games / shows

 Screen-free zones

- ☐ Dining table
- ☐ Bedrooms
- ☐ Car / auto rides (short trips)
- ☐ Puja room / prayer time
- ☐ _____

 Screen-free times

- ☐ All meals
- ☐ 1 hour before bed
- ☐ First hour after waking
- ☐ Homework (unless needed)
- ☐ Family time: _____

 Night-time parking spot

All devices charge at:

from (time): _____

 When we're bored, we will...

 We grown-ups promise to...

- ☐ Park our phones at meals & bedtime
- ☐ Put the phone down when a child talks to us
- ☐ Not scroll in front of the kids "just to relax"

 Online safety

- ☐ Ask before new apps / games
- ☐ No sharing address, school, photos
- ☐ Tell a grown-up if anything feels wrong

 If a rule is broken...

Signed by everyone:

Date:

Review on:

Inspired by the AAP Family Media Plan ([healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan](https://www.healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan)) and IAP 2021 screen-time guidance.



POSTER FOR KIDS · STICK ME ON THE WALL!

Our Screen-Smart Rules



Screens are fun – and so are WE!



1 No screens at meals

We talk, laugh and eat together.



2 Phones sleep outside bedrooms

Our brains need a good night's sleep.



3 Timer rings = I stop

I say "OK!" and switch off by myself.



4 Play outside every day

Run, jump, cycle, climb – sunshine for eyes!



5 20-20-20 for my eyes

Every 20 min, look 20 feet away for 20 seconds.



6 Ask before new apps

New games and videos – grown-up says OK first.



7 Keep secrets safe

Never share passwords, photos or our address.



8 Tell a grown-up

If something online feels bad, tell us. You won't be in trouble!

I promise to follow our rules! ✍️ _____



CERTIFICATE OF COMPLETION

21-Day Screen-Smart Family

This certificate is proudly presented to

The _____ Family

for completing **21 days** of connection, play and healthy screen habits together – and for choosing **people before phones**.



Our favourite new family activity: _____

The habit we are most proud of: _____

Our next family goal: _____



Sushma

Sushma Ma'am

Child Specialist Educator & Child Psychology Expert

Date

**A last word from Sushma Ma'am**

Congratulations – you did it! Remember, the goal was never zero screens. It was a family where **screens are tools and people come first**. Keep the plan on the fridge, keep talking, and when things slip (they will), simply begin again. I am so proud of you.

**Keep it going – your monthly check-in**

- ☐ Once a month: a 10-minute family meeting – what is working, what needs changing?
- ☐ Update the Family Media Plan at every birthday, new school year or new device.
- ☐ Before exams and holidays, agree on the "special season" rules in advance.
- ☐ Keep one screen-free family ritual every day – a meal, a walk, a story.
- ☐ Keep checking your own phone habits – children copy what we do.
- ☐ If slips turn into red flags (Chapter 9), reach out early for help.

**Sources & references for this book**

1. World Health Organization (2019). *Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5 years of age*. Geneva: WHO.
2. Indian Academy of Pediatrics (2021). Screen-time and digital-wellness guidance for infants, children and adolescents.
3. American Academy of Pediatrics – HealthyChildren.org: **Family Media Plan** ([healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan](https://www.healthychildren.org/MediaUsePlan)).
4. American Academy of Pediatrics (2016). Policy statements "Media and Young Minds" and "Media Use in School-Aged Children and Adolescents".
5. World Health Organization. **ICD-11**, International Classification of Diseases – 6C51 Gaming disorder.
6. National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro-Sciences (NIMHANS), Bengaluru – **SHUT Clinic** (Service for Healthy Use of Technology).
7. **Tele-MANAS** – National Tele Mental Health Programme, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India: 14416 / 1-800-891-4416.
8. National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) and helpline 1930; CHILDLINE 1098; Emergency Response Support System 112.
9. Eye health: the 20-20-20 rule (American Academy of Ophthalmology advice for screen use) and research linking more daily outdoor time with a lower risk of myopia in children.

Screens are tools. You are the parent.

Firm, warm and consistent parenting beats any app. Keep the family media plan on the fridge, keep talking, and keep playing together.

More from Sushma Ma'am & VS Sir

- LEVEL UP AI: Defeat the Glitch King – comic for kids 8–14
- NEET Physics: 30-Day Rapid Revision
- Practical Guide to AI for Educators

All books: vcakota20-web.github.io/ai-mastery-with-vs-sir/books/

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